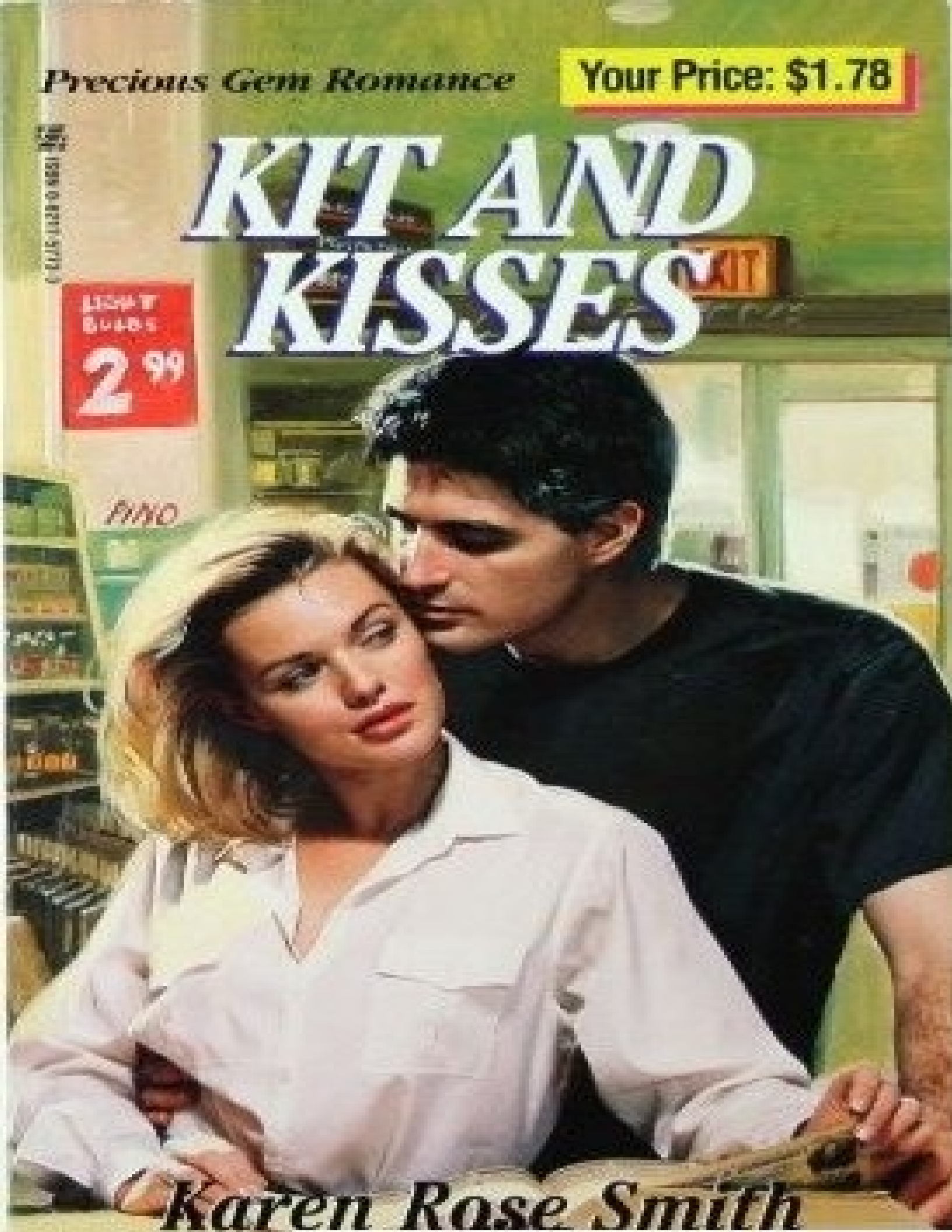
Precious Gem Romance

Your Price: $1.78

KIT AND KISSES



Karen Rose Smith

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BUSINESS OR PLEASURE?

Public relations whiz, Kit Saunders, was looking forward to a challenge—if not exactly the kind of challenge posed by Greyson Corey, the small-town Pennsylvania entrepreneur who hired her to spruce up his image. One look at the drop-dead gorgeous client and Kit concluded that his image was already perfect.

Never before had Greyson taken such a personal interest in public relations as he did when he met Kit. Unfortunately, he was a man who honored his own vow: never mix business with pleasure. Until Kit made it clear that taking care of business was a pleasure, and love could be the most satisfying enterprise of their careers.

CHAPTER ONE

Kit Saunders was a woman on a mission.

The object of her reconnaissance crouched in front of the shelves in the hardware store's painting supplies section, clipboard in hand. After studying him for a few moments, Kit decided he matched the description her brother-in-law had given her.

Even in his present position, she could tell Greyson Corey, owner of Corey's Hardware, was tall, and at least six-two. Under the fluorescent lights, strands of silver shone in his thick black hair. The green T-shirt emblazoned with the store's logo emphasized his broad shoulders, his muscular biceps. His jeans stretched tight over his thighs and buttocks. Nice, she drawled to herself before she remembered she wasn't interested in men any more.

Even so, she kept looking. In profile, the ruggedness of his jaw counteracted the classic line of his nose. In essence, he was one great-looking man. But that didn't matter. She'd fallen for good looks once before. It wouldn't happen again. This man was a potential client and she didn't have time to waste a July afternoon admiring the view.

Even though it was a very nice view. She crossed to him, her cotton flared skirt brushing his clipboard.

He cocked his head and studied her, from her chin-length, blond hair, down her western-style, fringed turquoise blouse and matching skirt, to her tooled leather sandals. "Can I help you?"

His slow, steady perusal made her feel warm and tingly in the air conditioned store. Despite that, she replied with a smile. "No, but I think I can help you."

His green eyes took another sweep. This time Kit felt her cheeks get hot as he rose to his feet, towering a good six inches above her. "Let me get this straight. You're in my store, but you think you can help me."

She extended her hand. "I'm Kit Saunders, public relations consultant. Eric McConnell is my brother-in-law. He said you might be interested in my services and suggested I should stop in some time."

He took her hand in his and shook it with a relaxed grip, the press of his fingers making a surprisingly hot imprint on hers. "I see. Eric mentioned you, but I don't know if I can afford a public relations consultant. My store's in trouble as is. Red Bucket Corporation is taking advantage of that and pressuring me to sell out."

His honesty surprised her. The touch of his rougher skin against hers made her thoughts jumble. Mere chemistry had never done that before. Pulling her hand away quickly, she asked, "Is that what you want?"

When he studied her again, the male interest in his eyes awakened sensations in Kit she thought died three years ago. "Life doesn't always let us have what we want," he said quietly.

The sadness in his voice touched her. "Eric told me that your dad passed away. I'm sorry."

A flicker of pain crossed Greyson Corey's face. Too soon, his expression was set again, and Kit realized he was still coming to terms with his grief. "Thank you." He glanced around the store. "He's the reason I don't want to sell. The store's been in the family for three generations. It meant history and good service to Dad. I don't want to give it up without a fight."

"That's why I'm here," she said softly, suddenly more interested in helping him than in making money from his account for Sunrise Public Relations.

Eric had told her Grey Corey's father had been sick for a year before he passed away, ten months ago. It was one of the reasons the store was having financial difficulties. Grey had devoted his attention to caring for his father. Kit considered it rare for a man to do that.

The nerve in Grey's jaw worked. "You're not what I expected."

She shook her head, wanting to make him smile. "Uh oh. Has Eric been telling stories again? About my three noses?"

Grey chuckled and seemed to relax. "No. But he did use the term 'expert.' I guess I expected someone in a suit with a briefcase."

She shrugged. "I've been known to wear suits. What about you?"

With a straight face, he said, "I've been known to wear them, too, though not often."

They both laughed and then their eyes met. A silence fell over them that had nothing to do with making conversation or public relations. It was man-woman awareness and the unexpected strength of it made Kit shiver.

Grey had a difficult time keeping his gaze away from Kit's swingy hairdo, her blue eyes, her beautiful smile. Her perfume, something exotic, teased more than his nose. When she smiled at him, he felt... He might as well be honest. Aroused was the word. Her skirt floated around her, hinting at her curves. The blouse molded softly to her breasts. The outfit wasn't in any way revealing. That was the problem. It let his imagination wander.

He guessed it was about time. He hadn't held a woman in two long years. Not since...Susan. They'd dated for six months. He'd thought they had a future. Until one night when he'd come home from visiting his dad in the hospital, the night Susan told him she couldn't accept Deedee. She certainly didn't want his sister living with them. She particularly didn't like the idea that if anything happened to his dad, Grey would have full responsibility for Deedee, for both her physical and financial well being.

That's when Grey had looked into group homes. But he'd realized he could never love a woman who didn't accept and learn to love his sister. That's simply the way it was. So he and Susan had gone their separate ways, even though a month later he'd found a home for Deedee that would give her more independence than he ever could. The arrangement had worked out better than he'd ever hoped.

The problem was—Susan wasn't the exception, she was the rule. How often while growing up had he defended Deedee, protected her, tried to insulate her against all those who couldn't accept her? He had dated other women who'd looked down on Deedee, who didn't know how to act around her, simply because she was different.

How would Kit Saunders react?

Why in blazes was he even asking? She was here on business.

Business. Yeah, right. That's why every time she spoke he wondered what her lips would feel like under his. Get a grip, Corey. You've been working way too hard. "Would you like to go to my office? I can show you my advertising schedule."

"Actually, I'd rather look around the store if you don't mind."

That smile. He wanted to taste her as well as kiss her. "No, I don't mind. I'll be in the office in the back when you're through."

Kit knew she had to get away from Grey's potent masculinity if she was to make an objective evaluation of his store and the type of campaign he'd need to turn it around. But even as she walked away, she knew she'd feel his presence no matter where in the store she went.

She made a slow tour, trying to forget about Greyson Corey by concentrating on strategies that could bring in business by bringing in more customers. Maple Grove was a mid-size town in south-central Pennsylvania that should generate more than enough business for a store like Corey's Hardware. But nearby Meadeville with its many shopping centers and malls was probably drawing business away. After fifteen minutes of making mental notes, Kit stood in the doorway to Grey Corey's office.

He looked up from his desk. "What's the verdict?"

Her fingers went to the necklace she wore, a Native American design with small birds of different colors. "How open are you to change, Mr. Corey?"

"Grey," he corrected her, then frowned. "I'm about as traditional as Dad was. I want to keep the store service-oriented and customer-minded."

"If it was customer-minded, you'd have more customers."

"Now, wait a minute..." he began defensively.

"From what Eric says, you have more of a problem than just putting this quarter in the black. Is he right?"

Grey rubbed his hand over his chin and met her gaze directly. "Yes."

From his expression and tone of voice when he spoke about it, it was obvious how much the store meant to him, how much he wanted to save it. He cared about his father's legacy.

Stepping into the office, she took a quick look around, then sat on the corner of his desk. "My guess is, along with the state of retail these days, you're losing business to the full service chain stores that have opened in Meadeville in the past few years. I won't know for sure until I make some inquiries and scout around."

He straightened his shoulders. "And your time will cost."

His unflinching stare didn't make her squirm. "Yes, it will. But I'm willing to invest my time if I can win an account for my company. I'm willing to work up some ideas and a cost analysis. Does that sound fair?"

He looked surprised for a moment before his eyes narrowed. "How many times do you do that and not get the account?"

She smiled. "I'm not going to give away trade secrets. But I can tell you I'm known for winning more accounts than I lose."

He chuckled. "Eric said you were good. He just didn't say how good."

Her cheeks got a little hotter. After a pause she said, "There is something you could help me with."

His brows arched.

"I'd like to buy a ladder."

When he stood and came around the front of the desk, he was close enough for her to smell male and hard work. It wasn't unpleasant. On his feet, he seemed to take up the whole office. His shoulders and chest alone could block the doorway. With him standing before her, she felt small, feminine, and very hot. She blew out a breath.

"What size?" he asked.

She figured a tall man's forty-four. It took her a moment to realize he was talking about the ladder, not a suit jacket. Hopping off the desk to equalize her position, she looked up at him. "I need to reach the ceiling comfortably. Actually, I could use it even higher than that so I can clean my porch spouting."

"You do that sort of thing yourself?"

"Is this chauvinism I hear?"

He looked chagrined. "Sorry. I told you I came from a traditional background."

"There's nothing wrong with tradition, Grey," she heard herself say, surprised because she usually had more fun breaking tradition than following it.

"So you believe in fireworks on the Fourth of July, eating turkey at Thanksgiving, and hanging mistletoe at Christmas?"

The thought of standing underneath the small white berries with him created a fluttering in her stomach. "I haven't been able to find mistletoe the last few years."

"That's a shame," he responded, his voice tinged with a husky rasp, that made her wonder if his mind was creating the same picture hers was.

She could have sworn she swayed toward him slightly; she could have sworn his head lowered a fraction. But then something clattered to the floor in the store, breaking the connection that had suddenly swept her toward thoughts of intimacy. She shook her head. Not a good sign. Since her debacle with Trent Higgins, hadn't she sworn never to trust a man again? And she couldn't think about intimacy with a man without trusting him.

Clearing her throat, she asked, "So what size do you think I need?"

He studied her for a moment, then said, "Probably six feet. C'mon. I'll show you."

He waited for her to precede him out the doorway. Her arm brushed his chest, and she swallowed hard. What about this man made her knees wobble?

Choosing a ladder didn't take long. Grey carried it outside for her. When she directed him to her car, he shook his head. "You have a problem. Even with the trunk tied down, you'll lose it."

"I should have brought Eric and Maggie's van," she mumbled. "If they're home, I can—"

"We deliver. That's part of our customer service."

She shaded her eyes against the sun. "But I live in Meadeville, not here in Maple Grove."

He shrugged, the action tightening the shirt across his chest, making her more aware of the few curling black hairs peeking from the crew neck. "Ten, fifteen minutes. It's not a problem. I'll consider it a favor to Eric for sending you over."

"I don't think you're sure it's a favor. Yet." Neither was she. Yet.

"I care about keeping the store, Kit."

She liked the way her name sounded when he said it, and she couldn't keep from reaching out and touching his arm. "I know you do."

When his gaze met hers, she was aware of the hair on his forearm under her fingertips, the breeze shifting her skirt around her knees, but mostly the heat in his eyes. Greyson Corey was dangerous to her peace of mind. She knew enough about herself to know that.

Removing her hand, she took a few steps toward her car. "How soon can you deliver the ladder?"

"We close the store on Saturdays at five. I can do it then if you'll be home."

"I'll be there. I'm at 643 Marshall. Do you know where that is?"

He nodded.

If she stood there any longer she'd make some excuse to go back into the store and talk with him more. She needed to go home, change, and get to work. See her empty living room. Remember how Trent had betrayed her. Then she wouldn't care who delivered her ladder.

She waved as she climbed into her car, but she didn't look at Greyson Corey again.

***

Pulling up in front of the address Kit Saunders had given him, Grey couldn't understand the sense of lightness and excitement that he felt at the thought of seeing her again, talking with her again. He'd actually caught himself whistling this afternoon. Did the thought of an attractive woman stir that many hormones?

Nah. He was simply glad it was Saturday, with a day off tomorrow that he could spend with Deedee. And maybe he was finally getting over the loss of his father. He still couldn't throw off the grip of grief that snuck up and unexpectedly grabbed him sometimes. They'd been close. After Grey's mother died, they'd raised Deedee together. Grey had spent his spare time in Corey's Hardware since as far back as he could remember. After he'd earned his accounting degree, his dad had made him an official partner. At thirty, what Grey wanted most in life was to turn the store around financially so it could prosper long into the future.

Maybe Kit Saunders could help him do that.

He climbed out of the truck and took the ladder from the bed in the back. Giant elms that looked centuries old lined the street. Bright red and white impatiens overflowing the garden's boundaries edged

the flower bed that eased along the wrap-around porch. The rambling house reminiscent of bygone days looked as if it had worn many coats of paint, but the shiny cream coating gleamed in the late afternoon sun. An old-fashioned house didn't seem to fit Kit, but then what did he know?

The concrete steps led to the wooden porch. The solid wood door stood open letting the warm breeze float through the screen. But something also floated out. Grey could hear a high lilting voice singing along to a popular song with a great deal of feeling. He held the ladder waist high and listened.

It was pure, sweet melody that reached down inside and grabbed a part of him that was alone and cold. The surprise of it made him suck in a breath. Damn! It was just a woman singing. He rapped sharply on the door.

Kit kept singing.

He rapped again, then knowing it was useless, he opened the door and stepped inside. Her living room was practically bare. As she sang along to a portable tape player positioned in the bay window, she precariously perched on a step stool, tearing flowered wallpaper from the upper half of the room.

He called, "Kit?"

She glanced over her shoulder, almost losing her balance. He hurried to catch her, but she jumped down and landed on both feet. "My gosh, I didn't know it was so late." Crossing to the CD player, she flicked it off.

The surroundings faded away as Grey again felt captivated by the woman. Her cut-off denims were deep blue, ragged at the edges, hugging her as they couldn't possibly hug anyone else. She'd tied her flamingo-pink, short-sleeved blouse at the waist and as she moved, creamy skin peeked out above her waistband. Her hair hung silky and sleek along her cheeks. Not a trace of makeup. She didn't need it. Not with those blue, blue eyes and soft pink lips.

His heart galloped and he gripped the ladder tighter.

She crossed to him, gingerly guiding her battered sneakers over the plastic covering on the hardwood floor, avoiding strips of torn wallpaper. Motioning to the stepstool, she smiled. "As you can see, I need the ladder before I break my neck."

"You should have waited," he said, his voice surprisingly gruff.

She lifted her chin. "For what? I want to get this stripped so I can get to work."

Holding the ladder in one hand, he moved the stepstool to a corner. "A remodeled room won't do you much good if you break your neck."

Her silence met him as he opened the ladder, placing it where the stepstool once stood. Terse words shortly followed. "No one tells me how to live my life, Mr. Corey."

When he faced her, her blue eyes were defiant, her stance defensive. "Not even if it's for your own good?"

Her hands waved through the air and she picked up strips of paper and stuffed them into a waste can standing near the archway. "I've heard that one before, and it doesn't cut it. My good is rarely someone else's concern."

"Are you saying no one cares about you?"

"Of course not. Eric and Maggie do. Maggie and I are closer than any sisters could be. What I'm saying is I mistrust people's motives when they're concerned about my good."

As she passed him, he caught her arm. "What motive do you think I have?"

He stared into her blue eyes, watching annoyance leave and confusion take its place as she answered, "I don't know."

He touched a strand of loose hair along her cheek and felt her tremble. "I wouldn't want to see you get hurt. It's as simple as that." Knowing he was standing too close, restraining himself from touching more than her hair, he took a step back and nodded to the CD player. "You have a great voice."

She looked a little dazed. He felt somewhat off balance himself. After a moment, she said, "Thank

you."

"Do you sing professionally?"

She laughed. "No way. As close as I get is Karaoke Night at The Music Box. Ever been there?"

He recognized the name of a club he often heard mentioned in the store. "I've been there once or twice. But not for that."

"I was practicing for tonight. Eric and Maggie are going to stop by. You could come and give me moral support." Then, as if the invitation had been given before she had time to think better of it, she asked, "Do you have a delivery slip for me to sign?"

He took the slip from his pocket and handed it to her. Their fingers brushed and Grey caught the flicker of awareness in her eyes right before she turned and headed for the kitchen, murmuring, "I'll get a pen."

He followed her to the large kitchen. A gigantic spider plant hung above the sink. Bright yellow walls seemed to bathe the room in sunshine. A rattan table for two set with colorful placemats sat next to the refrigerator. A cream-colored loveseat faced a small television housed on stacked orange creates. Magazines lay scattered on the floor beside the loveseat.

Movement caught Grey's eye. In front of the open door lay two cats, a gray tabby and a black and white long-hair. The tabby lay flat on his back, his four paws swaying in the air. The long-hair stretched his paws before him, blinked at Grey, and thumped his tail.

Grey smiled. "Have you lived here a while?"

"I rented it after I finished college. When Maggie finished, she moved in with me. Then a few years ago, she decided she'd trade apartment living to invest in a house.

"She and Eric haven't been married long, have they?"

"It'll soon be a year."

Grey glanced again at the living room. "The landlord doesn't mind you remodeling?"

Kit fished in a drawer, shuffling aside papers and a ruler. "Not if I pay for it. I've wanted to do it for a while, but..." She shrugged.

Kit didn't seem like the type to put off what she wanted. He wondered why he didn't see any living room furniture except the loveseat and television. "Are you going to leave the wainscoting on the bottom half?"

"No. What do you think would be the best way to get it off?"

"A crowbar. Do you have one?"

"No. But I'm sure Eric does. He lets me borrow whatever I need."

"He's a nice guy," Grey agreed.

"Maggie was lucky," Kit responded.

Her tone was almost wistful. Certainly a woman like Kit could date any man she wanted.

Finding a pen, she unfolded the slip and pressed it flat on the counter. The phone rang. "The machine will get it," she said as she signed her name.

After the first ring, Kit's lilting message played. Then a woman's voice came over the line. "Ms. Saunders, you don't know me. A friend of mine told me I should contact you, even after all this time because it might give me some peace of mind. I've wanted to tell you how much I admire what you did, how you went after Trent Higgins so he got what he deserved. The sentence he got isn't long enough for all the women he's hurt, but I guess it will have to do."

She paused then hesitantly continued. "I was one of them, too, but I was afraid to do what you did. I was afraid to come forward. The trial. The publicity. Everything. I didn't want everyone knowing how stupid I'd been. He took the money I'd saved for my daughter's college education." She stopped for a moment. "I'm sorry I didn't come forward when you pressed charges. But I'd really appreciate it if we could have lunch or something some time, though I'll understand if you'd rather not." The woman gave her

name and number and hung up.

The silence in the kitchen was thicker than a pea-soup fog. Kit's head stayed bent over the delivery slip. Grey knew he had no right to ask, but he wanted to know more about this woman who intrigued him. "What was that all about?"

"It's over," Kit said in such a low voice that Grey took a few steps closer. She looked pale as she raised her head.

"Kit?"

His voice brought her gaze to his. "I'm sorry. What?"

"Are you all right?"

Her back straightened and her shoulders squared. "I'm fine. Just fine."

"You were involved in something sticky?"

She leaned against the counter and crossed her arms. "You don't read the local papers?"

He gave an off-handed lift of his hand. "I haven't had much time for that."

She sighed. "Simply put, I got taken. I thought I was in love but it turns out I was in love with an image." She nodded to the living room. "I haven't had decent furniture in there for three years. I had to sell almost everything to pay the debts he ran up. I'm finally getting back on my feet financially."

"How did it happen?"

"Do you mean how could I have been so stupid?" Her voice was pained.

"No. You're an intelligent woman. How did he get to you?"

"It doesn't matter. What matters is that I caught on to him before we got married."

Grey stuffed his hands in his pockets, not pleased with the picture of her with another man. "You were engaged?"

She raised her chin combatively. "Do you think I'd let just anyone tamper with my savings and credit cards?"

"No," he said softly. "That's why I asked how he got to you. And I think it does matter."

Her arms tightened around her as she studied him. "I don't know you, Grey."

At least they were back to a first name basis. "Sometimes it's easier to talk to a stranger. Apparently the whole thing still bothers you or her phone call wouldn't have affected you."

"Playing therapist?"

"No. Just providing a listening ear."

She shook her head. "I've talked about this to Maggie until I'm blue and so is she. I've got to get over it, not whine about it."

"Whining about it is one thing. Talking about it to find out why it happened and why it still affects you is entirely another."

Frowning, Kit rubbed her fingers across her arms. "I know why it happened."

"Why?"

Turning away from him, she stared out the window. After a long pause, she answered, "Our family history. We had a father who drank and a mother who was afraid to leave him. She taught us to be compliant. But Maggie learned it better than I did."

"You were rebellious?"

Kit gave a mirthless laugh. "I saw Dad for what he was—a bully. I stopped trying to please him long before he died. But because of him, I guess, Trent Higgins duped me. For years, I'd looked for the perfect man, one who was kind, considerate, generous, and sociable—all qualities our father had lacked. But Trent's perfection was all a sham. I guess I was just hungry for the affection and attention he offered and couldn't see beyond it."

"It could happen to anyone."

"No. It could only happen to someone who was as gullible as I was."

"Or needing to be loved."

She faced Grey then, her blue eyes sad. "Yes, only I discovered love does strange things. He was a con man, but I didn't realize that until it was almost too late. My feelings blinded me. That will never happen again."

"Sworn off relationships?" He needed to know, not stopping to analyze why.

"I'm just very cautious about who I date. I ask for their life history. I accepted Trent's background without question. I should have known something was fishy when he said he didn't have any family."

That sadness in her eyes and the sense of disappointment in her voice moved Grey to say, "He hurt you badly, didn't he?"

Kit's eyes glistened and she again turned away.

Anger that Grey didn't understand surged through him and he wished he could get his hands on the man who had done this to her. He put his hand on her shoulder and nudged her around. "Everyone makes mistakes." Her gaze met his, and he was overwhelmed by the desire to take her in his arms and hold her until the past hurt went away.

Taking a deep breath, she forced a smile. "Yes, and I guess I just have to accept that. My pride was hurt most of all. But bringing charges against him helped. And when his two previous wives came out of the woodwork and he was charged with bigamy, too, the little devil inside me jumped for joy. Isn't that terrible?"

"No. That's justice." Grey nodded toward the answering machine. "Are you going to meet her?"

"Probably. So she knows she's not alone."

"You're a brave lady."

She laughed uncomfortably. "I don't think so. Somebody had to stop him. I did it first, that's all."

Grey still had his hand on her shoulder. She was close enough to hold, to kiss, looking up at him, waiting as he was. A bee buzzed outside the window. Leaves swished against each other as the breeze brushed through them. Desire had never seemed so strong.

All he had to do was bend his head...

CHAPTER TWO

Before his lips touched hers, Kit's eyelids fluttered and her hands came to rest on Grey's chest. Her touch made him realize this was no fantasy, it was real. And just as Kit had learned her lesson, he'd learned his, too. Letting go of her, he stepped back.

She blinked, then her cheeks got rosy. But her blue eyes became opaque, shutting away her emotions. Turning to the counter, she picked up the delivery slip and handed it to him. Their fingers didn't brush this time, maybe because they both realized they'd flirted with temptation.

Without mentioning what had almost happened, Kit led the way to the living room saying, "Thanks for delivering the ladder."

At her front door, facing her and thinking where a kiss with Kit might have taken them, he said, "Service is one aspect of the store I don't want to change."

"I'll try to remember that. I'll call you when I get a plan worked up."

He nodded. There seemed to be something unfinished between them, something they should verbalize. But Kit's expression said she wouldn't, and he didn't want to make them both uncomfortable since they might be working together. Better to let well enough alone. Better not to discuss what had almost happened in the kitchen. Better not to start dreaming again. Better to take the safe route instead of the risky one.

***

The Music Box was decorated in black and white and hopping with activity. Sheets of black paneling alternated with white on the club's walls while the shimmering silver curtain on stage pulled customers' interest to it. A young man, well, a man younger than Grey, sang into a microphone along with the music, not always synchronized to the melody. Some of his notes weren't on tone, either, as he watched the monitor before him displaying the words to the song. But he was smiling, having fun and, when he looked up during the instrumental bridge, his friends waved at him, giving him a thumbs-up sign.

Grey scanned the tables and found Kit's blond head almost immediately. Coming here had been a last minute decision. He still wasn't exactly sure why he'd decided to come. But thinking about Kit singing had made him change clothes and drive to the club.

Her gaze met his and her mouth opened in surprise. She was sitting with Eric McConnell and a woman who looked very much like Kit, though her hair was longer and wavier. This must be Eric's wife Maggie, Kit's sister.

As Grey approached, Eric raised his hand in greeting and smiled. "Kit said she'd invited you but didn't think you'd come."

Grey wondered what else Kit had said, if she was still thinking about the almost-kiss like he was. He nodded to her. "I figured I could use a night out." He couldn't seem to pull his gaze from hers until Eric nudged his arm.

"This is my wife. Maggie, Grey Corey."

She smiled. "It's nice to meet you. Every time Eric goes to your store, he comes home with a new piece of machinery. Soon he's going to need a workshop out back."

"Is that good or bad?" Grey asked with an answering smile.

"That depends on what comes out of the workshop," she teased.

Eric put his arm around his wife. "She won't use the snack tables I made."

Kit said, "That's because everything slides off. Your level must be defective."

"Not if he bought it at my store," Grey drawled.

Eric laughed as Grey sat next to Kit and a waitress in black shorts and a white satin blouse asked what he wanted to drink.

Kit met his gaze when he looked at her. He liked that about her. "Did you sing yet?"

"No, I'm next. I guess you're just in time. If you want to give it a try, you can add your name to the list." The corners of her lips twitched, and her blue eyes twinkled, daring him.

"I think I'll pass. But I'll watch you very carefully in case I decide to give it a shot in the future." He thought he saw her cheeks pink but it was difficult to tell in the dim light.

Kit tore her gaze from his, pushed her chair back, and stood as the DJ took the microphone from the singer to a smattering of applause. "I'm up. Wish me luck."

Maggie patted her sister's hand. "You don't need it. You're good."

Without meeting Grey's gaze again, Kit headed for the stage.

The waitress brought Grey's drink, but once Kit took the microphone in her hands, he forgot all about it. Kit singing along with a CD in her apartment was one thing. Kit in fuchsia stirrup pants and thigh-length knit shirt singing her heart out to the strains of a popular ballad in front of an audience was quite another. She drew his gaze like the sunrise over the ocean, almost blinding him with her color, her intensity and her enthusiasm for each note.

"She's something, isn't she?" Eric asked rhetorically.

She was beautiful, intelligent, and talented, and he was crazy for being here. He didn't need another complication in his life. He'd told himself he didn't need a woman in his life. He had the store to think about...and Deedee. Eric didn't know about Deedee. In their discussion of woodworking and problems with the store, her name had never come up.

The emotion in Kit's voice snagged Grey's attention and there was no way he could look away.

"So, are you going to hire her?" Eric asked.

Grey knew he shouldn't. Attracted to her, it would be damn difficult to work with her. But he had to think about the future of Corey Hardware. "That depends on what she comes up with."

"It'll be good. She knows her business."

"If the store didn't need help, I wouldn't even consider this. The idea of someone telling me how to run my business doesn't sit well."

"Grey, you yourself said you have to do something. If you don't sell to the Red Bucket Corporation, they're likely to build a store near you. If your business doesn't improve, they'll put you under in a few months."

Grey ran his hand through his hair and watched Kit's hips move in time to the music. Something baser than business grabbed him. Something almost forgotten. Once, Kit seemed to be looking directly at him. He thought her concentration faltered for a moment, but he must have been mistaken. She shifted her stance, facing the other direction, her voice strong and true.

Kit finished the song with a smile, and the club patrons responded with a spontaneous and vigorous round of applause. With a thank you she left the stage and headed for their table as the DJ took over again. Telling everyone the karaoke singers were taking a break and it was time to consider singing along to favorite songs in the next set, he played a Billboard hit.

Eric and Grey both stood as Kit returned to the table. She slipped into a chair and waved them down.

"You were great tonight, but then you always are," Maggie said.

"Are you sure you don't want to do this for money?" Eric asked with a grin. "There are lots of clubs..."

Kit laughed, a sweet, light sound that floated around Grey's head with more potency than the drink he

hadn't touched. "Always the bottom line with you, isn't it, Eric? You know I do this for fun. It relieves stress."

He shook his head and chuckled. "Getting up in front of a crowd of people relieves stress. I've heard it all."

She patted his hand. "No, you haven't. You haven't known me long enough."

Grey noted the easy affection between Eric and Kit. "Do you get the chance to sing again?"

"Possibly. It depends how many more patrons sign up."

Grey took a good look at Kit in comparison to her sister. Kit's clothes were vibrant, the sterling silver necklace that looked like an upside down horseshoe was unusual. Maggie, on the other hand, wore pale blue slacks and a matching short-sleeved sweater. A golden heart necklace on a delicate chain hung around her neck.

Couples filled the small dance floor. Grey caught sight of a man sitting at the bar, his gaze on Kit.

Eric took Maggie's hand in his. "Do you want to dance?"

When she smiled and nodded, they excused themselves and found an empty spot near the stage. Kit was turning her glass around on its napkin when the man at the bar started toward her. Grey knew exactly what he wanted and decided to prevent it. Without thinking about the consequences, he asked, "Would you like to dance?"

She hesitated only a moment. "Sure."

They no sooner positioned themselves near Eric and Maggie when the song ended and a slower melody took its place. Eric took his wife into his arms, his brown hair a dark contrast against her blond fairness. They were a handsome couple. A loving couple.

Out of the corner of his eye, Grey could see the man at the bar studying Kit. Without asking her if she wanted to stay on the floor, Grey took her hand and put his arm around her in the standard ballroom position. She tensed, then relaxed into his hold as the music played.

In some ways Grey felt awkward as he had when he was sixteen and asked a girl to dance for the first time. Yet in others, Kit seemed to fit naturally into his arms. "Eric didn't tell me you and Maggie looked so much alike."

Kit smiled. "People often ask if we're twins."

He could feel her heat through her shirt. His thumb made a small circle on her waist. "You and Maggie might look similar, but you're very different, aren't you?"

"Maggie's quieter, more reserved. We reacted to our backgrounds differently."

"Maggie didn't rebel?"

Kit looked surprised that he'd remembered what she'd said. "No."

"And she'd never get up on stage in front of a roomful of people."

"Heck, no!"

He laughed and his arm tightened, drawing her closer. The dance floor was getting more crowded.

Kit's heart thudded, and she wondered if Grey could feel it against his polo shirt because she thought she could feel his. She was aware of his finger, gently stroking along her waist, creating a swirl of feelings inside of her. She wondered if he knew he was doing it. His jeans were coarse against her knit pants as he guided their movement and she followed easily. When he'd walked into The Music Box, she'd felt the air whoosh out of her lungs. He was the last person she'd expected to see here.

After he'd left her apartment, she'd decided she'd read too much into what he'd said, how he'd said it, how close he'd stood. She didn't trust her judgment about men, not since Trent. That's why she hadn't dated. So she could have easily been wrong about the compassion she'd thought she'd heard, the intensity in Grey's eyes the moment before she thought he'd kiss her.

Kiss her? He didn't know her. Why would he want to kiss her? And if this excitement she felt around him was pure chemistry, that was even more reason for her to be on her guard. Hadn't she learned her

lesson well?

Except pressed close to him like this, her guard seemed mighty weak. What was wrong with her?

What was wrong was the strength of his arms, the subtle tease of his cologne, her breasts almost touching his chest, his perceptive comments about her and Maggie. Pushing away from him, she asked, "Why did you come tonight?"

He didn't answer right away but studied her. "I'm not sure."

"Oh." She cleared her throat and tried a different approach. "What do you usually do on Saturday night?"

"Watch TV. Work. Shop for groceries. When Dad was here, we'd get a pizza then go play pool."

She'd love to push back the thick shock of hair on his forehead. "It still seems strange, doesn't it?" she asked softly.

He knew what she meant. "Yes. I expect to see him come through the door. Especially at the store."

Her hand moved across his shoulder. It was meant to be a comforting gesture, but she felt the muscle and tautness underneath. "Do you have any brothers or sisters?"

"A'd sister." He tensed as he said it.

"And she wants nothing to do with a hardware store?"

"Something like that," he answered evasively. A few moments later, he broke the silence that had fallen awkwardly between them. "Did you use the ladder?"

"The paper's almost down. I'll get to the wainscoting tomorrow." Testing his presence here tonight, trying to find out what it meant, she asked kiddingly, "Would you like to drop by tomorrow and lend a hand?"

Instead of joking back, his expression became serious. "I have a commitment tomorrow."

A commitment. That could mean anything from a day fishing with the guys to a date with someone. From the expression on his face, he wasn't going to be casting his line. He didn't explain further and where before she'd been somewhat comfortable dancing with him, she suddenly found herself with two left feet and stumbled over his foot. They bumped into another couple. She pulled away so their bodies weren't touching and he didn't draw her back.

When the song ended, she said, "I need to go to the ladies room and freshen up."

He nodded. "And I'd better be going."

"Grocery shopping?"

"More like another look at the books to see if and how I can afford you."

The awkwardness between them was as palpable as the electricity. But as she'd discovered once before, electricity without honesty meant nothing. She could stick to business as well as he could. "I'll call you mid-week with the ideas I come up with."

"Fine."

She took a step back. She couldn't say she was glad he'd come because she felt confused...and worst of all, vulnerable again. So she didn't say anything. She turned and walked away.

***

On Sunday evening, Grey tossed Deedee the softball as the last rays of bright sun played over the grass. Her bat thumped it into a grounder that sped past him and came to rest under the playground's sliding board. He took off at a run and scooped it up while Deedee adjusted her baseball cap on her pixie-cut black hair, bringing the brim to rest at the nape of her neck.

At age twenty four, her coordination was better than it had ever been. He could remember a time after the accident when they didn't know if she'd speak, let alone walk again. She was a trouper. And she loved baseball. They spent most Sundays together and their activities usually involved a game of catch. Today, they'd gone to the movies, then for a drive to enjoy the wonderful July day, stopping eventually at her

favorite fast food restaurant. Afterward, as customary, they'd ended up here.

"Hey, Dee. Don't you think we should quit? It'll be dark soon."

"We should put a light on the ball."

He laughed. Her solutions were often better than his more complicated ones. Draping his arm around her shoulders, he guided her to the truck. "Would you like to go for ice cream?"

She gave him the smile he loved. "You bet."

When they got to the truck parked at the curb, Grey warned, "Look before you open the door."

She frowned. "I know, Grey."

She used that impatient tone with him when she thought he was treating her like a child. But she did have to be treated like a child at times, despite her chronological age. She didn't always think things through or see the consequences. Problem solving was still complicated for her, though living at the group home had helped her with that along with making attachments to other people. He and his dad had been much too protective of her for too long.

Traffic was heavy as Grey eased the truck onto the main highway. When he stopped for a light, Deedee said, "I'm going to Harrisburg next Sunday."

"You are?" The directors at the group home arranged a field trip at least once a month.

"Yep. We're taking the van to the Museum of Science and Discovery." She drew out the last word, pronouncing it carefully. She was usually careful about her words, deciding on them slowly. If she went too fast they got mixed up. The therapist had worked with her long and hard on her patterns of speech.

"That's terrific. Is Tanya taking you?" Tanya was the caring director of the group home.

"Yep. You know what, Grey?"

"What, honey?"

"I like taking long rides."

"Maybe we can take a long ride soon. Down to D.C. They have lots of museums."

"Washington, D.C.?"

He switched on his turn signal. "Um hum. Where the president lives."

"Can we see him?"

Grey suppressed a smile. "He's an awfully busy man. I don't think he'd have time to see us."

"Like you're busy sometimes?"

Pangs of guilt stabbed Grey when Deedee said things like that. She needed as much of an independent life as she could have. That's why she was living at the group home rather than with him. Logically, he knew it had been the best thing to happen to her. And the job they'd placed her at in a pet store had done wonders for her self-esteem.

"Like I'm busy," he agreed. "Like you're busy."

"I'm busy at work. We have two new cats. Tanya said maybe I can bring one home."

Home. She meant where she lived now, not the house where she'd lived for twenty-two years. Grey veered into Dairy Queen's parking lot and pulled into a space. Suddenly he saw a blond woman come out the door. He leaned forward. Could it be...?

The person swung around and he saw that the woman ...wasn't Kit. He had to get her out of his mind.

"Grey, are we going in?"

Deedee's voice dissipated the picture of Kit he too easily carried in his head. "Yes, we are. I hope you're hungry. How about a banana split?"

"Sounds good."

Grey chuckled and opened his door. Deedee was reality. Kit was dreams. Could reality and dreams ever meet? Experience had taught him no. He had full financial and emotional responsibility for Deedee. Yes, she had the workers and tenants at the home. But he was her family. Her only family. And he couldn't shove her to the background. He wouldn't.

***

"Grey, it's Kit Saunders."

Wednesday morning he picked up the phone not prepared to hear her voice. It was cool and polite and the addition of her last name made it formal. "Good morning."

"I have a plan ready to present to you but I'm waiting for some return calls. After they come in, I'll stop over if that's all right. It should be about—"

"Are you free now? I can drop by and save you the trip."

"All right. I'd appreciate that. I'll see you in a short while." With a good-bye, she hung up.

Grey stared at the receiver before he returned it to the console.

Fifteen minutes later, he stepped off the elevator onto the floor where Sunrise Public Relations' offices were located, feeling he should have changed his khakis and polo shirt into a suit and tie. Stopping at the desk, he asked for Kit. The receptionist motioned him down the hall to the fourth door.

She sat behind her desk, shuffling through a folder. Today, she wore a boldly patterned gauzy blouse and skirt in shades of gold, bronze, and orange. Orange and gold beads hung around her neck and long matching earrings swayed against her hair as she leaned forward, studying the papers.

When he rapped on her door, the carousel mobile hanging from the corner of the ceiling caught his eye, and then the shelf in back of her desk with at least ten clown figurines. But his gaze gravitated back to her. She smiled, her blue eyes widened, and his heart seemed to skip a beat. Nah! Couldn't be. Must be his imagination.

But then the smile faded as she waved to the teal leather chair in front of her desk. "Thank you for coming." Pulling the folder closer to her, she lifted a typed sheet of paper and waited until he was seated. "This is the promotion campaign I've planned. The first thing I'd advise is developing a website. Along with that I'd like to see you send out fliers for a sales promotion each week. That day, anyone with a flier would get a ten percent discount on everything they buy. That will make customers read the fliers and of course you will have other items advertised on it also, larger items like lawn mowers, vacuum cleaners, etc. The volume of sales will more than make up for the discount."

"We run sales now...sporadically."

"Do you advertise?"

"In the newspaper."

"You need to get into your customers' homes. The website with coupons and the discount in the fliers will make them take a good look at what you have to offer."

"I've been meaning to do a website, just wasn't sure who to contact or exactly what to put on it. But I'm open to that." He crossed his ankle over his knee.

"Next, I know you want to keep the old fashioned flavor of the store. There are several ways to do that. I saw park benches out back in your storage area."

She met his gaze but all he could find was the public relations expert, not the woman he'd first met. "We don't sell many of them."

"I suggest you put two outside, one on either side of the store entrance. Let your customers use them to chit chat. I bet you'll sell more, as well as adding to the atmosphere you want to create."

"I should have thought of that," he murmured.

Without responding, she continued down her list. "Consider having a celebration called the 'Good Ole Days.'

One Saturday a month, you'll run a special sale—one in which certain items will be the same price that they were in the 1950's. You can plan these for the year and buy from your wholesalers accordingly. Use special discounts and promotions they give you and pass those on to your customers."

"That would be a draw into the store on an ongoing basis."

She finally smiled. "Exactly."

Their eyes collided, and Grey remembered the feel of her in his arms, the temptation to kiss her. Her smile was as radiant as sunshine.

But the sunshine faded, replaced by a seriousness that didn't seem to belong. She pushed a piece of paper toward him. "This is a cost break-out for what I've suggested. I have several more ideas that won't be too costly, but will bring in more business. I just wanted to give you a taste."

A taunting voice inside him asked, That's exactly what you'd like, wouldn't you? A taste. He leaned closer to the desk and studied the figures. "But, of course, I'll have to sign on the dotted line for those other ideas."

She sat back in her chair and dropped the sheet of ideas onto the folder. "Yes, you will."

"And you have something bigger than fliers and park benches up your sleeve, don't you?"

"Yes, I do."

Damn her professional attitude. He missed her friendliness, the connection they'd made from the moment he'd seen her in his store. The electricity was still there, but she'd put up a shield. It was his fault, but he still didn't like it. "And what's your fee?"

She pulled a sheaf of papers from the inside of the folder. "Take this along and read it. It's my standard contract. If you decide you want to sign it, give me a call. Sunrise will be glad to do business with you."

"Kit..."

She waited expectantly, her face a mask of professionalism.

He took the sheaf of papers from her hand. "I'll get back to you as soon as I decide."

Kit stood and extended her hand. "I look forward to doing business with you. I know I can help you save your store, Grey, if that's what you truly want."

He knew he wanted to save the store, but at this moment he wasn't sure that was what he wanted most. What he wanted had more to do with Kit and seeing her smile just for him.

CHAPTER THREE

Wednesday evening, Kit sat on the patio outside Maggie's house in Maple Grove and noticed the smile on her sister's face as she watched Eric paint the picket fence half way down the yard. "You're really happy, aren't you?" Kit asked, suspecting the answer.

"I've never been this happy."

"Eric is a special man."

"His mother called last night. She invited us to come up to Connecticut over Labor Day."

"It was obvious at the wedding that she's coming to love you as much as Eric. She's so gracious and...independent. So unlike Mom."

Maggie sighed. "All my life I've wished things could have been different in our family. But 'could-have-beens' don't work for me anymore. I love my life now. I wouldn't change a thing."

Their father had died while they were in college. Their mother had passed away only two years ago. Sadness remained, but Maggie and Kit had gone on to find their own lives. There was only one thing now that Kit suspected Maggie would change. "You want to have children, don't you?"

"Eric and I have been talking about it."

"How does he feel?"

"I think he'd like a big family. He wants to buy another house with more space, but I want to stay here. My business is here. My clients know where I am. I like this area and the neighbors."

A C.P.A., Maggie liked having her business in her home. She'd been set up for four years before she met Eric eighteen months ago when his law firm had hired her to do their bookkeeping. When they decided to get married, he'd given up his condo and moved in with her. Maggie didn't take to change easily. Kit adapted much more quickly. But then she'd been the one who conformed to no one's standards but her own. She'd never tried to be the perfect child as Maggie had.

Eric came toward them and wiped the sweat from his brow. "I think that's enough for tonight." He dabbed a smudge of white paint on his wife's nose. "It looks better on you than on the fence."

She jabbed him in the ribs and didn't try to wipe the paint from her nose.

Eric sat down next to his wife in a webbed lawn chair. Taking Maggie's hand, he put it on his jean-clad thigh, covering it with his, then turned to Kit. "So, did you get the Corey account?"

She shrugged. "I don't know yet. Grey's looking over the contract."

"What did you think of Grey?" her brother-in-law asked casually.

That wasn't an easy question. "He's an interesting man."

Eric raised a brow and caught the look Kit exchanged with Maggie. "Um. I have a feeling my wife knows more about this than I do."

Eric knew Kit and Maggie confided in each other. Soon after he'd married Maggie, he'd told Kit he didn't expect Maggie to reveal any of her sister's secrets. He respected their closeness. But so far there hadn't been any secrets. "There's nothing to know," Kit said.

"I liked him," Maggie offered. "You two danced well together."

Kit remembered the dancing, the closeness, and the conversation.

Eric nudged Maggie. "She's not talking. That means something."

Maggie scolded, "Don't tease."

Kit shifted restlessly in her chair, knowing the couple meant well. "Look, you two. Grey's an attractive, intelligent man. But I'm not ready to get involved with anyone. I'm not ready to trust another man."

"Sometimes being 'ready' doesn't count for much," Maggie said softly.

Maggie had insisted she wasn't ready for love when Eric walked into her life. Look what had happened between them! Yet despite being sisters, Kit knew she was different from Maggie. She was bossier, more assertive. Not as easy to love. She didn't even know why she was thinking about loving again. She'd just met Grey. Yes, she was attracted to him. But that's all it was—attraction. And apparently he was already involved with someone. No way would she set a foot into that kind of mess.

Kit stood. "I'd better get going."

"I didn't mean to chase you away," Eric said.

"You're not. I have some work to do at home."

Maggie and Eric exchanged a look that said they didn't believe her. But she did have work to do. And right now work was a better alternative than thinking about the reaction Grey caused within her, let alone analyzing it with her sister and her husband.

***

Friday evening, Grey rang Kit's doorbell. Yes, he could have taken the contract to her office. He probably should have. But he didn't want that professional side of Kit to surface again, the one who didn't smile much and talked politely only about business.

She came to the door, plastering trowel in hand. She'd pushed her hair behind her ears. Perspiration gleamed above her yellow tube top and it was obvious she wasn't wearing a bra. While his body responded to that, his eyes lingered on the red short shorts baring her lovely long legs. The July heat stuck his shirt to his back but Kit's appearance made parts of his body burn and that had nothing to do with the summer temperature.

"Grey!" She took a step back.

He lifted the contract in his hand. "I signed on the dotted line."

"Um, well..." She looked over her shoulder. "I'd invite you in but it's hot as blazes in here. I only have an air conditioner in the bedroom..."

He gave a quick thought to Kit, in her bedroom, with or without an air conditioner, and focused on the trowel in her hand. "Plastering?"

"I have a mess where I pried off the wainscoting. I don't see how I can paint or paper over it."

"Would you like me to take a look?"

She glanced again at the contract in his hand, then pushed her bangs from her brow. "Why not? I can use all the help I can get."

Grey breathed a sigh of relief, until that moment not realizing exactly how much he wanted to talk to her. And not about business. He opened the door and followed the sway of her hips. A two foot square floor fan recycled the hot air through the living room. A new overhead light of oak and wrought iron with contemporary globes glowed brightly against the gathering darkness.

Grey held out the contract. "You might want to put this in a safe place."

She checked to see if he'd signed and dated it. "Do you have any questions?"

"It was self-explanatory unless there's fine print I missed."

A faint smile tilted her lips. "No fine print." She motioned toward the hallway. "I'm going to put this in my briefcase so nothing happens to it."

Grey watched her go down a short hall and heard a door open. Probably her bedroom. Quickly, returning his attention to the living room, he studied the lower half of the walls. This was an old house, probably about a hundred years old from the style and the looks of the damage. Holes of every shape and

size dotted the plaster. She'd patched one wall. He moved closer to examine her work.

A few moments later, she said next to his elbow, "I can't paint over it. The patches are bumpy. And that will affect wallpaper, too. Do you have any suggestions?"

"What about paneling?"

She wrinkled her nose. "I don't want to make the room dark."

"It doesn't have to be wood paneling. There are prints and patterns now as interesting as those on wallpaper."

"But I already picked out a paper I liked."

"There is a pre-paper you can put on the wall to prepare it. That might work. Or think about paneling to cover where the wainscoting was attached. You could use a chair rail at the seam. Then use the paper you picked out above that."

She brought her hand to her chin and tapped her finger against her cheek as she thought about it. "Now, I'm not sure what would look best. Maybe paper two walls, panel the bottom of two... I'd still better patch the holes so I can do whatever I want when I decide."

He took a peek into her kitchen and didn't see any signs of food. "Did you have supper yet?"

"I didn't take the time. I wanted to get this finished tonight."

"Want some help? We could order a pizza."

Her gaze was wary. "You don't have to help me for me to do a good job on your account."

He pushed his hands into his pockets and met her incorrect conclusion with a realization of his own. "Having pizza with you and patch plastering has nothing to do with the account."

"What does it have to do with?"

Her office persona had returned—voice even, eyes blank. He had no idea what was running through her mind. "Wanting to spend some time with you."

Her eyes widened and he saw the vulnerability she tried hard to hide. Crossing to her, his intentions weren't clear in his own mind. "I gave you the wrong impression Saturday night."

"About?" she asked, her tone neutral, the vulnerability again hidden.

"I'm not involved with anyone."

"You're not?"

"I'm not."

She tilted her head and asked suspiciously, "Then why did you let me think you were?"

Kit wasn't the type of woman to let the tough questions go unasked. He knew that about her already. "It seemed easier...safer."

A quick flash of understanding crossed her face. "You've been burned, too."

Telling her about Susan would serve no useful purpose. Besides, he wasn't ready to discuss Deedee and what she meant to his life. "Yes. But even more than that, my life's complicated right now. The problems with the store. Whether I'm going to sell or not. I didn't know if I wanted to add another complication."

"I see."

He touched her face then, his thumb brushing over her soft skin, then lingering on her cheekbone. She didn't back away; she didn't give him any indication that she didn't want him to touch her. "But I like you. And if we're going to be working together, we might be able to do a better job if we're...friendly."

Kit tried to swallow past the lump in her throat. Grey's hand on her face was jumbling her thoughts, making her a bit dizzy, creating pictures in her mind. His presence in her apartment was making her feel underdressed, out of breath, and not at all herself. He wasn't even saying he wanted to date her, which was perfectly fine, she told herself, because she wasn't ready to date again.

Dredging up her voice, she asked, "So you want to be friends?"

He smiled a crooked smile that sent her pulse on a speed chase. "Yes. Any objections?"

A small voice inside her whispered, It's a good place to start. A louder voice overrode the first by warning, Be careful. Stepping away from his touch, she stooped and picked up the bag of plaster mix. With a smile, she said cheerfully, "I can always use a friend. Especially one who's willing to work."

He laughed, a deep, rumbling sound that affected her almost as much as his touch. Taking the bag from her, a smile hovering on his lips, he said, "While I mix this, you call for the pizza."

Still trying to absorb Grey's physical presence in her living room and the effect it had on her, she crossed to the kitchen and asked, "Any preference?"

The heat that flashed for a moment in his green eyes weakened her knees. But the words out of his mouth were ordinary. "I'm partial to pepperoni and mushrooms."

"Together or separate?"

He chuckled. "Together."

As she went to the phone, she struggled with the question of whether or not becoming friends with Grey was a good idea. As she lifted the receiver she realized it didn't matter because they were on their way. She already knew he liked pizza with pepperoni and mushrooms. Together.

***

The heat increased instead of diminished as they worked. Sweat trickled between Kit's breasts as she sat on the floor smoothing a spot she'd just plastered. It was amazing she was getting anything accomplished when her attention kept straying. She looked over at Grey working on the same wall, perspiration beading on his brow. Drawing his wrist across his forehead, he grimaced and pulled his shirt away from his chest.

"I can set the fan closer to you," Kit offered.

"I don't think it will help. The circulation is best where it is. But I do think I'll take this off if you don't mind."

Pulling his T-shirt from the band of his shorts, he waited for her answer.

Mind? Why should she mind? "Go ahead."

Before she could blink, he'd tugged it over his head. Throwing it over the ladder that stood in one corner, he smiled. "That's better."

Better for him, maybe. She bit her lower lip as she tried not to stare. With a quick sideways glance, she took in his mussed black hair, his bare chest, his muscular arms, his broad shoulders. She couldn't prevent a second longer look. His chest hair was thick and full, surrounding his dark nipples and aiming down the middle of his chest. It didn't stop there, but she did. As she raised her head, her gaze smacked into his.

Fire burned her cheeks as she quickly looked away. She dipped her trowel into the bucket of plaster and smoothed it across the wall. The only problem was—she missed the hole. Biting her lip, she took a deep breath and concentrated on her task.

When the doorbell rang, Grey was closer to the door than she was. When he stood and went to answer it, she scurried to her feet and called after him, "I have to get the money..."

"I've got it," he called back, sidestepping her cats who'd stretched out in the middle of the living room.

After the work Grey was putting in, she couldn't let him pay for dinner, too. She went to the kitchen and took a bill from her wallet. But when she returned, the delivery boy had left. Meeting Grey at the door, she held out the money to him. "Here."

"Put it away, Kit."

"I can't let you—"

"Buy supper? Why not?"

"Because...because...I'm just very careful about that sort of thing."

He carried the pizza to the kitchen. "Why?"

She followed, saying, "It doesn't matter why." She hated feeling vulnerable, she hated feeling as if she owed anyone anything.

"Because of Higgins?"

She nodded.

He sat on the loveseat and patted the cushion next to him. "I'm not sure I understand the connection."

Sighing, she sank down next to him. "He was the perfect con man, Grey. He wined me and dined me till the end. Expensive restaurants, flowers, presents. I guess he considered it a good investment because then he stole triple that and more." She shook her head. "I've been paying back bills for so long I don't want to be beholden to anyone."

"Kit, this is just a pizza."

"And what do you expect if you buy me the pizza?"

"Half the pizza," he said with a poker face.

She couldn't suppress her smile or the laugh that followed and felt so good. "You think I'm being silly."

"I think you're making too much of a pizza."

When she inhaled, she could smell pizza but she could smell Grey too. Male. Heat. A hint of aftershave or cologne. His skin was bronze from the summer sun, his chest hair only a few inches from her fingers. His green gaze flecked with sparks of gold dawdled across her face and came to rest on her lips. If she leaned toward him, she knew what would happen.

Her mouth desert dry, she scooted away from him, saying, "I have soda in the fridge. I'll get it."

At the refrigerator, she asked herself, How was she going to work professionally with this man?

Easy. They'd both keep their clothes on.

She breathed a sigh of relief. It was his bare chest that was making her crazy. That's all.

Returning to the loveseat with the cans of soda and glasses, she sat a good six inches away from Grey.

He picked up the soda and popped the top. "The can is fine." Tipping it up, he took long swallows.

His neck was as tan as the rest of him. She watched each swallow, seeing the line of beard shadow extended far under his chin. Her fingers itched to trace it, to touch his skin, to find out if his chest hair was as soft as it looked. That chest again. Focusing on the pizza, she lifted a slice and took a bite.

"Now that I've signed the contract, what else do you have planned for the store?"

"You think I can remember without my notes?" she teased, thinking business was a safe topic.

"If you're as sharp as I think you are, you certainly can."

The compliment felt nice. Then she remembered all of Trent's compliments, his smooth lines.

"Kit?"

This was Greyson Corey, not Trent Higgins. But she didn't know him well enough to know how smooth he could be. "I think you should take a few lessons from the chain stores."

"The impersonal service, the waiting in line..."

"The amount of profit coming in."

He scowled. "I told you I want to keep the store customer-friendly."

"And we can do that. I don't intend to turn Corey's into something you don't want."

"What ideas do you want to borrow from chain stores?"

"Baskets, for one. If your customers pick up hand baskets when they walk in, they're more likely to pick up more merchandise."

He finished off a piece of pizza and picked up another. "I don't have a problem with that. What else?"

"A give-away."

"If you're suggesting a cruise like Tri-Hill is giving away, forget it."

Tri-Hill was one of the large chain stores in Meadeville. "I understand you can't afford that. But what about a Get-Away weekend for two in the Poconos or to Inner Harbor in Baltimore, or even to

Williamsburg. I think people in this area would go for that. And as they sign up, you're developing a mailing list of the loyal customers who buy at your store. You can target them for special sales."

He thought it over as the pizza draped over his hand. "I can see how that might work. I suppose hotels might donate nights just for the advertising."

"Exactly." She let him digest the ideas before saying, "And then there's one big promotion all the others would lead up to. We'd specify a special day when we have the grand opening of the "new" Corey's Hardware. Emphasize customer service, emphasize sales, emphasize everything special about your store. We'd go all out with this. We'd send fliers, we'd give away the weekend and door prizes, have a hot dog stand, the mobile unit from the radio station to broadcast from the store. We'll put Corey's on the map."

"We're talking about a real change, aren't we?"

"It's the only way I can see to increase the volume of customers and sales. No, it won't ever be the same again, Grey. But isn't that the point of hiring me? To bring about positive change?"

"Change usually brings loss."

"Maybe. But if you can accept change positively, it can be rewarding, too."

He seemed far away. As if he was thinking of all the ways change had affected him. This wasn't a shallow man. He was strong and stable and she got the feeling he was dependable, too. But could she trust her judgment again? She didn't depend on anyone...except Maggie for moral support. Needing, depending, loving, led to so much hurt. Maggie was the only person she could really trust.

"Eric said you were a go-getter and if anyone could turn the business around, you could. But I thought he meant the books, not the nature of the store."

Kit pushed the pizza box with her knee and faced him squarely. "Do you want your contract back?"

He plopped his unfinished slice of pizza into the box, then held her gaze. "No."

The electricity that had been building between them crackled around them. She fairly vibrated with it and experienced a magnetic pull so strong she felt her body lean forward.

"Kit?"

It was a question with only one answer. "Yes."

How could a conversation be so short and so long at the same time? Years seemed to pass that were merely seconds as he searched her face. In slow motion, his hand came closer to her until it grazed her shoulder and slipped beneath her hair. The thread of desire between them pulled taut, making anticipation painful yet breathtaking at the same time.

With his other hand, he stroked her cheek, heightening the wanting, intensifying the longing for his kiss. In a tender gesture, he brushed across her eyebrow, and tears pricked in her eyes. She didn't know why, she just knew he was touching more than her face.

The heat from his bare skin enfolded her, the emerald lights in his eyes mesmerized her, the scent of him surrounded her. The nerve along his jaw beat in time with her heart.

"I didn't intend for this to happen," he said in a husky rasp.

"Didn't you?" They'd both felt the chemistry from the moment they'd met.

"No. Because we do have to work together," he murmured as he leaned closer and all thoughts of work and plastering faded into the sensation of his lips finding hers.

The press of his lips was hot and firm and tempting. Gently sweeping the seam of her lips with his tongue, he asked her to open to him. She did...and waited. His tongue searched and excited. His hands held her head while he tasted her thoroughly. No other part of them touched, and that lack itself was frustrating and erotic. It only took a few moments until she wanted more...of the kiss, of touching, of Grey.

She lifted her hands to his shoulders and as she closed her fingers over his skin felt weak all over. He was so...male. So hot. So... Thoughts fled as he stroked her tongue with his, as desire surged through her blotting out the past, inviting her to take a risk, freeing her to need more.

She'd thought she'd known passion, she'd thought she'd known about the chemistry between a man and

a woman. Explosive had never been part of it. Neither had the somersaulting sensation in her stomach. Neither had the overwhelming yearning to touch a man and have him touch her.

Why Grey? Why now?

He said he hadn't intended this to happen because ...because...they had to work together. This was more than friendly. He was a client for goodness sake! She was going to save his store. They didn't even know each other and here she was...

Yes, Kit, exactly what are you doing? Jumping in with your heart before your head has a chance to protect you?

She'd promised herself she'd be careful. She'd promised herself that if she became interested in another man she'd check out everything about him. Exactly what did she know about Greyson Corey except that he owned a hardware store?

Exasperated with herself, her body's response to him, the liking she had no logical reason to feel yet, she gasped and pulled away.

Grey dropped his hands and examined her carefully, desire still alive and potent in his green eyes. He waited for her to say something first.

Only one thought entered her head and as she fought to control the emotion and sensation rioting inside her, she took a deep breath and asked, "Would you rather have another consultant work on your account?"

CHAPTER FOUR

Moments ticked by before Grey answered. Finally, he said, "I don't want another consultant. I want you." His green eyes were giving her the message he wanted her for more than her public relations expertise.

"I don't get involved with my clients, Grey. It's not good business." Never mind that she didn't intend to get involved with anyone.

"It was a kiss, Kit. That's all. We're adults. We control what happens to us."

And that was exactly the problem. She hadn't controlled what had happened to her in the past. Trent Higgins had slipped by her good sense and the intuition she'd trusted since she was a child with pretty words and promises and hope-building dreams.

Grey must have followed the path of her thoughts because he said, "The store's too important to me to jeopardize its future for a..."

"Roll in the hay?" she suggested sweetly.

He frowned. "If those are the terms you want to use."

She sighed. "They're as good as any." She was still too close to Grey. She still remembered his taste and the heat of his lips.

But before she could move away, he reached out and stroked her cheek. "You're a very sexy woman."

She could tell him he was a very sexy man but the emerald sparks of desire still dancing in his eyes told her to be careful.

Pulling away from him, she kidded, "Only when I'm dressed for patch plastering." Gesturing toward the pizza, she asked, "Finished?"

He nodded, his black hair falling over his forehead, his gaze much too intense for her peace of mind. She had to watch her step around Greyson Corey, yes, indeed, and she'd better not forget that.

***

Wednesday morning, Grey unpacked a shipment of rural mailboxes. He could let Gus or Larry do it, but he was too restless to work in his office. He'd caught himself thinking about kissing Kit too many times to count. Just a kiss, he'd said, as if he kissed and reacted like that at least once a day. Jeez! That kiss had practically untied his sneakers. Or more realistically led him to toss Kit over his shoulder and carry her to her bedroom.

And then what, Corey? How would you work with her? How would you talk to her? Would you tell her about Deedee? Would you let them meet?

He didn't think Kit was like Susan, but how could he tell until he got to know her better? Susan had made remarks in Deedee's presence that had hurt his sister. And after he and Susan broke up, Deedee had asked him, "It was my fault, wasn't it? That she doesn't like you anymore."

Afterward, he'd wondered how he could have thought he cared for Susan, how he could have been so wrong about a woman. Then he remembered her stunning looks, her intelligence, her sweetness when she chose to be sweet. Did Kit choose the face she showed to him or anyone else, calculating its effect? She didn't seem that way.

The bell over the door tinkled and he peered over the shelf.

He didn't know what always captivated him first, the bright colors Kit wore or her blue eyes. Today,

her short-sleeved suit of canary yellow made her eyes even bluer as she caught sight of him and smiled. There was no awkwardness in it because after the kiss, after their anything-but-thorough discussion of it, they'd gone back to being "friendly." But the turmoil surging through Grey was indicative of more than friendly.

As she threaded her way toward him, his body tightened and he realized his attraction to her would be an uphill battle to fight.

Standing beside him, she unzipped her briefcase and removed a folder. "I have a few strategies I'd like to look over with you if you have some time. One is a revised floor plan."

He knew he'd have to make changes, but he didn't like the sound of this one. "Just how much do you want to move around?"

"Let's go to your office, and I'll show you."

His office? Alone with Kit? He crossed his arms over his chest. "I can't. I'm here alone. Gus called in. He won't be here until eleven."

"The cashier's counter will do. I need to spread out a little."

He pushed the carton with the mailboxes to the corner and headed for the counter. If she needed to spread out, that meant the changes were extensive. Terrific. She was going to turn his store as topsy-turvy as his mind when he thought about her.

It took Kit one look into Grey's eyes and about a minute of conversation to realize something was wrong. They'd parted amiably Friday night, at least as amiably as she could manage after that kiss. He'd seemed so matter-of-fact about it, and she'd assumed it hadn't affected him the same way it had affected her. Had he thought about the kiss and regretted it? There was nothing to regret. Yet.

Kit took the floor plan from the folder and unfolded it, smoothing it on the counter.

After a minute of silent examination, he said, "I don't see the tool case."

The five-foot long, waist high case was difficult to ignore. It's absence, even on the floor plan, was obvious. She'd come here in person instead of emailing the plans because she had a feeling the tool case could be a bone of contention.

If she was lucky, she could explain this tactfully. "The tools inside look like antiques. Are they?"

"Yes. Dad and I collected them. Come here a minute." He crossed to the case in the front of the store and waited for her.

She weighed her words as she approached the case, realizing from his expression that he didn't want to move it. "I understand that the collection might be a hobby you and your dad shared. But what you have to think about now is what will sell to your customers, and ask yourself if this case, taking up prime store space, helps your profit or hurts it."

Grey took a key ring from his pocket and inserted a small key into the lock on the back of the case. "I guess it depends on how you look at it. These tools come from a time when workmanship held pride as well as skill. Look at this auger and that maul. They're at least a hundred and fifty years old."

He handed her the auger and she examined it carefully. "Um. I appreciate what you're telling me. But don't you think you could use this space for a new product or a sale item? It's the focal point of the store when a customer walks in."

"And just where do you want me to put the case?" he asked with an edge to his voice that told her better than the twitch in his jaw that he was holding his temper.

"If you choose to keep it in the store, put it somewhere less obvious where it won't interfere with sales." This was business, and Grey had to face the reality of it.

But he shook his head and stuffed his hands in his pockets, enforced patience emanating from him. "Do you know how rare antique tools are? Do you have any idea what these are worth?"

There was something more going on here than the moving of a display case. She was sure of it. "No. And it's a good thing no one else does either or they'd try to rip them off. You can't even see this case from

the checkout counter. There's no mirror, either. And while we're at it, we need to talk about a security system."

"My customers would never..."

"Do you know each one personally?" She handed back the auger, her fingers brushing his and tingling from the contact.

His gaze locked to hers. His serious green eyes seemed to hold a world of mysteries. What made Greyson Corey tick? What did he hold dear besides this store? And what could put a twinkle of merriment in his eyes?

Breaking eye contact, he put the tool back in the case. "I've known many of them for years. That's the type of store we are, a store that cares about customers, and service, and history."

Evidently, he wasn't getting her point. "How many people stop and look in this case in a week?"

With a shrug he locked it. "I don't know. I've never kept count."

"Maybe you should. You need to see if it's worth the space it's taking up. And remember, just because a customer stops to look at antique tools doesn't make him want to buy new ones."

Grey's jaw set stubbornly as he once again dropped his keys in his pocket.

She said quietly, "You hired me to help you."

"This wasn't the kind of help I expected."

"I think it's more than that."

"I told you before, it might take me a while to adjust to the idea of change. Baskets, a website and fliers are one thing. Changing everything about Corey's is another."

"We're talking about moving a display case."

Scowling, he went back to the counter and pointed to the floor plan. "And the shelves, and the appliance section."

"Look at the red arrow. That's the stream of traffic. Do you see how much freer it will be?"

"All right. Fine. We'll try it."

"What's really the problem, Grey?"

He looked up and said evenly, "The changes are the problem."

"I don't buy it."

His eyes narrowed. "And what do you think the problem is?"

"I don't know. That's why I asked. But it feels as if there's something wrong between the two of us."

"There is nothing between the two of us," he shot back sharply.

She felt his words hit her like a hard blow. How was it possible that this man had the power to hurt her? Not already. Not again.

Swallowing hard, she took a deep breath. "You're right, of course. And there are a lot of changes to consider. I can only make the ones that you allow." Sliding the floor plan toward him, she added, "Think about it. I should have the complete outline of what I've planned along with mock-up ads and ideas for a website by next week."

Picking up her briefcase, she zipped it and forced a smile, realizing she was retreating, recognizing it as unusual behavior for her but not caring. "I'll call you when I have everything ready for your approval."

She didn't wait for Grey to respond or to follow up on his earlier conclusion. There was nothing between them.

As she opened the door, though, she wondered why she felt bruised, why she felt as if she'd miscalculated again.

***

Opening the door to The Music Box, Grey stepped inside. If he found Kit, she had every right to tell him to go to hell. He'd seen the hurt in her eyes. He'd almost gone after her. But his pride had stopped him

as well as the attraction between them.

The past few days, his conscience had bothered him. He'd decided the last thing he wanted to do was hurt Kit. Finally admitting it to himself, he realized he wanted to get to know her better. Apologies came hard for him, but he owed her one. More than anything else, he wanted to see the sparkle back in those blue eyes when she looked at him as much as he wanted to kiss her again.

He spotted her at a table almost immediately. Tonight, she wore a slim-fitting violet dress. The material looked soft, touchable. Gold spiral earrings hung from her ears. Sitting with two men and a woman, she laughed at something one of them said. Had she come with one of those men? She looked at ease. The man on the left dropped his arm around her shoulders and whispered something in her ear. She laughed again.

Okay, Corey. Go break up the party. You have to do this.

Actually, he wanted to do this...and a lot more.

She didn't see him approach. When he tapped her shoulder and she turned, her eyes widened, then narrowed. "What are you doing here?"

All eyes were on him. One of the men raised questioning brows. The other leaned slightly closer to Kit in a proprietary manner. The woman gave him a swift, curious appraisal.

"I came to talk to you. Do you have a few minutes?"

She hesitated, then replied firmly, "I have a phone and an office, Grey. Wouldn't that have been easier?"

"This is personal not business. And you weren't home last night or this afternoon, and I didn't particularly want to talk to a machine. I don't have your cell number."

Her cheeks became more pink as she glanced at her friends, then back at him.

As she studied him, he couldn't read a thing from her expression. Finally, she pushed her chair away from the table and said to the people with her, "Excuse me for a few minutes."

The man beside her covered her hand with his. "Is everything all right?"

"It's fine, Bruce." She smiled. "Keep my seat warm."

Grey took her elbow and nodded to an empty table in the corner. Pulling away, she walked ahead of him. Once they sat and faced each other, Grey didn't know exactly what to say. He wanted to ask who Bruce was but decided that wouldn't be a tactful way to begin. There probably wasn't a tactful way to begin.

So he started with, "I changed the store around."

She tilted her head. "Did you?"

"You were right about the flow of traffic."

She didn't gloat or even look particularly pleased. "I thought you didn't come about the store."

"I came to apologize."

"For what? Stating the truth?"

"No, for denying the truth. For hurting you."

"You didn't—"

He took her hand, stopping her denial. "That kiss took me by surprise."

After a moment, her expression softened and her hands lost their tense rigidity. "Me, too."

He ran his thumb over the top of her hand. "I'd like to get to know you better. Yet, I don't know if I'm ready for a serious relationship—"

A waitress appeared beside Kit and tapped her shoulder. "You're up."

"Already?"

"The guy before you chickened out. Go on. Joe's ready to introduce you."

"Go ahead," Grey said. "I'll be here when you're finished."

She stood and grabbed his hand. "Come with me."

"What?"

"Come up with me. You just watch the monitor for the lines."

"I can't do that."

She pulled him to the dais. "Sure, you can. Live a little."

"Kit, I don't know..."

She grinned. "This doesn't have to be a serious relationship. I'm doing a song you'll know. Singers have been singing it for years."

As Joe introduced her, she took the microphone and introduced Grey, telling the audience he was going to help her on the refrain.

They applauded, Kit smiled, and Grey decided to make a fool of himself simply because it might be fun...because he caught the excitement of Kit's enthusiasm. When she started singing along to the music, he almost changed his mind. Her voice was sweet and true and definitely on key. But he knew the refrain to the old standard even without the monitor, and when she motioned him to sing along, he did. He couldn't believe it was his voice coming out of the speakers. Except for some hesitancy, he didn't sound too bad!

As he got into the rhythm, as he gazed into Kit's eyes while they sang, he forgot about the audience. It was just the two of them...exploring...connecting...having fun. When the patrons applauded at the end of the song, he raised Kit's hand with his high above their heads and grinned. When they left the raised dais, he still held her hand.

As she passed the table where she'd sat with her friends, Bruce said, "Way to go, Kit."

She stopped. "Thanks. Hi Grey, this is Bruce Carlson, CEO of Sunrise Public Relations, his wife, Greta, and Rob who works in the office next door to mine. Everyone, Greyson Corey. He owns Corey's Hardware."

Rob looked Grey over again as if sizing him up, but Bruce extended his hand. "It's good to meet you. Kit and I have discussed your account. I think you'll be happy with what she has planned."

"I'm willing to try whatever she suggests."

"Why don't you join us," Bruce suggested. "We can pull over another table."

What Grey wanted was to be alone with Kit. But she was looking at him inquisitively. She'd come with these people and probably wanted to spend the rest of the evening with them. This might be a good way to keep the ice broken between them.

Grey sat close to Kit, not touching her. His body went on alert each time she moved. He enjoyed the conversation which included everything from politics to advertising strategies. As the last karaoke singer performed and the DJ put on top forty hits, Grey leaned close to Kit and asked, "Did you come with Rob?"

"No. I drove myself."

That wasn't what he meant. "Are you with him?" The scent of her perfume, the silkiness of her hair as it brushed his chin sped up his pulse rate.

"No. I'm not with anyone."

"Would you like to go for a cup of coffee?"

She looked down at the cranberry juice and soda spritzer she'd been sipping. "Do you really want coffee or do you want to talk?"

"We could do both."

She hesitated a moment then asked, "Would you like to come to my place? To talk."

She was warning him ahead of time and setting her boundaries. For now, talking would be enough. "Yes."

After they bid good night to everyone in the group, Grey followed Kit home, parking beside her on a gravel patch at the back of the immense old home. He waited under the trees as she locked her car, then joined him on the walkway. The night was black as pitch with only a sliver of a moon to light their way to

the house.

"Do you feel safe coming home like this?"

"Usually I leave the back porch light on. I forgot tonight." Her high heels clicked on the sidewalk, and Grey sensed more than watched the sway of her hips as she walked beside him.

"Is there a tenant upstairs?"

"Not right now. A young couple just moved out. They're buying a house. My landlord's looking for a renter."

"So you're here all alone."

"Grey, it's no big deal. I can take care of myself."

Yes, he supposed she could. But protectiveness he'd only ever felt in connection with Deedee or his father urged him to look out for Kit, too. It was a strange feeling, one he never remembered having with Susan.

Grey could barely make out the edges of gardens as they walked up the path. He caught the scent of roses as they neared the house. Did Kit tend to the flowers, or did the landlord?

They walked up the wooden porch steps. Kit inserted her key in the lock. As she stepped into the kitchen, she turned on the light. They blinked at each other in the sudden glare. The heat in the house made sweat bead up on Grey's forehead.

"I have lemonade in the fridge. We could take it outside and sit on the porch," she offered.

"That's fine."

Kit's two cats came prowling into the kitchen as she pulled two glasses from the cupboard. Grey crouched down, rubbing the tabby under his chin. "What are their names?"

Kit pointed to the one he was petting. "That's Byron."

The black and white cat brushed against the back of his hand, wanting attention, too. "And this one?"

"That's Keats."

Grey chuckled. "They're not shy."

"Nope. Just friendly. Tomorrow Byron gets to go to the hospital to play with the kids."

"I don't understand."

"I belong to a group—Pets for People. One Sunday a month, we take our pets to pediatrics and let the kids play with them. It's amazing how frowns turn to smiles when they can pet a puppy or a cat."

Grey thought about Deedee and her job at the pet shop. She loved being around animals and she was good with them. He stood as Kit held out a glass of lemonade.

She preceded him outside and settled on the porch step. "Sorry I don't have lawn chairs. I've been saving all my pennies for the living room."

Settling beside her, he took a swallow of lemonade before he set the glass on the step. "Did you pick out furniture yet?"

"I ordered it a while ago. The delivery date is set for less than two weeks."

The scent of roses was strong as Grey turned to Kit. "I enjoyed tonight."

She set her glass on the porch by the wooden post. "Even the singing?"

He smiled. "Even that. Though I don't think it'll turn into a hobby."

"You have a good voice."

"And you have a beautiful voice."

The kitchen light shed dim rays onto the porch. With her head tilted, Kit's blond hair caught them and shimmered. Her eyes were as bright and sparkling as her voice was beautiful. The boat neck of her dress revealed creamy skin that looked as touchable as her hair. He wanted her, and the want became a need that ached.

When he raised his hand, she didn't back away but kept her gaze on his. He stroked her cheek. It was as soft as he'd imagined.

"Is Kit your real name?" The huskiness in his voice seemed to fit in the dusky night, in the silence that wrapped around them as he waited for her answer.

"Katerina is my given name."

"It fits. It's a name that belongs to a princess."

Her expression changed. Her eyelids fluttered down so he couldn't see what she was thinking. "What's wrong?"

She shook her head.

He lifted her chin gently with the tips of his fingers. "Tell me."

"I have a problem accepting compliments from men. Trent was good at it. So now, I can't help but wonder what the motivation is...if they're sincere."

"Do you think I tell every woman I see that they have a beautiful voice and a name fit for a princess?" he asked with a hint of amusement.

"I don't know."

She was wary because she'd been hurt badly. He could certainly understand that. But he also sensed that Kit was a woman who trusted her instincts. He stroked his thumb along her chin. "I think you do."

"Grey, I don't know if I trust my judgment anymore. Just Wednesday you said—"

"I know what I said, and I was wrong. There's something between us strong enough to make me want to deny it." He was definitely wrong about wanting just to talk. There was no point deluding himself or her. "As far as my motives go, maybe I do have an ulterior motive tonight. I want to kiss you again."

"You do?"

"If you don't have any objections."

She gave a brief shake of her head and murmured, "No objections."

He moved closer slowly, savoring the anticipation, the excitement, the desire sparkling in Kit's eyes. This time he wanted to hold her in his arms. This time he wanted to kiss her without regrets or caution or worries about tomorrow.

Kit trembled before Grey's arm wrapped around her. When he'd tapped her on the shoulder at The Music Box, she'd been surprised, elated, scared, and wary. Until he apologized. Then she'd realized he didn't know how to handle the chemistry between them any better than she did. The decision to pull him onto the stage with her had been pure impulse. She'd wanted to make him laugh. She'd wanted to see him smile. She'd wanted to see him enjoy himself.

Inviting him to come here had not been an impulse, but as Grey's arm enfolded her, she knew it might have been a mistake. The touch of his lips was curious, as if he wanted to discover more than he'd discovered before. He pressed against her gently, slowly persuading her to believe there was no where else she'd rather be and certainly nothing else she'd rather be doing.

His hand slid beneath her hair and cradled her head. His shoulder pressed against hers and she felt an aching begin deep inside. As she opened her lips, Grey accepted her invitation. And everything changed. Gentle and slow transformed into demanding and fast. So fast, her senses reeled and Grey became her only ballast. He was heat and passion and a reason to believe in dreams again.

Wanting to feel more of Grey, wanting to draw on his strength, wanting to assuage the yearning ache the kiss was stoking, she reached for him and clasped his shoulder. She traced the muscle under his polo shirt, rolling her thumb along his collar bone. Grey groaned and plunged deeper into her mouth, sweeping her tongue with his as his hold on her tightened. Her heartbeat ran wild.

As a cricket chirped near-by, Grey pulled away. In a raspy voice, he said, "It's as hot out here as inside."

Despite the sensual daze from Grey's kiss, Kit had to smile. "That's because it's July."

He smoothed his finger across her cheekbone. "This heat has nothing to do with the month of the year."

As her pulse slowed, as she took a deep breath to get some perspective, her thoughts steadied. "Grey,

I have to ask you again. Do you want another consultant to work with you?"

He thought about it. "No. I trust your professionalism. How do you feel about it?"

"I'll do the best job I know how to do for you and if at any time I feel I'm not, I'll give the account to someone else."

"Sounds fair to me." He took her hand and placed it on his knee, separating her fingers one by one, sliding his thumb from the base of each finger to the tip.

The caress was tender and sensual and made her shiver.

"Would you like to have breakfast with me tomorrow?"

"I'd like that but Pets for People visits the hospital in the morning. What about a late lunch?"

Shaking his head, he said, "I'm busy in the afternoon. What if we go to an early breakfast and then I come with you? Is that allowed?"

He covered her hand with his—it was warm and callused and felt so good. "Sure. We can always use a helping hand." One thought overrode the pleasure of his touch. It was a Sunday the last time he told her he had a personal commitment. She wished he'd tell her what he did...where he went.

But he didn't tell her. He stood and tugged her gently toward him. After a brief kiss that stoked the banked fire more than it quenched it, he murmured, "Good night. I'll pick you up around eight?"

She nodded.

He went down the steps and continued on the path into the dark of night. She liked Greyson Corey; she felt pulled towards him. But he was keeping something from her.

What was it?

CHAPTER FIVE

At the hospital the next day, Grey watched as a fuzzy, mop-like dog barked and a six-year-old's face crumpled with tears. He guessed the little girl wasn't used to being around animals. But before he took a step toward her, Kit was already there with Byron, crouching next to the child's wheelchair.

The owner of the dog, an older woman with silvery hair smiled and said, "Bobo's just talking to you."

The little girl didn't seem convinced.

"I'll let him talk to someone else," the woman added. "Why don't you pet that nice kitty."

Kit assured the child, "He's very soft."

"Can I hold him?" the little girl asked.

"Sure." Kit settled Byron on the girl's lap. The cat rubbed his head against the six-year-old's hand and she giggled.

Grey and Kit had made small talk over breakfast, neither of them mentioning the night before. Grey had told himself that the attraction between them wouldn't be so strong in the light of day, but he'd been wrong. The urge to kiss her was as strong this morning as it had been last night. When they'd gone back to Kit's apartment for Byron, he'd waited outside. Being alone with Kit in her apartment could turn into more than they both bargained for.

Ever since they'd arrived at the hospital, he'd watched Kit interact with the pets and children. She talked and played with them naturally, as if she was truly enjoying herself. She'd explained that Byron and Keats took turns visiting the children. As Grey helped her and the other volunteers introduce the pets to the kids, he saw their faces light up with joy. Smiles replaced frowns and the hospital confines were forgotten, at least for a short while. Kit had told Grey they visited the children for an hour—that way the animals were manageable as well as the kids.

A woman in a navy suit stopped to talk to Kit. Her name tag marked her as hospital personnel. "I have a surprise for you."

Kit stood, glancing at Byron on the child's lap to make sure they were getting along. "Okay, Sally. What have you done this time? Made me head of the committee to plan the Christmas program?"

The middle-aged brunette laughed. "Nope. Not yet, anyway. But I have nominated you for Meadeville's humanitarian award for this year. This program you established is good for the kids, the pets, and the volunteers."

Kit looked surprised for a moment and then smiled. "I'm honored. Thank you."

"The newspaper will probably call you for an interview. There might be some other publicity involved but I know you can handle it. That's your area of expertise."

Grey moved away from the conversation to an unoccupied corner of the lounge. Stuffing his hands in his pockets, he stared out the window. He hadn't known Kit established the Pets for People program. He'd assumed she was simply a volunteer. So why had the conversation he'd overheard bothered him?

Because it was one thing if Kit volunteered her time unselfishly. Another if she did it for the publicity, to advance her career. The bottom line was he hadn't spent enough time with her to know. He hated to think she'd do something like this simply for personal gain.

They drove back to her apartment after the hospital visit. Kit unhooked the light leash she'd attached to Byron's collar and set him down in the living room. "Go tell Keats all about it."

The cat looked at Kit, gave a small meow, and headed off toward the kitchen.

Kit shook her head. "Sometimes I think they understand me better than my clients do."

When Grey didn't respond, she asked, "Would you like something to drink? It's already hot enough to make me wish I had central air. If you weren't tied up this afternoon, we could go swimming."

He knew she was leaving him an opening. But he had questions he needed to have answered. "Why did you set up the Pets for People program?"

"I guess you heard what Sally said."

He nodded.

She laid the leash on the step stool. "You remember Bruce and Greta? Well, they have a daughter. She had her appendix removed. She hated being inactive and she was giving them a hard time. So I took Keats over one day to keep her company. You wouldn't believe what a difference it made in her attitude. Enough so that Bruce got her a kitten of her own. So...I looked at the idea in a broader context."

"You're a busy woman, Kit. Why take the time to set up a program like this? And after it was set up, why do you still volunteer? So you have something to do one Sunday afternoon a month?"

For a moment, she didn't answer him. Her gaze searched his face, then her smile faded and the brightness of her blue eyes changed to a cold crystal blue. "Why the inquisition, Grey?"

"Aren't we trying to get to know each other?"

"Maybe. But I think you have a particular question in mind that you're not asking. What do you really want to know?"

"Your motivation."

She shrugged. "That's simple. I like pets. I like people."

"And it has nothing to do with business?"

"What could it possibly have to do with business?"

"Promoting yourself, getting publicity for your company."

"And if I did it for that reason, what difference would it make?"

She was on-guard and wary and that wasn't what he wanted. "Let's just drop it."

She gave him a probing look that told him she didn't understand what had gotten into him. He didn't understand it himself. Maybe he was looking for some sign that Kit was generous and kind rather than calculating, some sign that she could take Deedee into her heart.

He checked his watch. "I have to go."

Kit brushed her bangs from her forehead. "Yes, I know. Thanks for going along this morning. Another pair of hands always helps."

"It was my pleasure." He took a few steps closer to her. He hadn't touched her all morning, though he'd wanted to many times over. "When can I see you again?"

Searching his face, she bit her lower lip. It was an indecisive gesture, one he wouldn't associate with her—she always seemed so sure of herself.

He ran his thumb over her cheekbone and added, "It can be business or pleasure." She trembled and he wanted to pull her tight against him to show her what she did to him. Instead, he waited.

"Tomorrow afternoon, I'm going to drive over to Marietta to see a man who sculptures logs with a chain saw. I thought he'd be a great draw for your promotional day. Would you like to come along?"

"Yes. I can drive if you'd like."

"That's fine," she said in a breathless tone that made his pulse race even faster.

Kissing Kit could turn into an all-afternoon commitment. So instead of setting his mouth on hers, he gently tugged her into his arms and kissed her forehead. A strand of her bangs tickled his lips. The scent of her perfume mixing with the heat could drug him. He held her a little closer...a few moments longer.

Then he released her. "I'll call you tomorrow to set up a time." Her flushed cheeks, the rosiness of her lips, the bemusement in her eyes urged him to pull her into his arms again. But he didn't. He walked to her

door.

Behind the wheel of his car, he knew he'd made the right decision. One kiss with Kit would never be enough.

***

Kit climbed from Grey's car and slammed the door. Okay, so he hadn't told her what he did on Sundays. It shouldn't matter. She shouldn't care. It was really none of her business. They weren't even dating, were they?

And if he was keeping something from her, what was she doing seeing him? Hadn't she had enough of that with Trent? What did it take for her to learn her lesson?

"The company truck would have taken the stony lane better. Sorry if you got bumped around."

That's why she hadn't learned her lesson. A few words of kindness, and hope sprung eternal. She considered herself an independent woman so why did she want to think Grey was beginning to care for her?

Trying to think of today as more business than pleasure, stirring up her resistance against the sound of Grey's voice, the magnetic draw of her body toward his, she quipped, "I take bumps fairly well. I'm just thankful I wore sneakers instead of high heels."

There was no definite path from the rutted lane to the cabin like structure nestled in the woods. She wondered if it had running water and electricity.

Grey was beside her in a few moments, his hand cupping her elbow. "Does this guy live in this century?"

"I don't know. I've only spoken with him twice on the phone. His voice is...refined."

As they approached the house, Kit could see it wasn't as rustic as it looked. There was a precise quality about the porch and the rails surrounding it that piqued her curiosity. She wanted to see inside.

Grey ran his hand over the balustrade. "Nice work."

Not seeing a doorbell, Kit rapped on the solid wood door.

The man who opened it was and wasn't what she expected. He wore a black tank top and worn jeans. His beard was long and bushy. His physique spoke of many hours doing manual labor. She'd guess his age to be around thirty, until she met his gaze and suspected he might be older. Brown almost black eyes bored into her, examining her closely.

"Mr. Whittaker?" She extended her hand. "I'm Kit Saunders. And this is Grey Corey."

There was no spark of anticipation in his eyes, nor much expression in his voice. "The name's Zac. Come on and I'll show you the trees." He stepped down onto the porch.

"Wouldn't you like to discuss your fee? The hours you might be available?" she asked.

"There's no fee," Miss Saunders. "I can work in a parking lot as easily as in my workshop." He started from the porch and glanced at her puzzled expression. "Coming?"

She looked at Grey. "Uh, yes. Right behind you."

Grey murmured in her ear. "Not real sociable, is he? Where did you hear about him?"

"I didn't. I saw one of his sculptures at a backyard party a client gave."

Zac Whittaker led Grey and Kit through a grove of trees to a clearing where the sun shone brightly onto a shed. Kit squinted against the light and then breathed, "Oh, my!"

Grey rested his hand at the small of her back as they gazed from one piece to another. "Masterpieces, aren't they?"

Zac said quietly, "You can look as long as you'd like. I can either start one from scratch on the day you have in mind, or I can bring one along that's almost finished. Each one takes about two weeks. It depends on how much time I give it a day."

"And you do this with a chain saw?" Grey asked.

"I start with a chain saw for the basic outline and work. I use other tools to finish. That's what takes the time."

Grey moved toward a four foot replica of a brown bear standing upright. The fur looked real enough to be soft to the touch. But it was wood.

Before Grey could ask any of the questions he had about the type of wood, if the artist had to import it from the northwest, Zac Whittaker left them with, "You don't have to let me know when you leave. Just give me a call and tell me where and when you want me."

And he was gone, as quietly as a true woodsman.

Kit shook her head. "What if he has another commitment the day I want him?"

"Something tells me he doesn't socialize much."

Kit crossed to a totem-like three foot sculpture with an eagle and symbols she didn't recognize carved at intervals. As she ran her fingers over the eagle's head, she said, "We want Mr. Whittaker, don't we?"

Grey placed his hand over hers. "We sure do. He'll attract a crowd large enough to fill the parking lot. People might not always want to pay for fine workmanship, but they recognize talent when they see it and are fascinated by it."

She was fascinated, not only by the sculpture, but by Grey's large hand covering hers. His index finger slid into the hollow of her thumb, stroking the sensitive area gently. As he moved in closer, his jeans grazed the back of her bare legs. She'd figured shorts would be practical for this trip. She hadn't counted on standing this close to Grey, hadn't counted on him making her wish he would hold her in his arms.

His voice brushed her cheek. "I wanted to kiss you yesterday."

"You did." She could hardly make out her own words.

"That wasn't a kiss."

His lips against her forehead had made her knees wobble. "Why didn't you?"

He knew what she meant. "Because we were alone. In your apartment."

Trying to keep it light, she murmured, "I've heard privacy is good for kissing. A crowd can be inhibiting."

He smiled and turned her to face him. "A crowd can be good protection. Keep things from getting out of hand. Let's face it, when I touch you..." He stroked her cheek and she trembled. "The earth rocks. And when I kiss you..."

He bent his head and his lips were hot on hers. She felt his hands settle on her waist and draw her into him. As she parted her lips, his tongue stroked hers and explored. They fit together so perfectly. Grey rocked his hips against hers and she lost all sense of time and place.

Abruptly, he pulled away, his breathing ragged. "See what I mean?"

Closing her eyes for a moment, she let the world stop spinning. "So you're saying we shouldn't be alone."

"Not if we don't want to end up in bed."

His bluntness made her step back and prop against the totem pole for support. "No, we don't want that to happen," she said evenly, though her heart raced at the thought. She knew she didn't want a relationship with sex as its basis. Apparently Grey didn't, either. Did he even want a relationship?

"I have an idea," he said, digging his hands into his pockets.

"What? We only meet in crowds?"

"That's sort of what I have in mind. Do you think Eric and Maggie will come to dinner if I invite them?"

"Sure, they will."

"I'll give Eric a call and maybe we can set it up for Saturday night."

"Should I bring a karaoke set-up?" she teased.

He grinned. "No, thank you. But you can come early and help me with dinner."

At last she'd get to see where he lived and maybe learn more about him. "What are we having?"

"What do you suggest?"

"I'm partial to chicken. Do you have a grill?"

"I not only have a grill, I have an enclosed patio and a picnic table."

She wondered if he invited people over often—if he invited women over often. "Then we're all set."

He removed his hand from his pocket. She watched as he reached toward her and her breathing became shallow. But all he did was nudge her hair behind her ear. "We're set as long as we keep our minds on making dinner, and Eric and Maggie arrive on time."

She took a deep breath and swallowed. "Maggie doesn't need to be reminded to be on time. She's always five minutes early."

The sound of someone chopping wood echoed as far as the clearing, distracting Kit for a moment. She grabbed onto it to avoid dealing with the glimmer of desire in Grey's eyes. "We'd better get back. I'd really like to see inside Whittaker's house, but I don't think he's that hospitable."

Grey glanced once again at the sculptures. "But he does have talent."

***

On the drive home after dropping Kit off at Sunrise, Grey remembered how he'd taken her hand as they'd walked back to the car. It had felt so right, so natural.

He was pulling into his driveway, thinking about Saturday night, when his cell phone rang.

Deedee sounded out of breath. "Where were you? I called your cell phone. You didn't answer. I called the store and Gus didn't know where to find you."

Obviously, he'd been so distracted by Kit he hadn't noticed the missed message on his phone. "I'm sorry, honey. I didn't mean to scare you. I went for a drive with...with a friend. I left the phone in the car when we...took a walk."

"What friend?"

"A new friend."

"Like Susan?"

Lord, he hoped not. "Just a friend, Dee. She's helping me with something at the store."

"What's her name?"

"Kit."

Deedee repeated it. "I never heard a name like that."

"It's short for Katerina. Just like Deedee is short for Diane."

"Oh."

"So why did you call?"

"Can you come over?"

"Now?"

"Uh huh. I got a kitten. She's black and white and purrs like crazy."

He smiled. "Do you want me to come over and take you out for a hamburger?"

"No. Jenny's cooking and I have to help. And I don't want to leave Star."

"Is that what you named the kitten?"

"Yep. She's got a star on her head. Wait till you see!"

"You go help with supper. I'll be over around seven."

"Grey?" Her voice was hesitant.

"What, honey?"

"Are you going to go to the movies with Kit?"

He and Susan often went to the movies. Although he'd tried to spend as much time with Deedee as he always had, he knew she resented the fact that they didn't take her along or that Grey could have been

spending that time with her. "I don't know. I haven't known Kit very long."

"I hope you don't."

What she was really saying was that she hoped nothing changed the way things were now. Deedee didn't like change, either. It upset the structure of her life. Before he brought Kit and Deedee together, he had to make damn sure he knew what he was doing.

***

Grey carried the platter of chicken to the redwood picnic table where Eric and Maggie were already seated. "I'm glad you could come."

"We are, too. Except for Kit, we don't socialize much," Maggie responded.

"Newlyweds don't socialize much," Eric said with a loving smile for his wife.

Kit spooned a portion of baked beans onto her plate. "And just how long can you qualify as newlyweds? Your year is almost up."

"A year?" Eric asked in mock horror. "I thought newlywed status lasted five years, ten if we're lucky."

Kit reached for the carrot sticks. "With you two it probably will."

Maggie addressed Grey who was sitting across from her. "So how are things at the store?"

"We sent out the first batch of fliers and ran the new ads last weekend. Business definitely picked up. When I saw customers loading their baskets, I wondered if they were buying more. The sales receipts proved it. I'm not out of the woods yet, but unless this week was a flash in the pan, we're on our way."

"It'll keep up," Kit insisted. "Once we have our promotional day, everyone in the surrounding area will know about Corey's Hardware."

Grey laid his hand on top of hers on the table. "Because you're good."

Kit heard the respect in Grey's voice. That enfolded her as much as the sparks of desire in his eyes excited her. It had been fun preparing supper with him. With all her heart she wanted to believe he wasn't too good to be true—sexy, attractive, caring. t r Yet doubts still plagued her.

His two-story home was modest and situated in a pleasant section of Maple Grove. The brick and white siding exterior was well cared for, as were the shrubs that outlined the yard. No flowers grew and Kit would definitely do something about that to give the landscape splashes of color.

The interior of the house had no particular decor and the style was masculine-comfortable—a long, cushy sofa, two recliners, small tables that held everything from magazines to knickknacks. She'd been most interested in the knickknacks which included an autographed baseball to a ceramic dish resembling something a child would make at camp. Several colored pencil and pastel drawings hung on the walls. They all carried a large "D" in the corner but no other signature.

The conversation flowed easily among the four of them until Eric asked Kit, "Is your living room finished yet?"

"Yep. The wallpaper is up. I'm just waiting for the furniture."

"If Higgins hadn't set you so far back financially, you could have had it finished long ago," Eric muttered, then glanced quickly at Kit. "Sorry, I know you'd rather forget about it."

Eric knew she'd confided in Grey about Higgins. Her brother-in-law never would have brought it up if she hadn't told him the subject was in the open. "That's all right. I don't cringe when I hear his name anymore."

The silence at the table was broken by the beep of a cell phone coming from the kitchen. Grey untangled his long legs from under the bench and said, "I'll be right back."

Maggie asked in a low voice, "You like Grey a lot, don't you?"

"Yes, and it worries me. I was wrong about Trent. I could be wrong about Grey."

"Grey Corey is nothing like Trent Higgins," Eric assured her.

"How do you know?"

"Because I've spent time with him. I met his dad. I saw the suffering Grey went through while his father was sick. He's the genuine article, Kit. Believe it."

Oh, how she wanted to. But she wasn't sure her heart was healed from her last attempt at loving. "This has nothing to do with logic, Eric. And even if I want to believe it..."

Grey's expression was grim as he hurried out the door. "I have an emergency I need to attend to. Please feel free to stay and finish dinner. I hope I'll be back shortly, but I don't know." Grey's cheeks were pale and his mouth was a tight line. "Is there anything we can do?" Kit asked.

"No. I really have to go. Kit, if this takes a while, I'll call you."

"I'll wait for you."

"You don't have to do that." With a lift of his hand, he apologized again to Eric and Maggie and went into the house.

Kit stared at the back door for a few moments. "All right, Eric. You know Grey so well. What's going on?"

Her brother-in-law looked uncomfortable. "I don't know. But I'm sure he'll explain it to you when he comes back."

"Oh, you think so. Well, let me tell you, if he doesn't, I won't be seeing him again. Not on a personal level. He's been keeping something from me. I know it. And I won't be involved with a man who does that again."

***

Dusk made seeing difficult as Grey drove slowly around the parking lot. Deedee's shift had ended at six. She'd gone outside to wait for her ride. One of the aides from the home was supposed to go and get her. But somehow signals had gotten crossed, lists had gotten mixed up, and no one had picked her up. Yet she wasn't still at the pet shop nor had she arrived home. She was lost and Grey felt sick in his soul.

What if someone had enticed her to their car? A stranger? She couldn't protect herself. She wasn't that strong. She got confused when she was upset. Everyone at the home was out looking for her. Grey had wanted to call the police, but Tanya had convinced him to give them another hour. To give Deedee an hour to be responsible for herself. The hour was killing him.

Driving out of the parking lot while keeping his eyes glued to the side of the street, he turned left toward a residential section of Meadeville. He should have kept her with him. He should have kept her safe under his roof in Maple Grove.

Deedee could have taken one of at least three routes home. It was about a mile—the longest mile Grey had ever driven–until he saw the shadow under a crimson maple. He recognized the set of his sister's shoulders as she stood under the tree with something in her hand. When he pulled up at the curb he realized it was an...ice cream cone!

Taking in a draft of air to calm himself, he got out of the car. "Deedee?"

"Grey, what are you doing here?" She hid the ice cream behind her.

"Honey, we were all worried about you. The schedules got mixed up and Roy forgot to pick you up. Are you okay?"

She licked her lips. "I'm fine. I'm walking home."

"I see. Why didn't you call Tanya from the pet shop when Roy didn't show?"

"Cause I felt like walking."

"You weren't afraid you'd lose your way?"

"Nah. I watch when Roy takes me. It's easy."

"Your ice cream's going to melt if you don't eat it."

Looking guilty, she took it from behind her back. "Don't tell Tanya, okay? She doesn't like me to eat too many sweets."

Grey dropped his arm around her shoulders. "It'll be our secret. C'mon, let's get you home before they send out the marines."

"Am I in trouble?"

Her dark brown eyes were so innocent and naive. He didn't have the heart to tell her what might have happened. "Not exactly. We'll have to talk to Tanya about walking home, though. It's not something you should do alone."

"Why? I saw other people walking."

"It's just better if you do it with a friend." He and Tanya would have to talk to Deedee about the dangers of walking alone, especially at night. Maybe between the two of them, they could explain it in terms Deedee would understand. They had to because he couldn't handle going through another hour like the last one.

***

Kit paced across Grey's living room for the umpteenth time. She heard his car pull into the garage. She heard him open the door from the garage to the kitchen. As his footfalls came toward her, her heart beat faster.

"I didn't expect you to still be here," he said as he entered the living room.

"I wanted to talk to you."

He frowned. "I hated leaving like that. I'll call Eric and Maggie tomorrow and apologize again."

"An apology might not be necessary if we knew why you left."

He studied her for a long moment. "It was personal."

"How personal?"

Coming closer, he stood in front of her. "We haven't known each other very long, but I'm going to ask you to trust me on this. There are some things in my life I'm not ready to share yet."

"Like what, Grey? An ex-wife? Maybe a not-so-ex-wife?"

"No. Absolutely not."

"Then tell me."

"I have no right to pry into your personal life and you have no right to pry into mine."

"I don't have any secrets."

He ran his hand wearily across his forehead. "I've had a tough couple of hours, Kit. Do you think we could postpone this discussion?"

She picked up her purse from the table next to his sofa. "Sure, we can postpone it. We can postpone it indefinitely. It's just that I had this mistaken impression that the kisses we shared were very personal. So was some of our conversation. But I've been wrong before. Very wrong."

"Kit..."

She went to the door. "It's okay, Grey. Maggie has always told me I'm too impulsive. Maybe now I'll believe her."

Not waiting for his response, she pushed open the door and went outside. Her pride and self-respect urged her to hurry to her car. As she pulled away, she didn't look back.

CHAPTER SIX

The shade of the tree didn't cool Kit off on Sunday afternoon as she sat in Maggie's car and waited for Grey to come out of his house.

Why am I doing this? Kit asked herself.

Because you care. Maybe too much. And you have to know the truth, one way or another.

The answer made sense. Her history with Trent Higgins urged her to follow through. But this didn't feel right. It just didn't.

Finally, Grey's garage door opened. As he pulled out of his driveway, Kit switched on her ignition and followed him from her spot under a tree a half block down the street. She was spying, pure and simple. And she didn't like it. But whatever he was hiding had to do with his Sunday afternoon commitments. She was sure of it.

Curiosity might have killed the cat, but being naive and trusting had depleted her bank account, put her in debt, and cracked her heart. Once and for all she'd find out whether she should have anything to do with Grey or not.

She'd borrowed Maggie's car so Grey wouldn't recognize it. With large aviator sunglasses and her hair tucked into a baseball cap, even if he glanced at her in his rear view mirror, he wouldn't recognize her.

And if he did?

She'd cross that bridge when she got to it.

Following him wasn't difficult. Traffic was light from Maple Grove to Meadeville. A station wagon pulled out in front of her, but she could still keep Grey in sight and when he turned onto a side street, she was right behind him. She'd driven in this section of Meadeville once or twice. It was a residential section and what she feared most was probably true—Grey was involved with another woman.

He pulled up in front of a two and a half story home with a wide porch. From across the street, she watched as he climbed out of his car, went up the steps, and rang the doorbell. Someone opened the door and let him inside. She couldn't see if it was a man or a woman.

The heat hadn't let up, but Kit didn't want to keep the air running. Her hat felt as if it were melting onto her head as the sweat rolled down her cheeks. Swiping it away, she yanked off the cap and brushed her bangs from her forehead.

Fifteen minutes later, her fingers tapping on the door frame, Kit asked herself again, What am I doing?

You're protecting yourself.

Then why did sitting here feel so wrong?

Because Grey had asked her to trust him, and spying on him was the direct opposite of trusting.

The questions kept coming. How did she know he deserved her trust?

She didn't. But was this the way to find out?

When Kit had asked Maggie if she could borrow her car, Maggie had given her a probing look. She'd probably suspected what Kit was going to do. They supported each other. They let each other make their own mistakes. And this was a mistake. This was no way to learn to trust again.

Kit started the car and drove past the house that held Grey's secret.

***

Working most of the afternoon and evening, Kit sat in her kitchen, the fan pushing air past her nose, ruffling her hair, as it directed some of the cooler night breeze into her apartment from her open door. Byron lay stretched on the back windowsill. Keats had chosen a similar position on the sill above the sink.

Engrossed in an ad layout for the past hour, Kit ignored the sounds outside, ignored thoughts and questions about Grey as much as denial would allow her. Whenever her attention strayed, she forced it back on work.

Byron meowed and Kit looked up. "What, baby?"

A moment later, Kit heard footsteps followed by a rap on the door. She'd locked the screen door and in the dark of night couldn't make out a figure there. "Eric? Maggie?"

"No. Kit, it's Grey. Can I talk to you?" His voice was rich and deep and held a demand as much as a request.

The temperature in her kitchen seemed to go up a few degrees and her palms sweated. Her purple knit shorts and tank top were not intended for company—they'd seen at least three seasons of washing. But she wasn't about to change.

The tile floor was still warm under her bare feet as she went to the door and unhooked the lock without saying anything.

Although he was draped in shadows, the outline of his broad shoulders was clear. "I know it's late. But I wanted to do this tonight."

She opened the door, and as he stepped into the lighted room, met his gaze. "Do what?"

He focused on her lips for a moment and then he canvassed the rest of her. Her nipples hardened and she remembered she'd discarded her bra when she'd changed. For a moment she thought about ducking into her bedroom then chided herself for the thought. This was her house...he was imposing on her privacy. And "imposing" was definitely the word. His skin was tan against his navy shorts and polo shirt, his black hair rough and masculine. Her heart beat much too fast for her well-being.

He concentrated his focus on her so intensely she felt naked...and vulnerable. Did he know she'd followed him today? Had he caught her spying? Was he here to tell her to stay out of his private life?

"There's something I'd like to explain," he said evenly, without the anger she expected.

"Where you went last night?"

His dark brows furrowed as he frowned. "That's part of it. Can I sit down?"

She nodded.

He chose the loveseat.

She settled on the kitchen chair across from him. Better not to get too close.

He rested his hands on his knees. "I have a sister."

She couldn't tell anything from his expression or the tone of his voice. "You told me that the night we danced at The Music Box."

"You have a good memory."

She probably remembered every word he'd said to her. Looking at his hands, his lips, she remembered not only his words.

He studied her carefully and she didn't know what he was looking for as he said, "Deedee lived with Dad and I until...he got sick."

The slight hesitation in Grey's voice caught her attention more than his words. Kit edged forward on her chair. His voice grew huskier as he continued. "When Deedee was four, we visited the summer cottage of a friend of Dad's. It was on a lake. They had four kids and some other friends were there with their children. Deedee was the youngest. When the rest of us went swimming, Mom kept her with them. But Deedee begged to sit and watch at the shore of the lake and Mom agreed."

"What happened?" Kit asked softly.

"Deedee never sat still," he went on giving the impression he would have continued without her question. "She came in after us but none of us saw her. Mom had only turned her back for a minute. We don't know how long she was under water. I got to her first and pulled her out. Dad did CPR until the paramedics arrived."

"Oh, Grey."

He shook his head. "There was brain damage. Originally the doctors told us she'd never come back to us. But with rehabilitation and Mom's constant attention, she did. Except...there was permanent damage. Her ability to learn was affected and at twenty-four, she's somewhat childlike. Problem solving is still difficult."

The pieces of the puzzle were falling into place. Kit felt so ashamed she hadn't trusted Grey, had suspected him of subterfuge, of being involved with someone already. "Where does she live now?"

"In a group home in Meadeville. She has a part time job at the pet store. Last night there was a mix-up. No one picked her up at work and we didn't know what had happened to her. She was lost for an hour until I found her walking home. Apparently she'd stopped for an ice cream cone and was dawdling while she ate it."

Kit could read the fear and worry Grey wouldn't express. "And you were terrified something had happened to her."

His eyes stayed on hers. "Yes."

"Why didn't you tell me? Why did you keep this all to yourself?"

His silence lasted for three beats of her heart until he said, "We haven't known each other very long."

"That's true, but—"

"Yes, it's the 'but' that's the problem. You and I...connect."

She couldn't tell if the connection pleased him or was the source of dismay. "That's one way of putting it. But I still don't understand why you didn't tell me about your sister. Why keep her a secret?"

"She's more than a relative, Kit. She's my family. I'd do anything for her. I'd drop anything to make sure she's safe and well."

"I feel the same about Maggie."

He paused for a moment as if he'd never thought about that. "There's a difference. I have financial responsibility for Deedee, too. I always will."

"Those aren't the reasons you didn't tell me."

For a moment only the night sound of crickets pulsed into the room. Then Grey said sadly, "People don't accept 'different' well."

"Are you putting me in that category?"

"I wouldn't be here tonight if I were."

His response carried intimacy he wanted to share as well as an element of hope. So she had to tell him about this afternoon or she'd be keeping a secret, too, and secrets were dangerous to any relationship. "Grey, I did something today I shouldn't have."

For the first time since he arrived, a slip of a smile played on his lips. "You drew up a another new floor plan for the store."

"I followed you."

His brows arched.

"For about twenty minutes, I sat outside a house on Laurel Avenue after you went inside then decided I wouldn't learn to trust you by spying on you. I left."

He was silent for a few moments, his expression serious. Then raising his arm, he crooked his finger at her. "Come here."

The huskiness in his voice drew her as much as his words. She moved over to him and sat next to him,

well aware of her bare leg touching his, the heat of him next to her. "I'm sorry I didn't trust you."

He dropped his arm around her shoulders. "In the end, you did. I understand why trusting is hard for you. Trent Higgins hurt you."

Resting against Grey, she could feel his taut muscles against her shoulder. The male scent of him, his presence beside her, his fingers caressing her upper arm made the living room spin.

Turning toward her, he took her chin in his hand. "I handled last night poorly."

She couldn't keep her hand in her lap when she wanted to touch him so badly. Stroking his jaw, she admitted, "I shouldn't have pushed."

"Maybe I needed a push," he murmured, his voice raspy as he bent and covered her lips with his.

Kit needed no push to give into the overwhelming attraction she felt for Grey. He was the man she thought he was—honest, hard-working, caring. She understood everything he hadn't said. His sister had been hurt by people who saw her differences and couldn't accept them. Grey had been hurt, too, though he might not admit it.

Kit didn't know what would happen when she met Deedee. Accepting differences had never been a problem for Kit. But the bigger question was—would Deedee accept her?

Grey's tongue teasing her lips brought a moan from her soul. She opened her mouth to him and held on to his shoulders as his tongue darted inside. Her senses reeled.

With a groan, he scooped her onto his lap. She felt his arousal under her thigh and knew she was stoking it when she pressed into him, needing more of his touch.

His hand slipped under her top and caressed her back in small circles, then wider ones. Her sigh of pure pleasure must have pleased him because he stroked higher. His touch on her skin was heavenly.

But suddenly he stopped, realizing she wasn't wearing a bra. Breaking off the kiss, he rested his chin on the top of her head, his breathing hard and fast.

His arms still circled her, and she felt the tension in his body that came from restraint. "Grey?"

He rubbed his chin back and forth across her hair. "You are such a temptation."

"You think you aren't?" she muttered.

He laughed, the rumble deep and strong against her breast.

As he held her and they breathed in unison, she asked in a small voice, "Why did you stop?"

Shifting on the loveseat, he tipped her chin up so he could meet her gaze. "Because I respect us both too much to race ahead without thinking about it. If we get as far as the bedroom, I don't want either of us to have regrets afterwards." Brushing her bangs away from her brows, he said, "I'm surprised you asked."

When she didn't respond, he frowned. "Higgins really did a number on you, didn't he? Don't you know what a desirable woman you are?"

"He lied so much, Grey, afterwards I didn't know what was true about the relationship and what wasn't. Including whether he desired me as a woman or simply saw me as a pigeon."

Grey brought her to him for another explosive kiss. It was hungry and encompassing, igniting an ache that was scary in its fiery demand for satisfaction. When he pulled away, he said, "You're no pigeon, Kit. You are a sexy, desirable woman."

Tears pricked in her eyes. Ducking her head, she laid her cheek against his chest. "I want to meet your sister."

Grey was still and she wondered if she was pushing again.

"All right," he said quietly. "She's working tomorrow. We can stop in at the pet shop. Keeping it casual will probably be best."

Kit had thought that about her relationship with Grey, too. But she suddenly realized she'd gone beyond casual, closer to intimate, and the idea scared her more than losing every cent in the bank account she'd rebuilt with determination, hard work and care.

***

The Pet Emporium was a flurry of activity as Grey guided Kit inside. He had no regrets that he'd told her about Deedee. But bringing her here specifically to meet his sister had worried him all day. Too much was riding on what happened tonight. He always felt better when he had a planned agenda in front of him. But with Kit and Deedee... Nothing about tonight could be planned.

"Where do they get their pups?" Kit asked casually.

Grey was beginning to understand how her mind worked. "From breeders in the area. No puppy mills are involved."

She gave him a bright smile that didn't look in the least bit worried. But when he didn't smile back, she laid her hand on his arm. "Will you relax? I've met people's relatives before."

Grey mowed his hand through his hair. "Deedee and the last woman I dated didn't...get along."

"Why?"

"Susan treated Deedee like a bothersome child."

"And you put up with that?" she asked with more curiosity than censure.

"When I realized Susan's attitude would never change, we parted ways. But several times Deedee got her feelings tramped on in the process."

"I imagine she's possessive about the time she spends with you."

Sometimes Kit was too perceptive for his comfort. "Yes."

She shrugged. "All right. So now I know the situation. Just introduce me to your sister and we'll see what happens."

Her attitude made Grey smile. "Do you always meet life head-on?"

"I don't know any other way to meet it."

He shook his head. "Remind me to kiss you later."

Tilting her head, she teased, "Do you need to be reminded?"

He groaned and tapped her chin with his finger. "Don't ask. I'd do it now, except—"

"Grey, what are you doing here?" Deedee's sweet, high voice sailed over Kit's shoulder.

When he motioned to his sister, Kit turned to face the younger woman. "I brought someone for you to meet," he answered. Deedee's dark brown eyes started at Kit's head and swept down to her toes. "I'm busy. I have to feed the dogs," she responded sullenly as her gaze met Grey's but avoided Kit's.

Kit smiled at Deedee anyway. "We don't want to interrupt your work. Can we watch?"

Deedee glanced at the woman at the checkout counter. "I don't know. I have to ask Monica if it's okay."

"I'm sure Monica won't mind..." Grey began.

"I have to ask," Deedee said firmly.

Grey sighed. "All right. Go ask. We'll go back and look at the pups."

"Don't go in," Deedee warned.

"We won't." He took Kit's arm, directing her to the middle of the store. They peered through a large glass window into a room with built-in cages. "Deedee takes her responsibilities seriously."

"We've invaded her territory, Grey."

She didn't sound surprised or impatient. Kit's attitude was so different than Susan's. Susan expected Deedee's respect, her notice, her acceptance. It seemed Kit expected nothing.

Deedee returned and with another covert glance at Kit opened the door into the pet room. One cage held two kittens, both were sleeping. Three cages held pups—a dachshund, a cocker spaniel, and a mixed breed who stood and wagged his fuzzy tail.

"Supper time, guys," Deedee announced to the animals. To Kit and Grey she said, "You can stand over in the corner."

As Deedee poured food into the dogs' bowls, Grey mentioned, "Kit has two cats."

Deedee stopped pouring for a moment. "Oh?"

"They're pretty grown up, though," Kit added. "Byron's six and Keats is five."

Deedee placed a bowl in the dachshund's cage and patted his head. "Those are funny names."

"I guess they are. I named them after men who wrote poetry."

Closing the first cage, Deedee picked up the second bowl. "What's poetry?"

"Words about how people feel or how something looks. Sort of like a song," Kit explained.

Deedee gave her a curious look. "I like songs. I like Brad Paisley. Grey likes books with big long words. Do you?"

"Sure do."

Deedee seemed to absorb that as she opened the second cage and set the bowl inside. After scratching the cocker above his ears, she asked, "Grey, are you going to the movies?"

He understood where that question originated. "We don't have any plans. Monica told me you get off at six. Should I call Tanya and tell her we'll bring you home?"

"I guess we can't play ball," Deedee muttered, with a sideways glance at Kit.

Before Grey could respond, Kit asked, "Do you like butterflies, Deedee?"

She faced Kit, her eyes bright with curiosity. "Butterflies?"

"I have a special garden with lots of butterflies. Would you like to see them?"

Deedee turned to her brother. "I don't know. Can I?"

Grey didn't know where Kit was headed with this but if it helped her and Deedee to get to know each other, he was all for it. "I'll call Tanya and tell her we'll bring you back later."

"I can't go until I finish work."

Kit nodded. "I want to look for some new toys for Byron and Keats. We'll be ready when you are."

Grey and Kit left Deedee in the pet room. He showed Kit to a rack with an array of pet paraphernalia. "Is there really such a thing as a garden especially for butterflies?"

Kit passed her fingers over a red sweater fashioned to fit a Chihuahua. "I don't know if you'll find it in the encyclopedia, but there are certain flowers and plants that attract them."

"This is in your backyard?"

Sliding a collar with rhinestones from the peg, she smiled as she examined it. "Uh hm. The landlord lets me plant whatever I want. He just mows around it. None of the upstairs tenants ever cared about the yard."

"I smelled the roses the other night." When he'd kissed her.

"They're up near the house." She hung the collar where she'd found it.

"Between pets and butterflies maybe you and Deedee can find common ground. But I want to warn you, don't pretend interest you don't feel. She'll be able to tell."

Kit's expression changed as she turned and stared at him. Her eyes became opaque blue—a color that hid her feelings. She waved toward the pet room. "Do you think I was pretending in there?"

"You were trying hard."

Her cheeks flushed and she brushed her bangs to one side as her voice lowered. "I was trying, period. To relate to someone new. And I resent the implication that I'd pretend with Deedee to get closer to you."

"I didn't say that."

"You didn't have to." Concentrating her attention on the toys before her, she picked out a ball with a bell in the center.

Kit was so different from any woman he'd ever dated. She demanded complete honesty from anyone she dealt with. And he was beginning to realize she demanded it most from herself. He'd offended her and he wasn't sure what to do next.

After Deedee finished her shift, Grey drove them to Kit's. There was tension between the two women and tension between him and Kit. It didn't make for a very comfortable ride. But when they reached Kit's apartment and got out of his car, Deedee gazed at the house before her and said, "It's big."

Kit came up beside her. "I only live in the downstairs. But there's plenty of room for me and the two cats. My sister used to live here with me."

"You have a sister?"

"Her name's Maggie."

"Why'd she move out?"

"Because she bought a house."

"Were you lonely?"

"At first, I was very lonely. But she and I talk on the phone and visit often. I know she's around if I need her."

Deedee remained silent and Grey wondered what she was thinking.

"Would you like to meet my cats?" Kit asked.

"I want to see the butterflies first."

"Then let's go around back."

Grey had never been in Kit's backyard in the daytime. As they rounded the corner of the house, they walked under a white wooden trellis draped with a climbing rose, brilliant red and fragrant. Deedee fingered one of the blooms before she followed Kit down the walk.

The early evening sun bathed the bed of flowers down the west side of the yard. The bright splashes of color were just out of reach of the shade of the maple and a weeping cherry and made a stark contrast against the green hedge separating Kit's yard from her neighbor's. Even from here, Grey could see butterflies darting and hovering over the purple, orange, yellow, and red flowers.

Deedee took a few steps closer to the bed. "Look at all of them!"

Small and large butterflies, copper, yellow, black, and white flittered above the flowers. Grey was amazed at the number of them as much as his sister.

"They're all looking for nectar—that's their main food," Kit explained.

"What varieties do you have planted here?" Grey asked as he looked at the assortment of flowers.

"Zinnias, snapdragons, cone flowers, Queen Anne's lace, cosmos, and asters. I started with the butterfly bushes in the back, and each year I add something new. I try to plant a variety of heights because some butterflies like to soar and others like to stay low."

"Which are which?" Deedee asked, looking on in awe.

Kit pointed and described each type of flower. She did it patiently and simply. Grey knew she wasn't pretending.

Deedee gestured across the yard at the white and red impatiens. "Why don't you have that kind of flower on this side?"

"Because that side of the yard gets shade and impatiens like shade. All of the flowers on this side like sun. Sun is important to attract butterflies. If their wing muscles aren't warm, they don't fly. That's why you don't see them much when the sun's not out."

Deedee tugged on Grey's arm. "They're on those rocks and their wings are open!"

"They like to rest and perch there. That's why I put the rocks in the garden."

A wooden chair sat near the garden, one with a long back that sank almost to the ground. "Do you spend much time here?" Grey asked gently.

Kit studied the profusion of color, the butterflies dipping and soaring and lighting on a cone flower's pink petals. "After work, when I need to wind down. I come down here and just watch their wings, absorb the colors, let the warmth seep into my soul."

"Can I watch for a while?" Deedee asked.

Kit smiled at the younger woman's hopeful expression, her obvious pleasure at seeing the garden. "Sure. I'll get us something to drink and make some sandwiches. Ham and cheese okay?"

Deedee dropped onto the ground, crossing her legs under her and nodding. Grey put his hand on her

shoulder. "I'll help Kit. We'll be right back."

She nodded again, totally engrossed by the flowers and the wings fluttering among them.

Grey followed Kit into the house and let the awkward silence linger only until she'd taken the ham and cheese from the refrigerator. "You're doing everything right."

"I'm not trying to do everything right," she said curtly.

He took her by the shoulders. "I know."

Kit restlessly moved under his hands. "Tell me something, Grey. What if Deedee doesn't like me?"

"She will."

With a toss of her head, she murmured, "I'm being realistic."

"So am I." Seeing his answer hadn't satisfied or comforted Kit, he told her the truth. "I don't know. You know what Deedee means to me, the responsibility I feel for her."

"I understand but..."

"Kit, I can't give you all the answers. All we can do is take one day at a time and explore this thing together."

The crystal blue of her eyes warmed. "So you think this will be an adventure?"

He chuckled, relieved the tension between them had eased. "With you and Deedee it couldn't be anything else." He slid his hands to Kit's neck and stroked her cheeks with his thumbs. When she trembled, he backed away.

Deedee was sitting in the yard, waiting for them.

CHAPTER SEVEN

As soon as Grey stepped away, Kit realized why he had backed off. One of these times that they started with a kiss, they wouldn't end with a kiss. And with his sister waiting in the back yard...

She asked, "How do you feel about parties?"

He shrugged. "I haven't been to any in a while. Why? Are you planning one?"

"Yes. My living room furniture is supposed to arrive on Friday and I'm throwing a bash to celebrate on Saturday. It's casual. Eric and Maggie will be here and co-workers from Sunrise. You met some of them when you came to The Music Box. Are you interested?"

His green gaze darkened with desire. "I'm very interested. A party sounds like fun."

The idea of Grey meeting her friends pleased Kit. Trent had always backed off. The more people in her life, the more questions they'd ask about him and his business dealings. Unfortunately, she hadn't asked enough questions or analyzed his answers closely enough. Hence, her caution with Grey. Yet the voice of caution was getting softer and softer and she realized trust was beginning to grow.

***

Late Friday afternoon, Kit stood in her living room and closed her cell phone, angry with the distributor who hadn't gotten her furniture to the store, angry with the store because they hadn't informed her about the delay before today. Now she had a party planned and no furniture. Lovely.

Suddenly she thought of Grey. She'd been thinking of him a lot, day and night, even in her dreams. Particularly in her dreams. Deedee had kept her distance Monday evening but her sullenness had lessened. Grey had dropped over Tuesday and Thursday and they'd played bocci in Kit's backyard, exchanging kisses for every point scored. That had been his suggestion. She had to smile thinking about it...the temptation...the anticipation.

But now she was thinking of Grey for practical reasons as she dialed the store.

Grey himself answered. "Are you calling to ask for a rematch?" he teased. "I think you still owe me for a few points."

"I paid in full, Corey. In fact, I think I'm paid up through the next three games."

He laughed. "Then we'll have to switch to another game. Are you free tonight?"

"I have to get ready for the party and that's why I'm calling. My living room furniture never arrived. The store's telling me it's delayed until next week. But everything else is set for tomorrow night. I wondered if you might have a display table and some folding chairs. They won't look as good..."

"I have tables and chairs. But they might look better outside. What if we put up a canopy or two and had an outside bash? I have strings of lanterns we can hang around the edges."

"I was planning to let everyone spill outside because of the hot weather, but your idea sounds terrific. I'll be glad to pay you for the lights, renting the tables and the canopies..."

There was silence for a moment. "No payment, Kit."

"But..."

"Can't I do you a favor? After all you've done for the store?"

"I get paid for the work I do at your store."

"I think we've gone past public relations expert and client, haven't we?"

He was right. She always did her best for her clients. But in the case of Corey's Hardware she wanted the store to succeed as much as he did. "Yes, we have. I'll accept your favor."

"I'll be over tomorrow morning to put up the canopies and the lights. Is eight too early?"

"Eight is fine."

***

Saturday morning, Grey set up the canopies while Kit washed and cut vegetables, made dozens of small sandwiches, and mixed dips. It was ten thirty, when he came into the kitchen, wiping the sweat from his brow. "That sun's getting hot."

Kit took a pitcher of iced tea from the refrigerator and poured him a glass. "Here you go."

He lifted the tumbler and drank. Kit watched his neck muscles, admired his tan, and remembered the strength of his body, the curling chest hair, his flat stomach. He'd look great in anything. Or nothing? a little devil inside her asked.

She put the tea in the refrigerator. "Would you like to stay for lunch?"

He set the empty glass on the counter. "I'd like to, but I can't. I have to get back to the store. I'm short-handed this morning. Larry isn't coming in until three and I told Gus I'd be back by eleven. Do you want me to come early this evening to help you set up?"

"Eric and Maggie are coming around seven thirty. You can come whenever you'd like."

Grey stepped closer to her, lifting her chin with his knuckle. "I'd stay here all day if I could, but thanks to you, one person in the store on Saturday isn't enough. You could give me something to get me through the day, though, and something I'll remember until tonight."

"And what would that be?" she asked breathlessly as his arms came around her.

"This," he murmured as his lips found hers.

Kissing Grey was becoming as natural as breathing. She fit against him so perfectly, his hand felt so right as it urged her closer. Welcoming his tongue, she tasted lemon from the tea, felt the damp heat from his morning's work, and inhaled his scent that could intoxicate her if she let it. For a few moments, she let herself be swept away.

But she could still hear that soft little voice in her head that whispered, You don't know him very well. Be careful. Bracing her hands on his chest, she gently pushed back.

Grey accepted her nonverbal signal. Backing away, he gently stroked her cheek. She could see the pulse at his throat beating as rapidly as hers.

"I'll see you tonight," he said, his voice husky.

She nodded, knowing her words would be shaky if she tried to speak. When he left her kitchen, she knew her feelings for him were getting serious. Very serious.

Was she ready for that?

***

Saturday evening around nine, with the party in full swing, Kit refilled the pretzel basket and checked the potato chips. She noticed Grey standing by the porch with Bruce, deep in conversation.

"Greyson Corey is much sexier than Trent Higgins."

Kit knew the voice before her gaze swept over the svelte red-head who worked in the office next to hers. Natalie Richards could make honey drip from her mouth if she wanted to woo a client. But her tongue could cut mortally if that same client or a co-worker displeased her. Kit stayed away from the woman as much as she could, but because of propriety, she'd invited her along with everyone else at Sunrise.

"He's more than a client, isn't he?" Natalie asked with a knowing smile.

Kit shrugged. "Grey's become a friend."

"I saw that kiss in the kitchen when you went in for more soda. It looked like more than friendship to me. Do you think that's wise when you're handling his account?"

"My wisdom or lack of it is really none of your concern." From experience, Kit knew exchanging barbs with Natalie would serve no earthly purpose.

Natalie took another more exacting look at Grey then offered, "I'd be careful if I were you. He could be attentive because he's interested, or because you'll do a better job for him if he is. You wouldn't want to get used again."

"Natalie, I'd suggest you try a sandwich and give your mouth something to do. It might keep you out of trouble."

As Natalie narrowed her eyes for a comeback, Kit moved away and plucked a can of soda from the cooler on the ground. Straightening, she popped the top but looked deep into the night rather than sipping it.

"Don't let her put doubts in your head about Grey."

Kit's hand went to her chest. "Eric, you startled me."

Her brother-in-law casually leaned against the end of one table, crossing one foot over the other. "That's because you were too deep in thought. Anyone who listens to that woman for a minute can tells she's a—"

"I know what she is. I have to work with her."

Eric pushed his hands into his pockets. "Grey is what he seems."

"I had the wool pulled over my eyes before."

"Kit, you have got to stop comparing every man you meet to Trent Higgins. You look for a hidden agenda. Grey doesn't have one."

Kit swirled the soda can around in her hand. "I'd like to believe that."

"Would you? Or are you more interested in protecting yourself from getting hurt again?"

Despite the run-in with Natalie and wrestling with her own doubts, Kit smiled. "I can always count on you to ask the tough questions."

"What else is a brother-in-law for?" Eric pushed up from the table and slung his arm around Kit's shoulders. "I understand there's a CD player on the porch. Let's put on some music and get this party jumping."

Grey spotted Eric and Kit as they approached the steps. He'd watched Kit with all types of men tonight—friends, co-workers. He'd recognized the appreciation and admiration as their gazes passed over her turquoise knit top and shorts. Rob showed lots of appreciation. It was obvious he was interested in more than looking.

Grey had been gripped by an entirely new feeling—jealousy. He couldn't remember ever feeling that with Susan. It made him realize his interest in Kit was going far beyond friendship, maybe even far beyond hormones.

Was he ready for that? Was Deedee? There was only one way to find out. He needed to get Kit and Deedee together again.

***

Sunday afternoon, Grey's hand brushed Kit's as he handed her the napkins. His fingers held hers for a long moment and he smiled.

To remember they were on a picnic so she and Deedee could become friends, Kit focused on the food in the picnic basket. But as she looked up into Deedee's wary and interested gaze, she knew she had a ways to go in gaining Grey's sister's confidence. Although Deedee had enjoyed Kit's butterfly garden and made friends with Byron and Keats, it was clear she was uncertain about Kit's relationship with Grey.

Today she'd stuck to him like the proverbial glue, insisting on sitting next to him in the truck while

managing to keep at least an inch between herself and Kit in the close quarters of the cab. Kit wasn't the only one afraid to trust.

Yet she was hopeful. She and Deedee had connected on their love for animals, and Deedeeb s had promised to go with Kit on her next visit to the pediatrics unit at the hospital. Common ground. They could start with that.

"Deedee, would you like a turkey sandwich or fried chicken?"

"Both," the young woman answered with certainty.

Grey chuckled. "I don't know, Dee. We have potato salad and pickled eggs, and chocolate chip cookies for dessert. Can you manage all that?"

"We have fresh strawberries for dessert, too." Kit winked at Deedee. "They're healthier than cookies."

Deedee looked from her brother to Kit. "Grey likes cookies."

Kit smiled. "Yes, he does. That's why we bought them. Do you like fruit?"

"I like bananas on my cereal."

"What about strawberries?"

"They're okay."

Kit shrugged. "You can have whatever you want. That's why we brought so much so we'd be sure to have something you like."

Deedee cocked her head and stared at Kit for a few moments, considering what she'd said. Then she decided, "I want a chicken leg first."

Grey put a plate on the blanket in front of her. "A leg it is."

Deedee didn't look at Kit while she ate but directed all of her comments to her brother. Kit understood what the young woman was doing. She believed that if she shut Kit out, Kit would get mad and walk away. What she didn't know was that Kit never backed down from a challenge.

She spoke to Deedee in the same tone in which she spoke to Grey with no trace of annoyance. "Deedee, has Grey told you I'm helping him bring more business into his store?"

"He said you were a friend."

"I am. But I'm helping him with the store, too."

Deedee looked to Grey for confirmation, and he nodded.

Kit crossed her legs under her and balanced a plate on her lap. "We're going to have a special day soon to let everyone know what a great store Corey's Hardware is. Would you like to come and help us?"

Her interest piqued, Deedee brought her gaze to Kit's. "Help do what?"

"I need someone reliable to serve punch to all the customers. You'd have to fill the cups and hand them out. Would you like to do that?"

Deedee glanced at the cup by her plate which held lemonade. "I like to help Grey."

"We'll have to find out what your schedule is at work," Grey remarked and Kit couldn't tell if he was pleased with her suggestion or not.

After a few moments when everybody concentrated on their food, Deedee set her piece of chicken on her plate and said to her brother, "Tanya says I have to ask you something."

He plucked an egg from the plastic container. "What?"

"Can I go camping?"

Lowering the egg slowly to his plate, he asked, "With Tanya?"

Deedee shook her head vigorously. "No. With the guys at work—Jenny, Winston, Monica and Mark."

After a long pause, he responded, "I don't know, Dee."

"Where are they going camping?" Kit asked, as she watched Grey's expression become concerned.

"Gettysburg. Jenny says we can cook our supper over the fire, and toast marshmallows, and go hiking. I want to go, Grey. Can I?"

"I don't think it's a good idea, Dee."

Deedee's eyes widened and her mouth trembled. "Why? I can sleep in a tent with Jenny and Monica. In a sleeping bag. I never did that. Please let me go."

Kit could see Grey's struggle though she didn't understand it. "It sounds like fun. When are they going?"

"Friday. After work. But Tanya said Grey has to say yes."

He pushed his plate aside. "I can't say yes, honey."

Kit watched tears well up in Deedee's eyes. "Grey, maybe..."

"Stay out of this, Kit. You have no idea what's involved."

Stay out of it? Stay out of what, his life? The food on her plate suddenly lost its appeal and her appetite vanished. She couldn't challenge him in front of Deedee because she didn't want to make the situation worse. Yet... She felt very much as she had when she was a child and her father gave her mother an order. Kit hadn't kept quiet then, either.

"So why don't you tell me what is involved," she returned, not letting him close her out that easily.

His brow arched and the nerve in his jaw worked. "We'll discuss it later."

Kit looked at Deedee and her woebegone expression and felt she had to go to bat for her. "I think Grey needs to find out more about the trip."

Deedee's face brightened. "You can talk to Jenny."

Grey gave Kit a dark look. "All right. I'll talk to Jenny. But I'm not making any promises, Dee. A camping trip can be dangerous. I don't want you going somewhere where you might get hurt."

"I like going different places," Deedee said with a pout.

"I know you do. But I'm not sure a campground is a good 'different' place. Maybe I can take you camping sometime."

"I want to go with Jenny," she pronounced stubbornly.

Grey almost looked hurt and Kit realized he hadn't let go of his sister. He was afraid to let her live her own life if he wasn't there to protect her.

The mood of their picnic took a decided downturn after that. Grey tried to get Deedee excited about playing a game of catch, but it was obvious she had one concern on her mind. When he dropped her off at the group home, she asked, "Are you going to talk to Jenny?"

He sighed. "I'll talk to her tomorrow. Okay?"

"Call me after."

"I will."

Kit slid out of the cab so Deedee could climb out. Grey's sister was half way up the walk when she turned around and said, "Bye, Kit."

Kit smiled. "Good-bye, Deedee." She wanted to say she'd see her again soon, but she didn't know what would happen once she and Grey were alone.

It didn't take long to find out.

Grey's jaw was set, his focus directed straight ahead as he drove to Kit's apartment. The silence would have lasted longer but as soon as he switched off the ignition, Kit said patiently, "Say what you're thinking."

"It's better if I don't."

"Afraid you'll hurt my feelings?" She was determined to have him speak his mind instead of brooding or treating her like a stranger.

He turned toward her, his expression more pained than angry. "That's exactly what I'm concerned about."

"I'd like to know what's bothering you rather than guessing about it."

He took a deep breath and let it out slowly. "You don't realize what's involved in Deedee's life, what she can and can't do, the type of supervision she needs."

Kit sat deep in the seat, wanting to touch him, but realizing he might not like what she was going to say. "I realize that you're probably as protective now as when she lived with you. Maybe more so. You said yourself you let her move into the group home so she could become more independent. Independent means making decisions, choosing activities, going places without you."

Frowning, he stared out the windshield. "She can choose activities and make decisions within limits. And when she goes somewhere she needs looking after."

"She doesn't want to go camping alone, Grey," Kit reminded him reasonably.

He whizzed his hand in front of the steering wheel. "None of the people she works with are over twenty-five. They don't realize she acts before she thinks. They don't know her—"

"They work with her. Of course, they know her."

Turning toward Kit again, he placed one hand between them on the seat, the other on the dashboard. "Working with her in a confined place where she has definite duties is not the same thing as a camping trip. And I wish you'd kept your thoughts to yourself."

Kit stared at his hand so close to her, yet felt the distance of his attitude even more poignantly. "You said as much."

He raked his hand through his hair. "I've been dealing with Deedee most of my life. You just met her."

Her gaze locked to his and for a moment she wanted to agree with him, to dissipate the tension. But she wouldn't. "You're right. But maybe because I just met her, I can be more objective than you. Maybe I can see the situation from Deedee's point of view."

"And what's that?" he asked gruffly.

"What did you tell her when she went to live at the group home?"

He closed his eyes for a moment, remembering. "I told her I wouldn't think about her any less now that she wasn't living with me, that I loved her, that in the group home she could learn to do things that other adults did by taking more responsibility for herself, by making friends, by trying things she'd never tried before."

"So a year later she takes turns making meals, she has a job, she's made friends, and now she wants to go camping with those friends. It seems to me she's doing exactly what you wanted her to do," Kit pointed out.

His green glare bored into her. "The people who take care of Deedee at the home understand her capabilities, her fears, her strengths and her weaknesses. I never would have trusted them with her care otherwise."

"And now maybe it's time to trust her and what she's learned."

He was silent a moment, then said firmly, "You don't understand."

"Oh, I think I do. You don't want to let go."

"That's your opinion," he snapped, shifting away, removing his hand from the seat, removing himself from her.

"Yes, it is," she returned softly. Grey's posture was rigid, his hands gripping the top of the steering wheel. She knew they wouldn't enjoy any more of the day together, not with this between them. But her heart pushed her to ask, "Do you want to come in?"

He looked at her then, his eyes hard, shuttering his thoughts from her. "I have yard work to do. The grass is getting high."

"Sure." She sighed and slid toward the door. He made no move to stop her.

Kit walked to her front door, wondering who would make the next move, which of them would have the courage to try.

***

Monday after work, Kit lifted her mail from the black box on her porch. She no longer dreaded

opening it. There were letters mixed in with the usual expenses, not the monumental bills she'd received month after month as she whittled down charges Trent had run up. A light blue envelope peeked up at her from behind a post card which reminded her of a dental appointment.

Calling a hello to Byron and Keats who were stretched out on her bed, Kit went to her answering machine, hoping to find a message from Grey. But he hadn't called her cell, at work or here. The red light wasn't blinking and her heart fell. Later in the week she had to go to the store to set up the posters for the promotional day. She also had to get his okay on ads as well as unveil the website. Sure, she could do it all in emails. She could take care of business without a personal word, but she'd prefer the personal words. She'd prefer not having a disagreement between them.

With a sigh she opened the back door and pulled out a chair at her kitchen table. Flipping through the mail, her fingers froze when she recognized the handwriting on the blue envelope.

Trent.

Why would he write to her?

Anger at what she'd let him do to her life made her movements jerky as she lay down the rest of the pile and tore open the blue one. Her fingers shook as she read:

My Dearest Kit,

I'm sure you're wondering why I'm getting in touch with you now after all this time. Over the months I've been here, I've thought about you every day. I know you won't believe it, but you were the love of my life. The other women... Well, there is no excuse for my infidelity to you. I guess my way of life was too ingrained for me to change, even for a wonderful woman like you. But I am changing now—I have no choice. Prison has a way of making one look at one's past, one's motives, one's feelings.

I still have feelings for you, Kit. I'd like to see you. It is lonely here and I'd like you to visit. If you did, we could discuss repayment of the debts I left with you. I'm thinking about writing a book about my life. Maybe a movie producer would be interested...or a talk show.

All that aside, I've put your name on my visitor's list and I would like to see you. Please think about it seriously.

Trent

Kit flopped down the letter, picked it up and read it again, then tore it in half. The unmitigated gall of the man!

He didn't honestly think she'd drive five hours...

Yes, he did. That was Trent.

Men. She didn't need any of them.

Then she thought about Grey...and sighed.

***

Grey didn't smile when she walked into the store, so she squared her shoulders and thought "business." But that was difficult when his gaze trailed down her Aztec patterned, short-sleeved sheath, quickly lifted to her sterling triangle earrings, then fastened on her lips. She'd left the jacket to her dress in her car. It was a good thing because despite the store's air conditioning, the temperature felt as hot as the heat outside.

She lifted her chin but Grey's eyes followed her lips. Finally, he broke the spell by stepping out from behind the service desk. "Gus will take over here. We can go back to the office."

"This won't take long," she said in her best businesslike tone.

He frowned and motioned her to precede him down the aisle.

Once inside his office, she kept her distance, made sure their hands didn't touch when she handed him

the ads, set up her laptop and the website, then stayed in front of the desk while he walked behind it and lowered himself into the swivel chair.

She waited until he'd looked at it all. When he glanced up at her, she asked, "What do you think?"

"The website is everything we'll need. The ads are fine. Kit..."

Swinging her portfolio onto the desk, she unzipped it. "These are the mock-ups of the posters. I can have them day after tomorrow." She pulled the boards out of the case. "If there's anything you want to change, now's the time."

He didn't look at the boards but picked up a pen on the desk and clicked it open. "I trust your judgment on the posters."

"But?"

"But you have to believe I know what's best for my sister."

"I see. Exactly what does that mean? That I can't give my opinion?"

He threw the pen on the blotter. "Of course not." Standing, he came around the desk and stood close enough for her to touch. "You can give your opinion. Just don't get upset when I disagree with it."

"But if we don't agree..."

"What?"

"How can we disagree and still be...close?"

He stroked her cheek and held her chin in his palm. "Disagreement doesn't have to mean distance. Not if we respect each other."

Kit remembered the arguments between her mother and father. Her father was louder, more forceful—he always won. Each argument seemed to put more distance between them until her mother did anything she had to do to avoid an argument. Kit didn't believe in peace at all costs. She knew she could never surrender her will, her thoughts, her beliefs to another person. Grey was saying she didn't have to. Was he right?

Studying him, the hair drifting over his brow, the lines around his eyes that grew deeper when he smiled or frowned, the strong line of his jaw, she knew she wanted to believe him.

He played his thumb across her cheekbone. "What's wrong?"

"Deedee might be too important a subject not to agree on. You said yourself that your last relationship broke up because of her," Kit responded bluntly.

"You don't pull any punches, do you?" he asked with a wry grimace.

"I don't have any illusions."

He searched her face, then his gaze held hers. "I said I didn't agree with you. But I respect your opinion and I thought about what you said. I'm going to let Deedee go camping. I still don't like the idea. Yet in case you're right, in case this is my problem, not Deedee's, I'm going to let her try it."

Grey had courage, and strength of character, and everything Kit could ever want in a man. She realized she was falling in love with him. Head over heels. Full dive into quicksand. Heaven help her.

She mumbled, "You won't be sorry. Deedee will only grow stronger if you give her the freedom she needs."

"I had a long talk with Tanya, and she agrees with you. I still have my doubts. We'll know after the camping trip."

Kit brushed his hair tenderly from his forehead. "You're going to worry all weekend, aren't you?"

He gave her a lazy smile that made her blood run hot and fast. "It depends. You could help distract me."

"By reviewing strategies for the promotional day?" she asked innocently as she tilted her chin, bringing her face closer to his.

"I can think of much better ways," he murmured as his lips met hers.

All Kit's thoughts centered on Grey—his taste, his touch, and the hope that this time the risk of losing

her heart was worth taking...because this time she'd found a man worthy of her trust.

***

Kit swiped the sweat from her brow Sunday afternoon as she dug into the warm earth in front of Grey's house. Making the hole larger, she dumped the pot with a combination of buds and blooms of bright yellow mums into her hand and plopped the molded earth into the spot she'd chosen. The mums would give Grey's yard some color for the rest of the summer and bloom again year after year.

The drone of Grey's mower in the back yard stopped and Kit felt a knot tighten in her stomach. She had something to tell Grey, a decision she'd made. She didn't know why she was nervous about it. After all, it was her decision. But it could start another disagreement, maybe an argument...

So she'd see if Grey's theory was right—that they could disagree without creating distance. Thinking back on her relationship with Trent, she realized they'd never argued. Why? Because Trent had always seemed to say and do the right thing, the appropriate thing, whatever would please Kit or make her happy. So she thought. Little did she know that behind her back he was manipulating, maneuvering, defrauding.

With Grey, everything was out front, above-board. She liked that about him. She couldn't be involved with anyone who wasn't honest and forthright. Never again.

So disagreement or not...

Grey came around the side of the house. Kit recognized her pulse speeding up, recognized the way every nerve in her body responded to Grey's appearance, his presence in her life.

His navy tank top molded to his chest and back from the honest sweat of yard work. He'd run his fingers through his hair to swipe it from his brow, leaving it ruffled. His legs were darkly tanned, his cut-offs frayed white against his thighs. She remembered his arms tight around her, his lips —hot and sensual —on hers. Not only her mind remembered; her body remembered. Her breasts ached to push against his chest, her fingertips tingled at the thought of stroking his face, heat curled in her womb ready to melt as he touched her. She'd never had such erotic thoughts until she'd met Grey. They were exciting, and surprising, and scary because they grew stronger each time she was with him.

Turning away from him and taking a gulping breath, she patted the ground around the mum, letting the earth squeeze through her fingers.

His shadow fell over Kit, shading her from the sun. "They look terrific. It's amazing the difference color makes. The house looks more welcoming."

"We should plant tulips, crocuses, maybe some daffodils, then in the spring you'll have color, too. It doesn't take long to plant bulbs and..." She lost her voice as well as her train of thought when Grey knelt beside her and covered her hand with his.

His voice held a husky edge as he asked, "Why don't you wear gloves when you garden?"

Although his hand on hers made her more aware of his skin texture, his heat, his scent, she managed a smile. "Because I like the feel of the dirt sifting through my fingers. I guess I didn't make enough mud pies as a kid."

He edged closer and brushed her cheek with his thumb.

Self-consciously, she swiped at the spot after him. "I guess I wear my pies well."

"You wear everything well." His gaze roamed to the V of her T-shirt where beads of perspiration had gathered. It was clinging to her like his was. She knew he could see the outline of her bra and maybe even her nipples which now felt hard from Grey's inspection.

When he reached out to her, Kit's breath caught. He ridged his finger along her neckline, tracing the V, causing shivers to skip up and down her back. "Grey..."

His touch teased the point above her bra. Slipping his finger under the edge of her shirt, he pulled her to him. Their sun-dewed skin met, their bodies melded together. Grey didn't hesitate to part her lips and dip inside. Kit's hands went to Grey's neck and her thumbs stroked his jaw. He groaned and deepened the

kiss, searching for more, asking for more, taking more.

She gave back the desire, increased it with forays of her own. In the distance, she heard a bee buzz, birds chirping, a car door slam. But the sounds meant nothing, only intensified her awareness of her heartbeat and Grey's. Her nipples rubbed his chest and the damp heat created a delicious friction. Warm earth, fresh-mown grass, Grey's male scent tantalized her nose.

Suddenly, Grey broke off the kiss.

Kit opened her eyes.

He grimaced. "Much more of that and the neighbors will get a real show."

His chest was rising and falling as fast as hers. It was getting more difficult to kiss him and not want a lot more. But she wasn't ready for more yet, and he seemed to sense that. "Grey, we have to talk about something."

"Maybe we're ready to do more than kiss?"

"Uh, no. Not exactly. I mean...Maybe we should wait until we go inside. To talk, I mean."

"What's wrong, Kit? You've been mulling something over all day. Is it Deedee?"

"No. It's...Trent."

Grey blew out a breath and sat on the ground, pulling her down beside him. "What's going on?"

Crossing her legs under her, she watched his expression carefully. Lines had already appeared around his mouth and his not-quite-frown was indicative of his thoughts about the subject. "I received a letter."

"From Higgins?" Grey asked with gruff vehemence.

She nodded and told him what the correspondence said. His frown became a scowl. "You're not going, of course."

That conclusion summed it up for Grey but not for her. "At first, I wanted to dismiss the idea." Before Grey could voice the disapproval arching in his brows, she went on, "But I had lunch with the woman who called me. Remember the day you came to the apartment with the ladder?"

His expression gentled. "I remember very well."

Instead of getting lost in his eyes and the feeling of excitement that had swirled inside her since the moment she'd met him, she concentrated on the subject at hand. "She and I talked for a long time. She has so many regrets, and guilt, and shame. Much of that left for me when I pressed charges. But I realized something's still unfinished. I haven't spoken to Trent since he left with my credit card one afternoon. During the trial, I wanted to wring his neck, not talk to him. I think I need to tell him exactly how much he hurt me, let alone my credit rating."

"You could send him a letter."

She met Grey's gaze and didn't shift away from the disapproval in his eyes. "I need to do it face to face."

He shook his head. "You haven't thought this through. Why put yourself through that? Driving to New York,

"I was hoping you'd understand."

"I think I understand too well."

His undertone made her wary. "I have to finish this, Grey."

"Finish it, or stir up old feelings?"

Anger at his implication bubbled up and spilled over. "I wouldn't be here at your house, planting flowers in your garden if I wanted to stir up old feelings!"

"I'm calling it as I see it, Kit. You always talk about the man by his first name. I don't hear bitterness or hatred in your voice when you mention him. There's almost fond remembrance. How do you explain that?"

Scrambling to her feet, she brushed off her hands and picked up the gardening tools. "I'm through the bitterness and hatred. Thank God. I got justice, in my way. But I did have feelings for the man. It might

have been an act, I still don't know, but he made me feel special. Yes, he was a con man. But we had some good times. And he was always gentle and considerate."

"Real considerate. He had two wives in another state," Grey muttered, coming to his feet.

"I realize what Trent Higgins is, Grey. He's a thief. More than the money he stole from me, he stole my ability to trust. That's what I want back. I don't think we can go any farther in our relationship until I get it back."

"If visiting Trent Higgins is the only way you can get it back, I have to wonder what we have. Our relationship should depend on me and you, not a con man who's still looking out for his own skin."

She'd expected Grey's anger, but it proved her point. With a disagreement, somebody had to win and somebody had to lose. They were at an impasse. "I'm going to get my things together and go."

Grey's shoulders straightened, his arms went rigid at his sides. "We're not finished discussing this."

"There's nothing to discuss. I'm going to see Trent. If you don't approve, you don't approve. But I can't live my life to earn your approval."

As she took a step toward the front door, he clasped her wrist and pulled her up against him. The sun beat down on her head as her knees went weak and all she wanted was to feel close to him again.

"You're running, Kit. You're putting up obstacles."

"No. I'm trying to tear down obstacles. You said we could respect each other's opinions even when we don't agree. Are you respecting my opinion?"

He abruptly let her go. "I respect your opinion, but I think you're making a mistake."

After a palpable silence, she asked, "So what now?"

He studied her eyes, her mouth, her lips. "I get a shower, you wash up, and we both think about the situation. Then we decide if we want to go play miniature golf or go to the movies." He lifted her chin and winked. "Or we can forget golf and the movies and you can get a shower with me."

He wasn't closing her out, or letting her go, or pushing her away, despite their differing opinions. Her heart felt light and hopeful. Maybe Grey was right. Maybe a disagreement didn't have to put up a wall between them.

"An air-conditioned theater and a tub of popcorn sound good."

He slung his arm around her shoulders and guided her toward the house, mumbling, "I didn't think you'd go for the shower."

They heard the beep of Grey's cell phone before Grey opened the door. Taking his arm from around Kit, he strode into the kitchen and plucked it off the counter. He paled a bit, then his expression turned grim. Kit's heart beat faster.

He said into his phone, "I'll be there as soon as I can." Clicking it closed, he turned to Kit. "Deedee had an accident while she was hiking and I have to pick her up. She's at the hospital in Gettysburg with her arm in a sling. Jenny said she's all right otherwise, but I'll believe it when I see it. She also gave Jenny a message. She wants me to bring you along. I have to get my keys and wallet upstairs, then we can go." He didn't give Kit another glance as he went up the stairs.

This is what Grey had expected to happen. Would he blame her for encouraging the trip?

CHAPTER EIGHT

Kit didn't attempt to make conversation as Grey drove to Gettysburg. She could imagine what was running through his mind. What kind of situation had Deedee gotten herself into? Was someone with her when the accident happened? If so, how did it happen?

Kit examined her advice to Grey, to let Deedee try her wings. Should she have kept her opinion to herself? Even though Deedee had asked for her to come along, should she butt out altogether where Deedee was concerned? She wasn't sure she could do that.

The hospital's emergency room was relatively quiet for a summer Sunday afternoon. Jenny had been watching for them. She backed up a step when Grey approached her. His expression was forbidding and demanded answers.

"I'm sorry, Mr. Corey," the freckled, red-head stammered. "It wasn't anybody's fault. We were hiking down a hill and Deedee slipped."

"Where is she?" he asked in a clipped tone.

"I'll take you back. They were waiting until you came and signed all the papers before they gave her anything."

His mouth drew tighter.

A nurse met them at the door to the examining area. After Grey introduced himself, she guided him toward a curtained cubicle.

Deedee lay on a gurney propped on two pillows. She looked worried. Evading Grey, her gaze locked to Kit's. "You came!"

"Sure, I did. Grey said you asked for me. How are you doing?"

"I'm fine." Finally, she looked at her brother under lowered lashes. "Are you mad?"

He went straight to Deedee and gave her a hug. "I'm not mad at you, honey. Do you hurt much?"

She shrugged, pushing down the sheet and showing him her arm which was tied in a sling. Making a face, she said, "I don't want any medicine."

Grey patted her hand. "I'm going to find the doctor."

"I've got to get going," Jenny mumbled.

"I'll keep Deedee company while you're talking to her doctor," Kit offered.

With a look that said, Don't get into any trouble, Grey ushered Jenny out.

Deedee looked at Kit and sighed. "I didn't mean to fall."

Kit sat in the vinyl chair next to the bed. "What happened?"

Deedee's eyes lit up. "We climbed up this big hill all the way to the top! I did it just like everyone else. But then we had to go down the other side. I stepped on some rocks and they moved... Is Grey mad at you? Because you said it was okay for me to go?"

Kit knew Deedee would know the truth from a lie. "I don't know. He's worried about you."

"He always worries about me."

"He loves you," Kit said softly.

Deedee wrinkled her nose. "I know."

Grey pushed open the curtain, a prescription in his hand. "We can go. The doctor said to keep your arm in a sling two days, then try it without. He says you wrenched your elbow." He lifted the prescription.

"I'll get this filled at the pharmacy. If your arm hurts too much, he wants you to take one."

Deedee frowned. "It doesn't hurt that much. I guess we have to tell Tanya what happened."

Grey nodded. "I'll explain."

"I can tell her myself," Deedee protested.

Grey gave his sister a long look. "Do you need help getting dressed?"

"Maybe to get my shirt on. But Kit can help me."

Grey's brows arched. "I'll go to the pharmacy then sit in the waiting room."

Kit glanced at Grey, but he was already gone. Deedee was asserting her independence more and more. It would take Grey some time for him to get used to it. Apparently Deedee had changed her attitude toward Kit, feeling she was on her side. They might even become friends. If Grey let them. If Grey didn't blame her for this accident. Life was never simple.

Deedee chattered during the ride to Meadeville, talking about her experiences cooking over the campfire, attending a square dance at the campground's pavilion, sleeping in a tent. She'd obviously enjoyed herself. Despite her accident, the trip had been good for her.

Before Deedee opened the car door, she asked Kit, "Can you come in and see Star?"

Kit glanced at Grey, then back at his sister. "Are you sure it's okay?"

"Yeah," Deedee answered. "Sunday's real loose. Everybody's probably playing ball or something."

Kit went with Deedee to find her kitten as Grey spoke with Tanya, and she wished she knew what he was thinking. Or better yet, what he was feeling.

In a family-room type atmosphere, Kit and Deedee threw a ball fashioned of tinfoil for Star to play with until Grey came into the room and said, "Deedee, we're going to leave now. How are you feeling?"

"It hurts when I move."

He came over to the sofa and sat beside her. "Then sit still tonight and watch TV. And take a pill if it hurts too badly."

"Maybe I will and maybe I won't," she said, lifting her chin stubbornly.

Kit suppressed a smile. Deedee was asserting her independence big-time.

As Grey gave his sister a good-bye hug, Deedee said to him, "Accidents happen to everyone, Grey."

He leaned back then kissed her forehead. "I guess they do. I'll call you tomorrow."

Kit gave Star a final pat on the head and rose from the floor. When she did, Deedee gave her a hug. Tears welled up in Kit's eyes as she squeezed back. "Take care of yourself."

Deedee smiled. "I will."

Kit followed Grey to the front door. Once outside, he took her elbow and asked, "Would you like to take a walk?"

Kit looked up and down the tree-lined residential street, felt the warm breeze lift her hair and fan it against her cheek. "A walk would be nice."

They strolled down the path to the sidewalk and Grey motioned to the right. Kit walked beside him, wishing he'd touch her again, wishing for some connection between them. There was only one way to get it back and that was to clear the air. "You're blaming me for Deedee's accident, aren't you?"

"I did. For a short time. Because you encouraged her. You nudged me. But then I blamed myself for letting her go. I should have made the right decision no matter what anyone else said."

"But you did make the right decision. Can't you see—?"

He chuckled and held her by the shoulders. "I can always count on you to tell me exactly what you're thinking."

"I wish you'd tell me what you're thinking. I thought you were angry. I thought you'd tell me to butt out. I thought—"

He pulled her into his arms and covered her mouth with his. He took control swiftly, sweeping her mouth, demanding a response, exciting her in the way only he could. Melting in his arms, she ran her

fingers through his hair. His hands stroked down her back and cupped her bottom, pressing her even closer. She gasped from the sheer pleasure of his arousal against her. She wanted him desperately, but was still afraid of the consequences of getting even closer.

Grey took her upper lip between his teeth, gently nipping, then slowly set her away. "I was worried, upset, but not with you. And after I talked to Deedee and heard how much fun she had, I realized she is changing. In a good way. And I'll have to learn to accept it."

Kit smiled and took his jaw between her hands. "You're a very insightful man."

He grimaced. "Sometimes it takes a while. But I do know there's one subject I am insightful about. Trent Higgins. Have you decided what you're going to do?"

She dropped her hands from his face. "I'm going by to go see him."

Grey's expression hardened, his jaw tightened. "All right. But let me go with you."

"No. There's no reason for you to go along. I fight my own battles, Grey. I want to finish this, once and for all."

He took her chin in his hand. "How far do you want our relationship to go?"

She felt panic rising in her chest—trusting, risking, giving part of herself away. How far was she willing to go? Right now, she only had one answer. "I don't know."

He dropped his hand to his side. "You don't trust me yet."

"I'm trying."

"It's not a matter of trying. You either trust or you don't."

"It's not that simple."

"Then take a step. Let me go with you to see Higgins." His voice gentled. "We could drive up on Saturday, go somewhere nice for dinner, stay overnight."

Her legs suddenly felt weak again and her heart raced as she thought about going out of town with Grey, being alone with him. "In a motel," she said almost to herself.

He pushed her hair behind her ear and kept her gaze locked to his. "We'll get two rooms. Then we'll play it by ear. We might decide to just use one of them."

He was serious and she was scared. But it might be time to make a decision about more than a motel room. It might be time to take the risk to love again.

***

The following Saturday evening after dinner, Grey walked Kit down the hall to her motel room. She'd been quiet on the drive to New York, but at least she'd agreed to let him come along. That was progress. She was so damned self-sufficient, independent, and because of Trent Higgins, wary. Grey found he wanted more and more of her—her smiles, her kisses, her thoughts, her time. And she gave freely, but only so far. There was a wall there he wanted to penetrate. Maybe this trip would do it. Maybe tonight would do it.

They stopped outside her door. "Are you going to invite me in?" he asked. I thought we could watch a movie." Actually, he had a lot more than a movie in mind. Dim lights, a turned down bed...

He felt freer now. Deedee seemed to be coming around. She'd asked for Kit after her accident for a reason—she felt she had an ally. Kit stoked the relationship with his sister with gentleness and caring, never patronizing, always trying to understand. So Deedee was no longer a roadblock. He wanted to take his relationship with Kit to the next level, a physical Foman to unders level. But trust was still a problem for her. He could see it in her eyes, feel it in the way she responded freely, then suddenly put on the brakes.

"I don't know if your coming in is a good idea," Kit said, her gaze not quite meeting his.

The letter from Higgins had increased Kit's wariness and her hesitation. Grey wasn't sure where her doubts were seated or exactly what she was thinking, but suspected Higgins still had an emotional hold on

her. And if she was still susceptible...

This visit was a damn mistake and he was going to make sure it didn't become more of a mistake. "What are the visiting hours tomorrow?"

"Ten to five. I thought I'd go over after breakfast."

"You mean we, don't you?"

"No, I don't. I'm going alone, Grey."

His anger fought with his concern for her. "That's not a good idea. I came along to support you and that's what I'm going to do."

"Support me? I didn't ask you to come along to hold my hand. In fact, I didn't ask you to come along at all. It was your idea. I agreed because the trip gave us time to be together."

"You're not going to that prison alone."

Kit squared her shoulders. "Oh, yes, I am."

"Be reasonable."

"I'm being perfectly reasonable. This is my unfinished business, not yours. I'm a big girl, Grey. I take care of myself."

"Sure. Real well. That's how you got mixed up with Higgins in the first place."

Kit looked stunned for a moment, and he knew immediately he'd said the wrong thing. Hurt flickered in her eyes right before they became glacial blue.

She took her key from her purse and opened her door. Then she turned to him and said, "You can forget the movie, and anything else you had in mind. I don't appreciate you telling me what to do, or insinuating that I'm not intelligent enough or wise enough to make my own decisions."

"Kit—"

"I'll see you tomorrow. After I see Trent. Good night."

He wouldn't let her walk away that easily. He wouldn't let her build a wall he couldn't tear down. Before the door could shut in his face, he followed her inside and tugged her into his arms. Without giving her a chance to resist, he kissed her, hard and fast and demanding more than a good-night kiss at the door.

He wanted to tell her so many things—that he appreciated her beauty, admired her intelligence and courage, and that he wanted more than one night in her bed. But words seemed to have no place as need and hunger took precedence. Lacing his hands in Kit's hair, he drove his tongue into her mouth and caressed her back, drawing her tighter against him. When she moaned, he hoped she was as lost as he was. But he had to make sure.

Tearing away, he held her head between his hands. "I only want this if you do, too. If you want me to walk away, tell me now."

Kit searched his face, then reached up and wrapped her arms around his neck. "I don't want you to walk away. I want you to make love to me."

That was all he needed to hear.

With a shrug, he was out of his suit coat. As he unzipped her dress, she tugged down his tie and unfastened his shirt buttons. Undressing was a means to an end. Necessary foreplay. But Grey knew if he became any more aroused, they'd be finished before they started. At least he would be.

As he skimmed her panties down her long legs, he sucked in a breath. Kit took hold of the waistband of his briefs and gave them a tug. He gripped her hands with his. "I want you, Kit."

She smiled up at him. "Then what are we waiting for?"

Her honest desire made any awkwardness vanish. After he stepped out of his briefs, he scooped her into his arms and held her close to him. His lips sought hers and he carried her to the king-size bed, never breaking the kiss.

When he laid her down, she reached for him.

He held himself above her. "You have to be ready."

"I am," she said softly.

After stroking her thigh, he touched her intimately and found she was ready. Calling on every vestige of restraint, he slowly entered her, watching her face. She sighed, raised her knees, and gripped him tighter.

"Kit, I don't know how long I—"

She stroked his jaw. "You worry too much. The first time doesn't have to be the only time."

Her words pushed him over the edge of control. He thrust into her and with her moan of pleasure, retreated then thrust again.

Kit moved with him, encouraged him, met every drive with her own need. Until the look in her eyes told him she was on the verge of the same precipice he'd climbed with her and was ready to tumble over the peak.

His last thrust was the most powerful, his release intense as Kit cried his name. When he collapsed beside her, he held her tight, never wanting to let her go.

***

Kit awakened all warm and cuddly and feeling more protected than she'd ever felt in her life with Grey's arm around her. Last night had been...

There were no words for it. After the first time, they'd used protection. She'd brought some and so had Grey. They'd had the same thing on their mind, but Trent Higgins had almost gotten in the way of what they both wanted.

Or Grey's fierce protective streak had. And she still had to deal with that this morning. But after last night, after such soul-close moments, wouldn't he understand what she had to do?

She was curved against Grey's side and suddenly she realized his arm didn't feel protective as much as seductive. His hand moved closer to her breast. Lifting her head, she saw he was awake, too.

"Hi, there."

His hair was mussed, his beard dark, and he looked even more sexy this morning than he had last night. "Hi, yourself."

"How do you feel?"

She wasn't sure exactly what he was asking, but it didn't matter. "I feel wonderful. How about you?"

"Like I'm ready to begin last night all over again. Slower, in the light, taking our time, not racing as if we'd never hold each other again."

"Grey, everything about last night was terrific. I wouldn't change a thing."

His smile was crooked. "We don't have to change anything. But we could add to it." Abruptly he frowned. "There is something we might want to change. The first time. I should have been more prepared. If you get pregnant..."

"I won't. This is my safe time."

"Still, if you are pregnant, you know I'll support you. In fact..."

She pressed her fingers to his lips. "Let's just take this one step at a time. Neither of us are ready for promises or more than today."

The expression on his face said he might not agree. But before he could argue, she stroked her hand down his thigh. "Besides, we have much better things to do than talk."

Grey apparently agreed because his hand slipped to her breast and teased it into high awareness of his intent. She waited and waited while he circled her nipple, coming close but never touching it. Restlessly, she stroked his thigh higher, trying to tell him with her touch that she wanted much more.

"Slowly, Kit. This morning, we go slow."

He chuckled when she gave a soft moan. If he wanted slow, she'd give him slow. Sensuous torture that would definitely speed up the process.

Propping on her elbow, she said in a sultry voice, "All right. How about I start with you?"

"Be my guest."

With entirely wicked intent, she arranged herself by his side, her breast teasing his chest, her foot caressing his calf. She saw his eyes darken and she knew she was getting to him. When her fingertips tauntingly teased the outer circle of his dark nipple, his arousal became complete and beads of sweat dotted his forehead.

"Is this slow enough?" she asked ingenuously.

"Just right," he managed.

She brought her lips to his nipple.

When her tongue slipped out to taste it, he ran his hand through her hair and tugged. "Kit..."

"I've just begun," she said coyly, licking, tickling, and finally gently biting. He drew in a breath and when she glanced up at his face, she saw he didn't know whether to stop her or urge her on.

She removed her tongue from the nipple and replaced it with her teasing fingers. Then she kissed down his chest, skimming her hand through his chest hair, moving lower and lower. His muscles tightened and she knew she had power over him. It excited her as much as she was exciting him.

Down, down, down, she kissed until Grey gripped her shoulder. "No."

She lifted her head, stroked him gently and defied him. "Yes."

Before he could move a muscle, before he'd want to move a muscle, she loved him in the most intimate way possible with her tongue, with her lips, with everything she was.

Grey only permitted her loving for a short time, then he rolled her over. "You're a witch. And now I'm going to do to you what you've been doing to me."

He kissed her at the same time he kneaded her breast. His tongue left her stroking against him, meeting his hunger with hers. When he moved to her breast, her breathing became shallow and she bit her lower lip to keep from crying out. As he moved lower, she knew he wouldn't stop at her navel. When his lips touched her as intimately as she'd touched him, her body glistened with desire, her muscles tensing, growing tighter and tighter, until suddenly she felt herself burst apart into sparks and tingles and breathlessness.

Tears came to her eyes and she knew she'd never experienced anything so wonderful. Grey prepared himself, rose on his elbows, joined his body with hers, and brought her to the top of the mountain again. Her second orgasm hit at the same time as his, and she clung to him, clung to the closeness they'd shared.

A few minutes later, Grey shifted to his side and nestled her beside him. She could feel his breathing slow as hers did the same. His voice was gruff when he asked, "Did you ever do that to any other man?"

His question shocked her, yet brought all of her love for him to the surface. "No. Have you ever loved another woman that way?"

"No."

She sighed, wondering what he was thinking, afraid she knew. "You're thinking about Trent, aren't you?"

"You bet I am," he said curtly.

"Why now?"

"Because you loved him. Because in a little while you'll be seeing him."

"Grey, you've got to understand my feelings for him are over."

He lifted her chin so her gaze met his. "Then, don't go."

"I have to. And I have to go alone."

"Dammit, Kit—"

She'd explained over and over again. If he didn't understand, explaining once more wouldn't help. She disentangled herself from him and slid out of bed. "I have to get a shower. And then I'm leaving for the prison. You're welcome to stay...you could shower with me," she tacked on hopefully.

Avoiding her gaze, he dropped his legs over the side of the bed. "I'll get some breakfast then wait in the lobby." Reaching into his trouser pocket, he found his car keys and tossed them on the bed. "I'll be ready to leave when you are."

With that, he stood and quickly dressed in his clothes from the night before. He didn't kiss her. He didn't wish her good luck. He just walked out the door.

***

The guard locked Kit's pocketbook in a locker. Passing through the metal detector, she told herself this was no different than going through security at an airport. Looking around, she wondered if Trent Higgins had changed, being in this place. If he'd realized he couldn't use people and get away with it.

She saw him almost immediately, propped casually against the wall scanning the visitors entering the room. He looked as benevolent and charming as ever, if a man could look charming in prison garb. His sandy hair dipped over his brow and his blue eyes twinkled at Kit as she walked up to him.

Pushing away from the cement blocks, he stood quietly before her and said, "I got the message you were coming. Thank you."

Always the gentleman. She didn't feel much like a lady. Her nerves over this meeting had added to the tension with Grey. Of course other things had too–the idea of loving again, committing herself to a man which meant trusting him. She'd done tons of thinking on the drive over. It wasn't just a matter of her trusting Grey. She wasn't so sure Grey trusted her. If he did, he wouldn't have been so adamant about coming with her. What did he think she was going to do? Fall into Trent Higgins arms? A con man who'd betrayed her?

She was old enough to know that proverbial leopards didn't change their spots. And she wasn't naive enough to believe that Trent Higgins cared one whit about her. He cared about what she could do for him.

He motioned to two chairs. "We can stay in here or sit outside, if you'd like."

She nodded toward the chairs. This wasn't a social visit, it was an exercise in determination to give her peace of mind. Once seated, she gripped the arms of her chair.

"I'm glad you decided to see me. I truly did care for you Kit. I still do. I thought if you'd start visiting me every month or so, we could regain..."

"What do you want from me, Trent? Why the letter?"

He reached for her hand. "I remember the time we spent together, the plans that we made. Unfortunately I fell in love with you when I was in the process of a divorce. I needed money as much as freedom and I got sucked in to the wrong business deals."

"What about your first wife? You never divorced her to marry your second. Was I going to be number three?"

"I was trying to straighten it all out. I didn't expect you to come along. I didn't expect to fall in love again."

What had been wrong with her three years ago? Why hadn't she seen the insincerity? How could she have believed his lies?

"And the women you dated while we were engaged?" She hadn't found out about them until the trial. He'd done more than date them. Had she been so involved in her work she hadn't noticed the time they'd spent apart? Or had she just wanted to believe so badly that true love was possible? That a man could be flattering and agreeable and say all the right words when she needed to hear them?

"Give me the bottom line, Trent. Why did you write to me?"

"I just told you..." When her expression didn't soften and her determination to get to the truth didn't waver, he sighed heavily. "I have to get a new lawyer and that's hard to do from in here. I thought maybe you could check around and find someone who could get me paroled sooner."

She absolutely could not believe the arrogance of the man. "Certainly you can get access to names and

addresses of lawyers and write to them yourself."

"They can toss letters aside." His gaze drifted over her with an appreciative glimmer. "You standing in their office would be another matter."

That was it. She'd held her temper as long as manageable. "I won't be standing in anyone's office on your behalf. I came here today for one reason—to tell you how much you hurt me. I trusted you. I depended on you to be the man you said you were."

"Look, Kit, everything just happened. I never meant..."

"I don't know what you did mean and what you didn't. I gave you my heart and believed in your promises. You trampled on me. You took my faith in men and shattered it."

"Don't get so melodramatic. Everyone gets taken. And it's not like I didn't care about you—"

"Care? You don't know what the word means. There's a man in my life now who I want to trust. But I'm scared to death he'll hurt me, too."

"Kit, I'll pay the money back."

Probably another promise that would never come to fruition. "You still don't get it. It wasn't the money. Yes, I had a tough two years paying off your debts, getting back credit, building another basis for financial security. But money comes and goes. Faith, trust, and loyalty don't. You stole more than my money. You stole the deepest part of me that believed in love."

She stood. "But I'm going to find that again, too. Just as I paid off your debts, just as I'm finally getting on my feet again, I'm learning to trust. I found someone who knows how to truly care, not because he'll benefit, but because that's the kind of man he is. He doesn't always say what I want to hear because he's honest. If you ever want a life again, Trent, you'd better figure out how to be honest, not only with others, but with yourself."

Suddenly she realized how much better she felt! The weight that had laid over her heart was gone. She felt free. And she wanted to see Grey. She wanted to give him her trust and hope he could give her his. Trent Higgins simply didn't matter anymore.

She left Trent Higgins in the prison where he belonged and went out into the sunlight, hoping trust in Grey would grow along with her love.

***

In the lobby of the hotel, Grey flipped through the pages of a magazine, not absorbing the glossy images. He shouldn't have walked out like that. He should have told her he'd discovered.

But he hadn't. He'd thrown her the keys, still angry she wouldn't let him go with her. Couldn't she see that he wanted to...

The thought bit the dust as the lobby doors opened and Kit stepped inside. She looked like a sunbeam in her yellow slacks and top, her blond hair shining with reflected light beaming in the glass doors. Spotting him, she walked toward him, a tentative smile on her lips.

Standing, he shoved his hands into his shorts' pockets so he didn't yank her into his arms and kiss her until she forgot all about Higgins. "How did it go?" His voice came out more brusque than he intended.

She looked nervous for a moment, and that was so unlike her. Uncustomary fear wrapped around Grey's heart until she said, "He'll never stop trying to manipulate and con. I can't believe I didn't see it when we were together."

"You weren't looking for it," Grey said quietly. Then he asked the question uppermost in his mind. "Is it over?"

Kit stepped closer, so close her perfume became part of the air, and her heat mingled with his. "It's over. When I told him how he'd hurt me, what I'd felt, what I feel, it was like I was free again."

He tenderly traced his finger over her bottom lip and felt her tremble. "What does that mean for us?"

She kissed the tip of his finger, then took a deep breath. "It means I'm going to stop being afraid. But it

also means you have to trust me as much as you want me to trust you."

"I do."

She shook her head. "If you trusted me, you wouldn't have been so anxious about this visit with Trent. You would have trusted the feelings between us."

Her conclusion stopped him cold. Could she be right? Was the jealousy simply a lack of trust?

"Grey, you can't protect me like you try to protect Deedee. You have to trust my ability to follow my instincts, to make my own judgments, to tell you the truth about how I feel. I'll feel smothered and trapped and devalued if you don't."

His gut told him she was right. His head told him that Kit could never be anything but an equal. "Old habits die hard. I'm used to protecting and safeguarding the people I care about." He couldn't quite say the word "love" yet. Maybe because it was such a serious word and carried a world of feelings and responsibility with it. When he said it, he needed to be sure they could have a future together.

Kit wrapped her arms around him and laid her head on his chest.

Overwhelming need gripped Grey. Cupping her head in his palm, he bent his head and took her lips with the urgency of his pounding heart. He swept her mouth with his tongue, thankful he'd found a woman like her—strong, compassionate, loving. Soon...he could tell her what was in his heart. Soon...they'd trust each other as they needed to in order to forge a future together.

CHAPTER NINE

Monday evening, Grey followed the walk to Kit's back door, wondering if either of them were really ready for the next step. She'd been quiet on the drive home, but so had he. She'd said Trent Higgins was now the past. Was she free to trust? To love?

Not only his relationship with Kit was on his mind tonight. He'd received a visit after lunch from Red Bucket's representative. The corporation had upped the ante. Their new offer was nothing to sneeze at. If he took it, he could invest the money for Deedee's future and still make a salary that was more than comfortable. For a couple. For a family. He was definitely thinking about the next step.

Yet, if he accepted Red Bucket's offer, he'd no longer own the store. He'd be a manager, and he'd have to listen and abide by the rules and regulations of the parent company. His time wouldn't be his own, any more than the store or the products he'd sell.

For a moment, he looked at the blue sky with the clouds floating lazily along an invisible pathway. Pop, what would you think of Red Bucket owning your store?

The answer came in words Grey had often heard from his father. You need to be your own boss, son. You make the decisions and call the shots. It's the only way to run a business.

Grey knew it wasn't the only way, but it was the right way for him. It made him proud that through Kit's help Corey's Hardware could carry on the tradition his grandfather had started. He did not want to sell the store. He didn't want to be a link in a chain.

Hearing singing coming from the kitchen, Grey smiled and climbed Kit's back porch steps. He rapped, but she didn't hear. As he opened the door, he could see her standing at the sink in a white blouse and flowered skirt, singing her heart out as she washed vegetables. She was so beautiful, so alive, and had become such a major part of his life. He stepped up behind her and wrapped his arms around her.

She gave a yelp. "Grey, you scared me half to death."

His reply was a soft nuzzle on her neck.

She sighed, saying, "But I think I'll forgive you."

Brushing her hair aside, he explored the area below her ear. When he teased her earlobe with his tongue, she melted against him, and he knew she could feel his arousal. Gently, he lifted his head and turned her around in his arms. "Maybe we could skip supper," he said with a husky catch in his voice.

She wove her fingers into his hair and lifted her face for his kiss. When he touched her, he forgot about the future and thought only about the moment. He couldn't believe his need for Kit hadn't diminished in any measure. Breaking the kiss, he held her face in his hands. "I think you cast a spell over me."

"What kind of spell?"

"The kind that made me wish I hadn't dropped you off last night."

"But you wanted to spend some time with Deedee."

"Um hmm. And I did. But I couldn't get to sleep thinking about exactly how you might look in a nightgown, how I'd like to enjoy the sight, then strip it off of you." He could see the desire in Kit's eyes growing brighter with his words.

"We could postpone supper and I could model one for you," she suggested quietly.

"A fantasy come true. How much luckier can a man get?" he breathed before his lips came down on hers again. His tongue breached her lips without waiting for her to open.

He couldn't taste enough of her sweetness. Her soft moans flamed his desire as much as the lingering scent of her perfume, the softness of her hair, the satin of her skin. His hands passed up and down her back, and when he ached for her so much it was painful, he cupped her bottom, bringing her softness to his hardness, not caring about nightgowns, or clothes, or food or drink. All he needed was Kit and her passion surrounding him.

She gasped when he lifted her up against him.

"Did I shock you?" he growled as he kissed her chin, her neck, her ear.

"No, I want you, too. But at this rate—"

Something in her voice alerted him that she wanted to stop...at least momentarily.

"What's wrong?" he asked, letting her slide to the floor.

"Nothing's wrong. But we should be prepared this time. We wouldn't want to tempt fate twice."

Wouldn't he? He could think of nothing he'd like better than to see Kit pregnant with his child. His child.

Yet how could he even consider it when they'd known each other such a short time...when he had Deedee to think about and her future as well as his.

"You're right. Unfortunately, my good sense flies out the window when I get anywhere close to you."

She gave him a bright smile, then took his hand and led him to the bedroom.

"Kit, this is a bad idea if I need to go to the drug store..."

Once inside the room, decorated in colors of the sunset, with a giant rainbow stretching across the spread, Kit went to a small bag on the long maple dresser. With a smile, she handed it to him.

Peeking inside, he grinned. It was a box of condoms. "Only one box?" he teased.

"Greyson Corey," she said in mock indignation, hands on her hips. "You're...you're..."

"Needing you," he filled in, hastily dropping the bag on the bed and pulling her into his arms again. "The hell with the nightgown," he murmured. "We'll save that for another time."

When he kissed her, the flames quickly licked at him again. Suddenly impatient with their clothes, he pulled her blouse from her skirt and found her warm skin. The problem was—this was one of those blouses with tiny buttons, and he groaned as he thought about how long it would take to unfasten each and every one.

With a deep breath, he backed away from her. Then he started on the top button, his gaze on hers. "I'm thinking of all the things I want to do with you, every place I'd like to kiss."

When his fingers fumbled with the third button, she asked, "Do you want me to do it?"

He shook his head. "No. I want to do the unveiling myself."

His knuckles brushed her breast and he felt her tremble. For him. With him. After he finished with the last button, he pushed the blouse from her shoulders, then unfastened her bra. When he nudged the straps from her shoulders, she let it fall to the floor.

He'd never needed a woman this much.

With her breathing, her breasts rose and fell and she stood perfectly still...waiting...anticipating as he was. His gaze caressed her as he let the moment stretch, adding to the excitement.

But he couldn't wait long.

He brought his lips to her nipple, gently laving it with his tongue.

"Oh, Grey."

He raised his head. "What?"

"I can't tell you how that makes me feel inside. It makes me realize I'm a woman in the deepest sense of the word."

He brought his lips to her.

She tugged his shirt with enough strength to make him lift his head. "Equal," she whispered. "I want us to be equal."

"Baby, we're going to be as equal as any two people can get," he growled as he let her lift his shirt over his head.

Once it flew to the floor beside her bra, she ran her hands feverishly over the whorls of hair on his chest, through them, then her nails grazed his nipples and the throbbing in his loins demanded satisfaction. He reached for the fastener on her skirt.

With her skirt puddled on the floor, he stared at the wisp of nylon covering the golden triangle of curls. When he thought about kissing her there...

He stripped her panties down her legs and touched her before she could kick them out of the way. She moaned when his fingers slipped up the sensitive skin of her inner thigh, teasing, stroking, tempting her to let him touch more. Leaning against the dresser, she closed her eyes.

But he wanted her eyes open. On him. "Watch me, Kit. Watch me give you pleasure."

When she opened her eyes again, he saw that she'd decided to accept the challenge.

Grey realized he didn't want her to forget who was touching her...who was giving her pleasure. It might be ridiculous, but he still felt jealous of Trent Higgins. If he had anything to say about it, he'd wipe every trace of the man from her mind and her memory.

Stroking her thighs slowly, Grey watched her blue eyes become hungrier...needier. She bit her lower lip as he caressed higher. The curls teased his fingers as much as he was teasing her. Finally, he ventured into the heart of her desire.

"Grey!"

"What, baby?"

"I want more," she said on a breathless sigh.

"So do I," he replied, feeling her moisture...her readiness. When he slipped inside, she gasped.

Bending, he kissed around her navel, always touching her, inflaming his need as he was inflaming hers. His lips nuzzled and wet her skin.

"Let me touch you," she finally pleaded. "Like you're touching me."

Just the thought of it made Grey strip off his clothes and come back to her in less than a moment. And when she curled her hand around him, he thought he'd explode.

"Kit..."

"Don't tell me to stop," she chided gently, as she ran her thumb over the velvet tip of his manhood, lingering there, making him crazy with wanting her.

But when she brushed down him again, his control snapped. Turning away from her, he reached for the bag on the bed.

His fingers fumbled with the packet. She took it from him and slid out the condom. With eager touches, gentle fingertips, and obvious desire to bring him pleasure, she prepared him, sliding the condom on slowly, driving him even wilder with need. The bed seemed too far away as he lifted her onto the dresser and spread her legs.

Surprise flashed in Kit's eyes, but when he plunged into her, she gripped him with her knees. He caught her gasp with a kiss that was as intense as their joining. Her tightness milked him as he thrust into her again and again, swiftly, smoothly, until they both glistened with sweat and quivered from the wave sweeping over them. The few bottles on the dresser jangled as Kit arched into him, clasping his backside, meeting him with an acceptance that fueled him on.

The crescendo built swiftly, catching them in its power, tossing them into its depth. Grey tore his mouth from hers just before the final burst. She cried out and his guttural groan answered her as they held each other with a strength coming from the passion they'd shared.

Propped against the dresser, he dropped his head to her shoulder and kissed it.

Still joined to him, she contracted around him, an aftershock that made him groan and want her all over again. Finally, he lifted her from the dresser and carried her to the bed. When he came down next to

her, she was smiling in a dazed way.

"I'm glad your dresser's practically empty," he admitted with a wry grin.

"I'll never spray on perfume again without remembering," she teased.

He cuddled her against him, pleased by her observation, wanting to make many more memories. Before he could put the thought into words, the phone by her bed rang.

She picked it up and checked the caller ID. "Maggie," she said. "I can let it go to voicemail–"

Grey shook his head. "Go ahead and take it. I don't mind."

Kit's body was still humming from the excitement of their lovemaking when she said, "Hi. What's going on?"

"Kit, I don't know what to do. Eric and I had a fight and..." Her sister's voice broke.

"What happened?" Kit prompted gently.

"We argued. He stormed out. I don't know where he is or if he's even coming home tonight. He's been gone for over an hour... Kit, he was so angry...this is the first fight we've had since we were married..." Tears broke her words again.

"Do you want me to come over?"

There was a slight hesitation. "No. I'll come to your place. Maybe you can help me sort it out. I'll be there in ten minutes."

As Kit replaced the receiver, Grey asked, "What's wrong?"

"Maggie and Eric had a fight. She's coming over. She didn't give me a chance to tell her you're here."

He took Kit in his arms and hugged her. "I'll leave when she gets here."

Wrapping her arms around his neck, she said, "You're a very understanding man."

"I know how important family is." Grey's green eyes drew her to him as potently as his words and she realized, better than anyone, he did understand about family. He seemed to understand everything that mattered. She couldn't be wrong about that, could she? He'd loved her so passionately... Would the doubts ever go away? Would she ever know she could trust him completely?

His lips were hot, persuasive, commanding. She opened hers and took him inside. When he groaned, he caressed her back with long strokes that pressed them close again. Her legs tangled with his. His kiss took her deeper and deeper into passion as his tongue searched and explored and teased her. She forgot the doubts. Almost.

Gently, with a teasing laugh, she pulled away, regretting the necessity of stopping before they could find satisfaction again. "I have to get dressed. Maggie will be here soon."

Grey suggested slyly, "Maybe I can just take a walk and after she leaves, you can model a nightgown."

Kit liked Grey here. She liked him in her life. She loved him. And the thought scared her to death.

They dressed together, glancing at each other, smiling often. Kit had just fastened her skirt when the doorbell rang. She said, "I'll let her in."

Combing her hair with her fingers, Kit called as she walked, "I'm coming."

When she opened the door, her sister saw Kit's flushed cheeks, her mussed hair, and a moment later Grey standing in the living room. "Am I interrupting something?"

Maggie's nose was red, her eyes overly bright. Kit put her arm around her. "No. Come on in."

"I was just leaving," Grey said as he moved tow N

"You don't have to go," Maggie said in a firm voice. "In fact, maybe you can explain the male psyche to me," she said waving her arm through the air. "I swear, you'd think Eric would know by now that something like this would upset me. I can't believe he did it."

"What happened?" Kit asked as she guided her sister to her new furniture which had finally arrived. Grey stood beside her inviting green and salmon-striped chair, not looking comfortable in the situation.

The words poured out of Maggie. "I told you Eric wants to move. He thinks we need a bigger house. I like our house. My office is perfect where it is, and my clients know where I am."

"You said you and Eric discussed it."

Maggie frowned. "We did. Without coming to a decision. I thought we'd stay where we are for another year, at least."

"So what happened?"

"Eric put a retainer on a house today!" her sister exploded. "Without me even seeing it. Without telling me first. Can you believe it?"

Kit knew Eric was a take-charge kind of guy. But he loved Maggie more than life and he would never do anything to purposefully hurt her. "What was his reasoning?"

"That's what I asked him and he got angry. He said he saw the perfect house for us so he did something about it. How does he know it's perfect when I didn't even see it! And why didn't he tell me he'd contacted a real estate agent?" She looked at Grey with confusion and hurt.

Running his hand over his chin, he looked even more uncomfortable than a few minutes before. "Maggie, I certainly can't tell you Eric's motives."

She looked annoyed. "I know that. But tell me what it is about men that they think their decisions are the right decisions. I would never even think of putting a down payment on something so big..." She covered her face with her hands. "Oh, darn."

Maggie had loosened up quite a bit since she'd married Eric. She'd been reserved all her life but Eric had released the vibrancy that had always bubbled below the surface. It was obvious that she was hurt by his unilateral decision. Kit saw a tear run down her sister's cheek and for once in her life, she wasn't sure what to say. She loved Maggie and she respected and had learned true affection for her brother-in-law.

Grey came closer and finally stopped at Maggie's chair. "I can't tell you what Eric was thinking, but anybody who looks at you two together can tell he thinks the sun rises and sets on you. He wouldn't do this to hurt you."

Maggie looked up, her eyes brimming with hurt. "He had to, I wouldn't like the idea. I don't want to move."

"Why?" Kit asked.

"I told you."

"But what's the real reason. If you're thinking about having a baby, if you're with Eric, what does it matter where you live?"

"But I decorated the house myself, and I've always been happy there. It's a symbol of...independence."

Kit patted her sister's arm. "Maybe that's the problem. Maybe it doesn't feel like home to Eric. Maybe it feels like yours, rather than a house that belongs to both of you."

"Then why did he pick one out on his own?" Maggie asked, her voice rising.

Grey said, "Maggie, men like to feel that they're taking care of the people they love. He probably didn't want somebody else to buy the house before you could see it. That can happen."

Kit suggested, "Maybe he thought this would give you a little nudge to at least get you looking. Let's face it, Sis, you can be somewhat inflexible at times."

Maggie didn't deny it. She looked at Grey. "So he might have done what he thought was best for me."

"Could be. Did he tell you anything about the house?"

"He said it was in a beautiful neighborhood with lots of trees. There's a nursery and a guest room, too. I think he said something about a winding staircase...I don't know. I guess I stopped listening because I was so upset he decided on his own."

The doorbell rang. Kit didn't need her sixth sense to know who was at her door. Giving Maggie her it-will-be-all-right look, she opened the front door.

Eric's face was drawn, his tie tugged down and hanging to one side. His gaze settled on his wife, and he didn't look away.

Kit moved to the side and said, "Come on in. I'll go get us something to drink." She glanced at Grey

and disappeared into the kitchen.

Before Grey could move to the kitchen, Maggie stood and went to her husband. "I'm sorry if I overreacted."

He enfolded her in his arms. "I should never have done it like that. I should have come to get you and taken you with me. But the real estate agent called me with the new listing..."

"I didn't even know you'd contacted a real estate agent."

Eric's face showed his consternation. "I know. I should have told you. I'm sorry, sweetheart. If you don't want to move, we won't move. Your happiness means everything to me. I went about this all wrong —"

Maggie pressed her fingers to his lips. "I know you're right about needing more space. If you want me to consider this house, I will."

He held her face in his hands. "We don't have to take it. I want you to understand that. It has to be what we both want."

Maggie nodded and Eric kissed her.

Grey felt like a voyeur. Would he and Kit ever share this kind of love? Would they be able to compromise, recognizing each other's needs? Respecting them? All his feelings for Kit had ambushed Grey until he had to be sure he was making the right decisions.

Would Kit be able to accept Deedee unconditionally as she needed to be accepted? Kit made love to him as if nothing else in the world mattered. Yet, did she want the same future he did?

He needed more time with her. They needed more time with Deedee—together. Then they could discuss where they were going, and how they wanted to get there. Unobserved by Maggie and Eric, Grey went to the kitchen. He'd ask Kit if she'd like to go to a baseball game.

With him and Deedee.

***

The Orioles were Deedee's favorite baseball team. Her baseball cards with stats of each player were one of her prized possessions. When Grey had asked Kit if she'd like to go to the game, she'd looked surprised but had agreed, saying, "I haven't been to Inner Harbor in a long time and I've never been to Camden Yards. It will be fun."

He'd looked for signs of hesitancy, of a hint if she was going just to please him. But he couldn't tell.

They decided to go on a weekday. She and Grey had worked until lunchtime, then they'd picked up Deedee and driven to Baltimore's Inner Harbor. Deedee was delighted by the sights and smells. Grey rented a paddleboat and he and Deedee peddled around the harbor while Kit spoke to the women at the information booth about tours, places to stay, and restaurants. Afterward, the three of them walked through the distinctive shops, dined on crab cake sandwiches, listened to a street performer strum his guitar as a juggler played to the bystanders. Deedee insisted she could walk the four blocks to the stadium so they left Grey's car in the parking garage.

Camden Yards was built like an old-fashioned stadium rather than the newer domed ones. The natural turf and open air bleachers brought back memories of baseball's origins. Grey had purchased box seats along third base from a customer who had season tickets for his family, but rarely attended week night games. Deedee sat, engrossed with the program and score card, until the game began. Then she concentrated on the players on the field.

Grey took Kit's hand, placing it on his knee.

"I always enjoy myself with you and Deedee."

Grey took Kit's hand and lifted it to his lips, kissing her palm. Goose bumps broke out on her arms and she murmured weakly, "Grey."

"I like to hear you say my name with that little tremor that means I'm getting to you," he whispered in

her ear.

"You'd better behave," she warned with a glance at Deedee, who was sitting beside her.

"Or what?" he taunted.

"Or...or...I'll let Gus draw the winning names out of the fishbowl at the promotional day on Saturday."

Grey laughed out loud, a deep rich rumble that Kit felt all the way to her toes. "Now, that's a threat if ever I heard one." He kept her hand imprisoned on his knee during the first inning, making small circles on the top of her hand, deliciously soothing the skin between her thumb and index finger until she wanted to kiss him right there on the spot. Between hot dogs, soft pretzels and soda, they watched the game, though Grey tenderly wiping mustard from her lip, brushing his shoulder against hers, and leaning across her to speak with Deedee, excited Kit much more than what was happening on the field.

The game heated up during the eighth inning. Both teams were tied at four runs. "Go, go, go," Deedee called as her favorite Oriole came up to bat.

He let the first one soar by. Strike.

The second one was a ball.

But the third... He hit it with a resounding thwack. Deedee yelled and cheered, standing and waving her hands in the air. She called the player's name over and over as he ran the bases, jumped up and down, and threw her fist into the air.

Her cap fell off her head into the lap of a woman sitting behind her. Unmindful of the loss, Deedee hugged both Kit and Grey joyously.

The woman behind them gingerly slid the cap onto Deedee's seat as she commented to the man beside her, "I can't see why a grown woman has to act that way. She should learn some decorum."

Judgmental people irked Kit. Especially when they had no knowledge of the situation or the people involved in it. Without hesitating, she faced the woman behind her who seemed to be in her fifties, put her hands on her hips, and lifted the bill of her baseball cap so she could have an unobstructed view. "A baseball game is a place to have fun, it's not high tea. If you want decorum, maybe you should find another past time."

Ignoring the woman's haughty "Well!" Kit put her arm around Deedee's shoulders and gave her a gentle squeeze.

Deedee looked at the woman behind them, then at Kit, and broke into a smile. "What's high tea? Is it like iced tea? Tanya doesn't let me put too much sugar in it."

Kit laughed and her gaze caught Grey's. "We'll have high tea some time and you can see for yourself."

Grey had no doubt that Kit's defense of Deedee was genuine. How much more time did he need to decide they could be a family?

None.

So there was only one thing left to do—ask Kit to marry him.

CHAPTER TEN

Saturday dawned clear and bright and balmy. Grey was amazed at the number of customers and onlookers standing in groups and milling about the parking lot of Corey's Hardware. Kit seemed to be ten places at once as she coordinated and supervised. Right now, she was standing at the radio station's mobile unit parked to the side of the store's front entrance. The sunlight glinted on her hair, transforming its shimmering golden strands. As she spoke to the announcer inside the van, the light caught her gold spiral earring.

Her fuchsia slacks and top enabled Grey to find her easily as she finished at the van and stopped for a moment at the group watching Zac Whittaker sculpt a beaver from a log. In the last few moments he'd finished with the chain saw and was now using a chisel. Kit stood in the interested circle a few minutes then strolled to the patio table and umbrella where Deedee poured punch.

Grey wanted to spend the rest of his life with Kit. He'd decided to ask her to marry him this evening, after their preoccupation with the promotional day was over, when they could concentrate on the two of them...for the rest of their lives.

The success of the ads and fliers bringing in a host of customers, the count of coupons from the website, the sales receipts buzzing out one after the other, were almost inconsequential at this point. As Kit beckoned to him to come to the raffle table outside the front entrance, he wanted to ask her to marry him, and nothing else seemed as important.

But when he reached the table, she said, "You should pull out the winning tickets. After all, you own the store."

"Hey, Corey," a man called from the back of the crowd. "I never seen so many people here. Maybe you should give out six trips instead of three!"

The crowd applauded.

Grey laughed. "Maybe we'll have to do this again in the spring. You folks keep coming in and I'll see what I can do."

He heard a woman comment, "They're so helpful here."

The man beside her said, "He actually delivered supplies to my place without charging me. You bet I'll be back."

Grey squeezed Kit's hand. "You've done a great job."

When she squeezed back, she said, "I had good material to work with."

With a grin and a flourish, Grey reached into the fishbowl to pull out the first winner. He read the name aloud and a couple to the side yelled, "That's us!"

Grey congratulated them, then pulled out another name.

A young man in jeans won the second weekend get-away and an older couple won the third. After giving the winners information and instructions for setting up dates for their weekends, Grey's phone vibrated on his belt. He pulled it off and checked it. It was Tanya. He could let it go, but what if it was important.

"Who is it?" Kit asked close to his ear.

"Tanya. I should take it."

"Go on into your office so you can hear. I'll keep everything going out here."

Although Grey was concerned about the phone call, he suddenly realized how well he and Kit worked together, how they managed to combine their ideas. He tenderly caressed cheek.

He answered the call and asked Tanya to give him a minute until he reached his office.

Threading his way through the store, he admired its new look. Once in his office, he said, "Okay. Now I can hear you. Do you need to talk to Dee?"

She quickly assured him, "No. But I need to meet with you. Are you free anytime today?"

He glanced at the customers outside and thought about the evening he'd planned. "Not really. Is it important?"

"I didn't want to tell you over the phone, but our government funding is being cut. I need to talk to you about how that will affect our clients. You might want to consider other options for Deedee."

"Other options? Is it that bad?"

"That's why I need to see you."

Grey felt torn between his obligation to the store and his responsibility for Deedee. If Gus and Larry could handle the inside of the store for an hour, and Kit took care of the three ring circus out front...

"I'll be there in ten minutes."

After speaking with Gus, Grey found Kit again watching the artistry of Zac Whittaker. Taking her arm, he guided her to the side. "I have to run an errand, but I'll be back in an hour. Will you be okay here?"

"Everything's under control and going well. Is something wrong?"

He wasn't sure exactly what the outcome of the meeting would be. But there was no point borrowing trouble. "No." He patted her hand and kissed her, unmindful of anyone who might care to watch.

When he lifted his head, he glided his thumb along her chin. "I'll be back before you know it."

***

After Tanya opened the door to Grey, she led him down the hall to her office. He sat across from the silver-haired, middle aged woman, remembering his first impression of her had been correct—she was kind and compassionate and cared about anyone she took into her care. Now, she gazed at him with a concerned expression.

"You're not closing the home, are you?" That's what he'd worried about most on his drive to Meadeville.

"No. Our clients come from families in all walks of life. We have a good reputation and have always had a waiting list. What I am concerned about are the clients who are here now who might not be able to stay because of financial considerations. In a way, we're like a private boarding school. And now, with the funding cut, the families will have to carry the burden of that expense."

"How much are we talking about?"

She pushed a computer printout toward him, but he swept down the list of itemized expenses to the bottom line. Immediately, he realized his plans for the future would have to change.

***

Kit stood outside of Corey's Hardware and watched Grey set the new security system. The parking lot was now empty, all the customers and hoopla finished for the day. Someone from Deedee's residence had picked her up late in the afternoon. After closing, Kit had cleaned up outside while Grey checked the receipts. The day had been a rousing success.

Yet Grey didn't appear as ecstatic as she'd hoped. In fact, since he'd returned from his errand, he'd seemed preoccupied.

Even now...

"Are you ready to celebrate?" she asked as he pocketed the key.

"Kit, I really have to go over the books tonight to figure out where I stand."

"But I thought profits were increasing and our strategy is working."

"I have to make sure."

"So...you don't want to come over tonight?"

He stroked her cheek and playfully flicked her earring. "Not tonight. I'll call you."

Why did this sound like an end rather than a beginning? She'd done her best for Grey and succeeded. But there was a look in his eyes, a distance, that hadn't been there this morning. Now that she had done her job, was he finished with her?

She remembered their lovemaking, their kisses, the intimacies she'd never experienced with anyone else.

Was Grey the man she thought he was? Or had he enjoyed the thrill of the chase and now that he'd caught her, the excitement had vanished?

With a smile that took every ounce of self-possession, she said, "Sure. Call me. Or I'll call you."

In the glare of the storefront's light, she saw the shadow pass through Grey's eyes. He didn't want her to call him.

Again reaching for composure she didn't feel, she said, "Goodnight then." As she walked to her car, she pressed the remote to unlock her doors. She'd unlocked her heart and now...?

She felt Grey's gaze on her as she climbed into the driver's seat. But he didn't come after her. He didn't even come to her window to say good-bye.

He let her drive away.

***

Thunder grumbled and lightning flashed Sunday evening as Kit flicked off her television and pet Keats who was sitting beside her on the sofa.

"Should I call him?" Kit asked the cat.

Keats yawned.

"You're not much help," Kit muttered, staring at the phone. "Maybe I overreacted last night. Maybe Grey really did have work to do..."

A crack of thunder shattered the silence.

"You're not supposed to use a landline when it's storming. And I probably wouldn't have good cell phone reception."

Keats's tail thumped against her knee.

A static-filled call or the possibility of being struck by lightning. "One call won't be dangerous. And I don't want to talk through crackles. I have to find out what's going on." She lifted the cordless phone from its base on her end table.

When she jabbed Grey's number, she held her breath. What would she say when he answered? He hadn't called. She probably should wait until he did.

But she wasn't a woman who liked to wait.

One ring, two rings, three rings. Surprised when his answering machine didn't click on, she counted at least ten more rings. But there was no answer at his home. She tried his cell phone. It went straight to voicemail. What message could she leave? Should she simply ask the question–are we still a couple?

Could he be with Deedee?

Kit placed the phone back on its base and felt tears prick her eyes.

Something was definitely wrong.

***

Interested in the floor plan of the house that Eric had thought was perfect for his family, Kit followed Maggie up the winding staircase. Running her hand over the beautifully-grained wooden banister, she

asked her sister, "So you're really going to buy this?"

"We submitted a contract and it was accepted. We already had one couple come by twice to look at our house. Eric and the real estate agent don't think it will take long to sell with the market picking up. We priced it right."

Maggie led Kit into the master bedroom. It was huge, with enough space for a bedroom suite and a sitting area with a fireplace. The walls were panted a soft peach. Kit peeked into an adjoining bathroom with a whirlpool tub big enough for two.

"This is beautiful. Eric has good taste. How do you feel now about moving?"

"When I saw the house, I realized why Eric thought it was just right for us. I'd never even considered something this big. I'm still used to watching pennies. But we are cramped at the other house and Eric doesn't even have a room for an office. Here he will in the downstairs study."

"What about your office and work area?"

"There's a game room that the previous owner added on. It will be perfect for me. I'll show you when we go back downstairs. I want to show you something else first."

Kit followed Maggie down the hall into a smaller bedroom. It only took a glance at the pink and blue wallpaper to realize this was the nursery. "I don't think this is the spare bedroom."

Maggie's smile was tremulous. "No. In fact, in April we'll be using it."

"You're pregnant?" Kit hugged her sister. "That's wonderful! Isn't it?"

"Yes. I suspected, but wasn't sure. I found out this morning."

"Does Eric know?"

"Oh, yes. I stopped in at his office. I think he's going to be overprotective."

Kit laughed. "Let me guess. He didn't want to let you out of his sight."

"Exactly. But I told him he couldn't hold my hand and chauffeur me for nine months. He strongly disagreed. I'm going to have to set limits or he'll pamper me to death."

"How did you get away?"

Maggie winked. "I promised him a romantic evening for two tonight." Watching her sister's expression, she asked, "How are you and Grey doing?"

"I'm not sure."

"You love him, don't you?"

"Yes. I'm ready to take the risk and believe in love and a future with Grey. But I'm not sure how he feels. After I saw Trent, we seemed to be on the right track. But then Saturday...I thought after the success of the promotional day we'd celebrate. But Grey got a phone call and left for a while and when he came back, he was different. Distracted."

"He wouldn't tell you what was wrong?"

"No. And then when we closed the store, he said he had to work on the books for a while. And he didn't call yesterday. I tried calling him, but he wasn't there. Something's wrong. Maybe he still thinks I can't accept Deedee. Maybe he's not even interested in a future. Maybe the challenge of the chase is over and now he's not interested. Have I been a fool again?"

"Grey's not that type of man."

Kit sighed. "You and Eric think that. I'm not sure what to think."

"You know Grey. He believes in family and loyalty and the basic values you and I believe in."

"So then what's wrong?" Kit asked, exasperated.

"Give him time. He'll tell you."

"You know, Sis, I don't like caring this much. All day yesterday I worried about him. I worried about us. And last night when I couldn't get hold of him..." She shook her head. "I care too much. It scares me."

"Love is scary. We both know that. But I can tell you one thing. When you love the right man, the happiness is far greater than the fear."

Kit was.

***

Kit was so happy for her sister. And she had to admit she was envious, too. She wanted a happily-ever-after like Maggie had. What were the chances? Was she just dreaming?

She'd just let herself into her apartment and switched on the fan when her cell phone beeped. She swiped it from her purse and couldn't help smiling. It was Grey!

"Hi! I've been worried about you. Is everything okay?"

His hesitation was enough to tell her everything was not okay. Then he confirmed her conclusion by saying, "Kit, we have to talk. Will you be there around seven?"

"Sure, I can be here. But can't you tell me?"

"I'd rather talk about this in person. I'll be there at seven."

Kit's heart pounded. She'd find out what was wrong in less than an hour. All she had to do was keep her fears in check.

That's all she had to do.

***

When Grey rapped on her back door, Kit was loading dishes into the dishwasher. She looked up and their eyes met. He opened the door and approached her slowly. She'd missed him and she wanted to feel his arms around her.

When he bent his head to kiss her, she lifted her lips to his and anticipated the magic that usually overwhelmed her. Grey's tongue swept her mouth, and he pressed her into him so they could both feel the strength of their desire, but then he broke away.

With a kiss like that, everything had to be all right, didn't it?

She saw Grey was breathing raggedly, too, but he didn't reach for her again. He backed off and ran his hand across his forehead. "Let's talk."

Fear curled around Kit's heart and she told herself stay calm. But her heart kept its up insistently fast rate, ignoring her command. She was surprised to find she couldn't even ask him what he wanted to talk about because she couldn't find her voice.

"I've made some decisions about us and about the store. I thought I could keep the store, marry you, and not jeopardize Deedee's future, but that's impossible now."

She tried to absorb everything he was saying one statement at a time. Her heart took wings at the word "marry" until the "but" registered, and she waited for the ax to fall.

"Funding at Deedee's home is being cut. Expenses there are going to double. I know what you've been through with Higgins, and I won't ask you to take on another financial burden. Red Bucket has upped their offer. I can't afford not to consider it seriously. So, I've decided to sell the store."

After a moment, when her voice seemed frozen in her throat, Kit felt the fire of anger surging through her. Her astonishment and fear melted away, leaving her with a feeling of betrayal and fury she hadn't experienced even with Trent Higgins.

Taking a deep breath, she faced Grey squarely. "When did Red Bucket up their offer?"

His jaw tensed. "Last week."

He'd kept this from her. Her stomach clenched. "Why didn't you tell me?"

"Because there was nothing to tell."

Her heart hurt, and tears burned in her eyes. All she could think about were Trent Higgins's secrets and the lies he'd told. "I had a right to know, Grey. My time and effort are involved in the success of your store, too. Did you think I'd stop working on the special promotion if I knew?"

With a frustrated frown, he said, "Of course not. Understand my position, Kit. I had to think about

more than my future. I had to think about Deedee's."

"I thought we were close enough to discuss it. I thought we were becoming a couple."

"We are a couple."

"No, we're not. After letting me stew for two days, after letting me worry about the hundred reasons why you pulled away, you walk in here and tell me I've put weeks of thinking and planning and energy into a store you're now going to sell. Selling Corey's Hardware is your decision to make. But the reason you're selling it is so you can marry me? Did I hear that in there somewhere?"

"I don't know why you're so upset. I'm doing this for us!"

"That's the problem, Grey. You don't understand why I'm upset. You kept Red Bucket's offer from me, then you made a decision that involved me."

"I didn't keep it from you. It wasn't important. I wasn't going to consider it. Not until Tanya called and needed to talk to me about the cut in funding."

"Is that where you disappeared to on Saturday?"

"Yes," he shot back.

"You didn't tell me about that, either!"

He looked ready to shake her. In an even tone, he returned, "I'm telling you now."

"After. You're telling me after the fact. After you made your decisions. Decisions, I might add, that could affect my life. I can't believe you did this, Grey. I can't believe you didn't trust me enough to confide in me. You of all people know what I went through with Trent. The financial burden was the least of it."

"I know he hurt you, Kit—"

"Not as much as you have. I opened my heart to you. I've been as honest as I know how to be. I can't believe I chose another man who wants to keep things from me—"

He took her by the shoulders. "Dammit, Kit, don't you put me in the same category as Higgins."

She pulled away and backed up until the refrigerator would let her go no further. "You asked me to trust you and I did. Because I deluded myself into thinking you knew how to respect a woman and treat her like an equal."

He clenched his hands at his sides. "I do respect you and see you as an equal."

"Really? You made the decision we'd get married without, I might add, even mentioning it to me. You decided to sell Corey's hardware. You decided I wouldn't want to help with Deedee's expenses. And then you say you're treating me as an equal?"

"Kit, I'm doing what's best for everybody."

"You think it's best to sell the store your dad loved and you've fought for since he died? You think it's best that marrying me fits right in with financial decisions you make? That makes me feel...sad. I don't want to be a financial decision. I don't want our relationship to be determined by the next crisis."

"You're blowing this all out of proportion. If you look at the situation objectively—"

"I don't love objectively. But then you haven't mentioned love. Maybe it isn't important to you, but love is important to me—more important than finances. If you believed in our future, in me, in us, you'd know I wouldn't care about helping to pay Deedee's expenses. You'd know I'd want you to keep a store you've given your adult life to. You'd know I wouldn't care if we had to struggle as long as we did it together. You accused me of not trusting you. I think you're the one who can't trust. And if you can't give me your trust, if love and sharing isn't important in our relationship, then marriage is out of the question."

Behind the anger, Grey could see the hurt glistening in Kit's eyes. He could hear it trembling in her voice. She gave the impression she had a strong, tough facade, but inside she was soft, and vulnerable. He'd miscalculated. He'd bungled badly. And he might have done their future irreparable harm. He wanted nothing more than to hold Kit in his arms and assure her he did love her. He should have started with that. He should have asked her to marry him on Saturday night no matter what else was happening.

She turned away from him, her shoulders rigid. "You'd better go," she said, building a palpable wall

around herself. He could feel it growing thicker and higher the longer he stood there.

"Kit..." When he reached for her, she stiffened.

Maybe they both needed a little time and space. Maybe if he backed off now, she'd realize he'd never meant to hurt her.

He walked to the door, knowing he'd be back. And somehow he'd convince her their future was worth fighting for.

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Deedee threw the tinfoil ball across her room and Star chased after it. Grey didn't get the usual pleasure he experienced as he watched his sister giggle and enjoy herself. He knew he was too preoccupied. He knew he was too frustrated to get pleasure out of anything. He'd called Kit at least ten times without success. Her voicemail took her messages. At ten last night, he knew damn well she was monitoring each and every message. He couldn't bring himself to tell her he loved her on a computer chip! He had to do it in person...face to face...heart to heart. Figuring time would help, he'd stayed away for four days. But now he wondered about that time. Maybe it had done more harm than good. Obviously he didn't know how women thought. He didn't know how Kit was feeling right now. As upset as he was? As in love? Was that the real problem–his pride? He didn't want to be rejected again so he'd walked away?

His frustration mounting, he got up from Deedee's bed and went to her desk. Large sheets of drawing paper lay scattered across it. The top one in pencil, depicted Star chasing a butterfly. It was quite good. The drawing underneath caught his attention immediately. Colored in chalks, a garden of zinnias and snapdragons summoned half a dozen butterflies. Grey recognized the greenery behind the vibrant flowers, the flat rocks in the midst of the garden. And his heart ached.

"What's the matter, Grey?"

If he was honest with Deedee, he'd find out how she felt, too. Though he knew no matter what Deedee thought, he was going to marry Kit. They'd work it all out somehow.

Still holding his sister's drawing in his hand, he turned to her. "Kit and I had a...disagreement."

"She's mad at you?"

"That's about it."

"But you're not mad at her?"

"She was right. I was wrong."

Deedee picked up Star and plopped the kitten in her lap. "Did you tell her?"

Was the solution as simple as that? "No, I didn't. Not yet. I'm trying to figure out a special way. How would you feel if Kit and I got married?"

Deedee stared at Star and tickled her under the chin. "I like Kit," she said softly. "And I think she likes me."

"I know she likes you."

"She's not like Susan."

"No, she's not."

"I guess it's okay if you get married. Can we still play catch?"

Grey crouched down on the floor next to Deedee. "Yes, we can still play catch, and go on picnics, and go to ball games. Being married to Kit will make everything better than it was before. The three of us will be a family."

"Not if she's mad at you."

He rose from the floor. "I guess I'll have to fix that." Lifting the drawing, he asked, "Can I give this to Kit? I think it might help."

Deedee thought about it for a moment. "Yep. Can I help wrap it?"

"You sure can. But more important, I'd like you to sign your name."

"Why?"

"Then Kit will know it's from you, too."

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Planting new bulbs for next spring was one of Kit's favorite gardening chores. But even the promise of ruby red and yellow tulips, and fragrant blue hyacinths couldn't cheer her up. Maggie had scolded her more than once for not answering Grey's calls. Truthfully, she was scared to answer them. This from a woman who'd vowed never to be afraid of anything. Exactly what was she afraid of?

He might say he didn't love her and marriage was just a convenience he'd thought would benefit them both.

He might say he wasn't interested any more.

He might say he loved her.

What then? What kind of relationship could they have if he made decisions for her? If he couldn't tell her how he felt? Each day that passed, Kit realized more and more how much she loved Grey and how afraid she was that he didn't love her the same way. But she also remembered what Grey had said to Maggie. Men like to feel that they're taking care of the people they love. Had he really seen the situation in that light?

Digging into the ground with the gardener's shovel, she scooped down a few inches then bored deeper. By the time she'd planted her third bulb, she was sweating. The end of August. Summer was almost over. And she and Grey...

Suddenly, she knew she was no longer alone. Glancing over her shoulder, she saw a long shadow. Before she had time to take another breath, Grey stood beside her. With her hands trembling so much she could hardly hold the shovel, she laid it on the grass.

His deep voice floated down to her. "You didn't answer my calls."

Pretending a bravado she didn't feel, she plucked the unplanted bulbs into her gardening basket and asked flippantly, "So you decided to come in person to see if my phones are working?"

"No. I came to give you something."

She had no choice then but to look at him. He held a flat box in his hand. It was wrapped in yellow paper and decorated with a red bow. Curious, she climbed to her feet. Grey kept his gaze on her, but she couldn't tell anything from his expression. He handed her the box.

Running her hand under the paper, Kit unwrapped the present. As she lifted out a folded-up piece of paper, Grey took the box and wrappings and laid them with her bulbs. Slowly, she unfolded the paper. She recognized her garden immediately, just as she noticed Deedee's name.

"You're like one of those butterflies—strong yet delicate, beautiful yet practical. You've brought me vibrant color, excitement, passion. I love you, Kit. I should have said that first before I said anything else the other night. I screwed up. Badly. I thought about everything you said and you were right. My only excuse is that I'm not used to sharing responsibility. But I promise, if you love me, too, and if you agree to marry me, I'll make a determined effort to remember you're a woman who wants to be a full partner. I promise we'll make our decisions together. Will you marry me?"

Grey looked as if he hadn't slept since their argument. His hair was disheveled as if he'd run his fingers through it recently. What she loved about Grey the most was his honesty and sincerity. And she knew deep in her heart it was real and dependable, not a figment of her imagination conjured up because she wanted to believe it was there. He was in the habit of protecting those he loved. She'd just have to show him she needed his love much more than she needed his protection.

Nothing in the world could have prevented her from asking, "When?"

He laughed joyously and pulled her into his arms.

The kiss was everything she'd ever experienced with Grey and more. It was tingles and escalating

excitement, fire and scorching passion, demand and teasing seduction. But now it was also love, commitment, and the promise of a lifetime together.

Caressing her back with long strokes, he splayed his fingers through her hair and kissed her as if they only had today, as if tomorrow might never come. She kissed him back with the same fervor, stroking his face, his neck, his shoulders, leaning into him, trying to get closer. Her body cried out for his touch, her heart sang of its love, her soul wanted union far greater than the physical.

Grey held her by the shoulders and with a frustrated groan pulled away. Leaning his forehead against hers, he said in a ragged voice, "I want to carry you inside and make love to you. But we have to straighten out a few matters first."

Her heart took a scared little leap, but then she gazed into the green depths of his eyes and knew they could solve anything with persistence, determination, and love. "What?"

"I'm not only asking you to share my life, but my burdens too."

"Deedee's not a burden."

He smiled and kissed her forehead. "I know. But her care could be. We have a couple of options." He straightened but linked his arms around her. "I can sell to Red Bucket, become their manager and make a nice salary, and keep Deedee at the home. I can keep Corey's Hardware and Deedee could live with us. Or...I can keep Corey's, hoping business keeps growing, let Deedee stay at the home, and ask you to help with expenses. I need your honest feelings on this. I want to do whatever is best for our marriage. So I guess I'm asking you to seriously consider the consequences of marrying me. All I can offer you is my love and support and the promise I'll love you always."

"That's what I want, Grey. Your love and support. And I vote for keeping Corey's and letting Deedee stay where she is. Of course, I'll help with her expenses. And after another year, we can reevaluate. We'll do whatever we have to do. If at any time Deedee wants to come live with us, we'll welcome her with open arms. We'll always consider what's best for her as well as what's best for us."

Grey held Kit close for a moment and stroked her hair. "Do you know how special you are?"

She tilted away and smiled. "I know how special you are and how much I love you."

The evening sun shed beams of light and warmth on them as they gazed into each other's eyes, communicating with their hearts. A slight fluttering nearby finally broke the intensity of their unspoken words.

An orange and black Monarch butterfly lighted on Grey's shoulder.

Kit asked softly, "Do you know what that means?"

"What does it mean?"

"That we'll be blessed with happiness and good fortune."

Grey smiled, bringing her into the curve of his arm without disturbing the butterfly. "I was blessed with happiness and good fortune the day you walked into my store."

Kit leaned her head against Grey's shoulder, accepting his strength and the promise of his love.

EPILOGUE

Grey carried a large white sheet cake onto his patio and set it on the redwood table. Eric stood beside Maggie's lawn chair as she cuddled their new son in her arms. In the yard, Deedee hit a croquet ball and watched it roll.

Kit crossed the threshold behind Grey, a coffee pot in her hand. "The christening went well. Michael couldn't have been a better baby."

Grey took the coffee pot from her and set it beside the cake. "I think his godmother was terrific. He never considered crying because you rocked him the entire time."

Grey watched an expression play across his wife's face as she glanced at Maggie and the baby. In the first nine months of their marriage, he and Kit had kept no secrets, told each other their concerns.

"What's wrong?" he asked softly.

"I wasn't going to say anything yet..."

"Spill it, kiddo," he prompted.

Kit got that soft and vulnerable look on her face, the look that made Grey want to take her in his arms, hold her, kiss her thoroughly, then lead her to bed. With an uncertain smile, she murmured, "Holding Michael feels so good. And when I was rocking him at the christening, I had this strong, strong feeling. I'd like one of our own."

Because of Kit's career, Grey hadn't brought up the subject of children. His love for his wife glowed in his heart as he responded, "So would I. But I thought maybe you needed more time. Your career is important to you."

"Yes, it is. And I'd like to keep involved with public relations. But I also want to have your baby. I think it would make life more...complete."

He put his arm around her and pulled her close, whispering in her ear, "Want to slip away and start now?"

She laughed and jabbed him in the ribs. Then her smile faded. "Can we afford it? I mean we have to think of the future. College..."

"The store's doing great thanks to your bright ideas. Customers just needed to know Corey's existed. And as long as we make personal service our trademark and keep expanding, I foresee a bright future. Your decorating center with paint and fabric samples was brilliant. The fabric shop sends customers to us, we send customers to them... More ideas like that and I'll have to V the t I hire more help."

"Deedee told me the gallery sold another of her paintings."

Because of Deedee's drawings, Kit had suggested she take art lessons. Within a month, she'd blossomed under her teacher's tutelage and the woman had found a gallery willing to show her work. Now working with oils and watercolors, she painted on a regular basis.

Grey chuckled. "She's becoming quite an entrepreneur. Not only is she selling her paintings, but she told me Maggie's going to pay her to help her at home."

"Maggie says Deedee has been a godsend the past few months. Now that the baby's here, she can use her help even more. Between the pet shop, and painting, and now helping Maggie, Deedee is almost working full time."

"She seems to love it."

"Because the work gives her independence she needs. We have to let her try her wings, Grey."

"And we have to try ours. I want to see you swollen with my child. If you're ready, so am I."

She gazed into his eyes saying solemnly, "I'm ready."

Deedee called to Grey and Kit. "Look at the butterflies."

As the weather had gotten warmer over the past few weeks, Kit and Grey had planted a garden with butterflies in mind. Now swallowtails dipped and hovered over the red and white impatiens. As the zinnias grew taller and the snapdragons and phlox filled out, more and more butterflies would be drawn to the area.

Kit and Grey strolled to the garden where Deedee watched the delicate creatures. Maggie and Eric followed.

Kit felt the comfort of her sister and brother-in-law by her side. As Deedee sidled closer and brushed Kit's elbow with a smile, Kit knew she'd found true happiness. The wings of love had brought Grey to her. She'd treasure the love and happiness they shared...always.

When Grey wrapped his arms around her, she treasured the love they'd found and looked forward to whatever the future brought...because they'd embrace it together.

"I love you," he murmured in her ear.

"I love you, too," she whispered back, looking forward to treasuring the moment and believing in the future.

From the Author:

Kit And Kisses, first published with Kensington Precious Gems, was a challenging romance to write. The hero and heroine face real-life responsibilities. To add an aspect of Paintington beauty and a little lightness, I created a butterfly garden to entrance the hero's sister. I have a butterfly garden of my own that brings me hours of enjoyment. Throughout all my books, I attempt to keep the emotion of my characters as the focus. My intention is always to touch my readers' hearts and urge them to believe in happily-ever-after. Since Kit And Kisses, I've gone on to write many more novels, making both the USA Today List and the Borders Group Bestseller List. Living in Pennsylvania with my college sweetheart and two cats, I spend most days writing, editing, cooking and gardening. I draw inspiration from music, the farm in my back yard, and my butterfly garden. Relationships have always fascinated me and I look forward to writing about them for a long time to come.